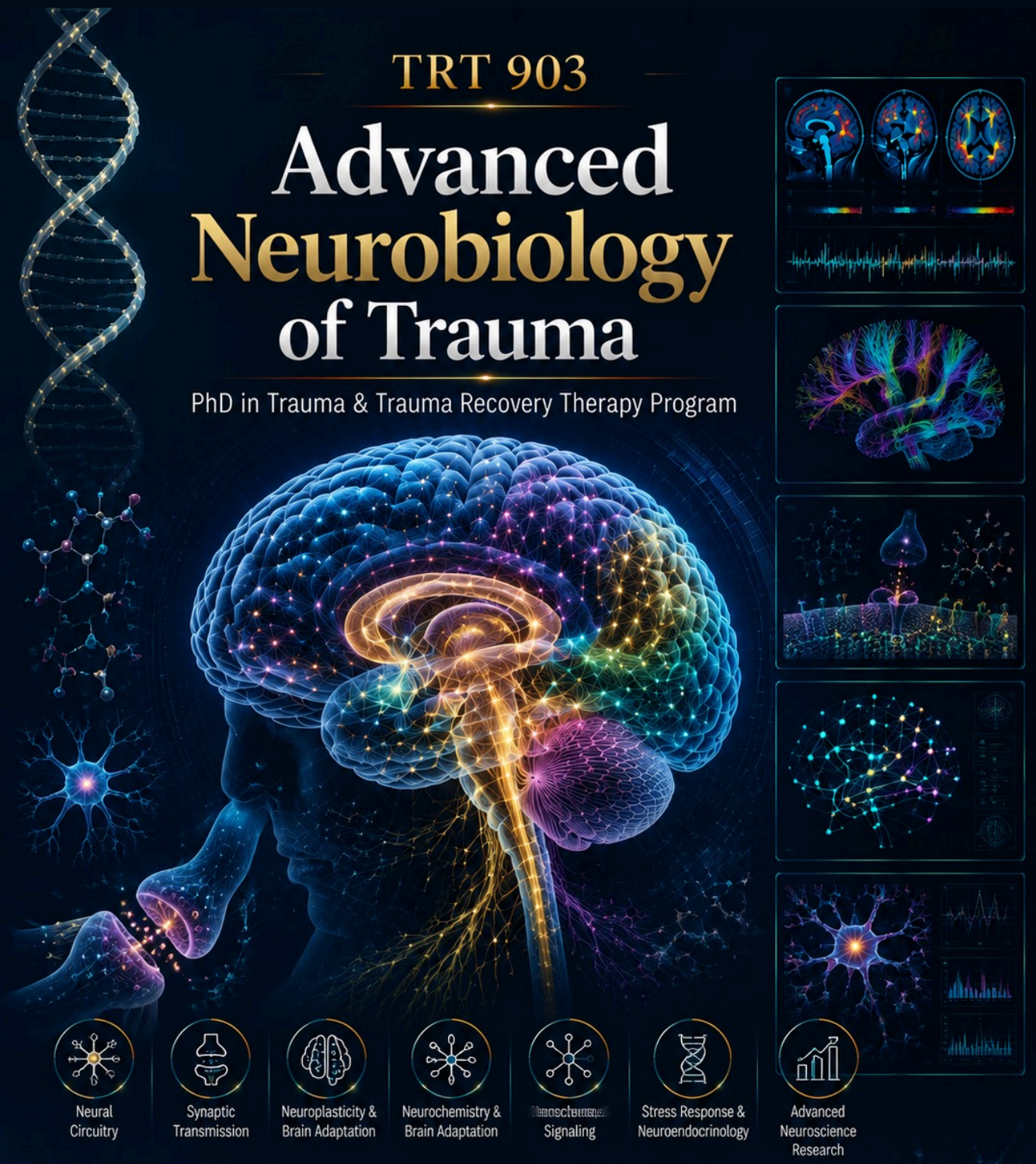
TRT 903

Advanced Neurobiology of Trauma

PhD in Trauma & Trauma Recovery Therapy Program



Neural Circuitry

Synaptic Transmission

Neuroplasticity & Brain Adaptation

Neurochemistry & Brain Adaptation

Signaling

Stress Response & Neuroendocrinology

Advanced Neuroscience Research

TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY
GLOBAL EXTENSION, USA

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Advanced Neurobiology of Trauma

A doctoral-level textbook

Corporate author TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY GLOBAL EXTENSION, USA

Course code: TRT 903

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This textbook does not replace professional training, supervised practice, medical assessment, current clinical guidance, applicable law, institutional protocols, or emergency care. Study of neuroscience does not confer competence or authority to diagnose, prescribe, interpret clinical imaging, conduct brain stimulation, or perform laboratory procedures outside an appropriately qualified and supervised role.

Blank fields in research and neuroimaging worksheets are intentional learner-completion spaces. They are not missing patient findings or research results. Complete them only for an authorised educational task using clearly identified, approved information; do not enter identifiable patient data without the necessary lawful and institutional safeguards.

Dedication

To students, researchers, clinicians, educators, patients, families, and communities whose questions advance the understanding of trauma, adaptation, treatment, and recovery.

Preface

Trauma neuroscience asks how experiences of threat, injury, loss, violence, and helplessness interact with the nervous system over time. No single brain region, hormone, or biological measure provides a complete answer. Understanding requires attention to cells and circuits, development, endocrine and immune regulation, learning and memory, relationships, health, culture, and social conditions.

This doctoral-level textbook connects biological explanation to methodological scrutiny and responsible professional action. Its

sequence moves from foundational concepts and neuroanatomy through cellular and molecular processes, learning, stress physiology, disorders, recovery, measurement, intervention, and research translation. Introductory explanations support access to advanced material without replacing the prior study and critical reading expected at doctoral level.

A recurring distinction is between what a study observes, how a finding is interpreted, and what decision it can justify. Group differences do not determine the condition or history of an individual. Biological language should clarify uncertainty rather than confer an appearance of certainty that the evidence does not support.

The book treats trauma neurobiology as one part of a broader account of human responses. It avoids reducing people to symptoms or measurements and connects scientific reasoning to ethical practice, cultural understanding, participant protection, and equitable access to services.

Acknowledgements

The intellectual foundations of this subject reflect the work of neuroscientists, psychologists, psychiatrists, neurologists, endocrinologists, immunologists, geneticists, imaging scientists, statisticians, qualitative researchers, clinicians, service users, carers, educators, public-health professionals, and research participants.

How to use this book

Begin with each chapter's objectives and identify the concepts, methods, and decisions that organise its argument. Relate technical terms to a clear definition, a level of analysis, and an observable measure. Use tables and figures to compare relationships and limitations rather than memorise labels in isolation.

For clinical and service applications, discuss assessment, treatment, risk, and neurotechnology within appropriate supervision and current professional guidance. For research tasks, treat proposed questions as starting points: undertake a structured literature review, define the population and constructs, justify each measure, and obtain the required scientific and ethical review before developing a protocol.

Teaching cases illustrate reasoning; they do not establish treatment effectiveness or provide sufficient information for independent

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diagnosis. Where an exercise supplies no data, do not invent results. State which information is available, what is missing, and what conclusion is defensible.

Study sequence

Chapters 1–3 establish foundations, functional anatomy, and lifespan development. Chapters 4–7 examine cells, molecules, neurotransmission, plasticity, learning, and memory. Chapters 8–11 address stress physiology, genetics, threat learning, emotion regulation, interoception, and dissociation.

Chapters 12–16 consider neuroimmunology, neuroimaging, sleep and circadian regulation, developmental trauma, and systemic and structural trauma. Chapters 17–20 address assessment and differential diagnosis, therapeutic translation, research methods and evidence appraisal, and professional integration.

A twenty-week schedule can assign one chapter each week. A shorter semester may group related chapters into teaching blocks while preserving prerequisite knowledge. Reading should be combined with terminology review, figure or table interpretation, critical appraisal, case discussion, and a research activity. Laboratory observation, software training, and supervised clinical discussion require separate arrangements where they form part of the programme.

About this edition

The corporate author and copyright owner of this edition is TRIUNE BIBLICAL UNIVERSITY GLOBAL EXTENSION, USA (© 2026). The work is positioned at doctoral level as TRT 903; no credit value is assigned.

This edition is the product of a comprehensive editorial reconstruction. The source manuscript contained extensive repeated template passages, duplicated and non-locating reference lists, devotional inserts, and unresolved placeholders. In preparing this edition, repeated material was synthesised, devotional content unrelated to the scientific subject was removed, and the chapters were rewritten in concise, sourced form. Every citation in Chapters 1–20 was checked against a published record — a publisher or journal page, PubMed, or the issuing agency — before inclusion; no statistics, quotations, or bibliographic details were invented, and claims that could not be verified were deleted or qualified rather than retained. Cases are composite teaching examples and describe no real person.

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The 187 glossary entries carry term-specific definitions reviewed against standard neuroscience usage; an editorial register recording the verification status of each entry accompanies this edition. The acronyms list, appendices, research resources, teaching protocols, professional standards, and further-reading guide were newly compiled for classroom use and reproduce no third-party instruments or protocols. The learner worksheets are intentionally blank completion tools and contain no patient data.

This edition has not undergone independent external peer review or accreditation, and no ISBN has been assigned. Institutions should satisfy themselves as to its suitability for their programmes. Nothing in this book replaces supervised professional training, current clinical guidance, or local law and institutional policy.

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Contents

Chapter 1. Foundations and Historical Development of Trauma Neurobiology 1

Chapter 2. Functional Neuroanatomy of Threat, Memory, and Regulation 23

Chapter 3. Brain Development Across the Lifespan and Developmental Timing of Trauma 53

Chapter 4. Cellular Neuroscience: Neurons, Glia, Myelin, and Neural Tissue Responses 64

Chapter 5. Molecular Neuroscience and Synaptic Transmission in Traumatic Stress 73

Chapter 6. Neurotransmitters, Neuromodulators, and Neuroendocrine Signalling 82

Chapter 7. Neuroplasticity, Learning, Memory, and Reconsolidation 92

Chapter 8. Stress Physiology: HPA Axis, Autonomic Regulation, and Allostasis 102

Chapter 9. Genetics, Epigenetics, and Gene–Environment Interplay 112

Chapter 10. Threat Learning, Fear Conditioning, and Traumatic Memory 122

Chapter 11. Emotion Regulation, Interoception, and Dissociation 132

Chapter 12. Neuroimmunology and Inflammation 141

Chapter 13. Neuroimaging: Methods, Findings, and Limits 150

Chapter 14. Sleep, Circadian Rhythms, and Trauma 159

Chapter 15. Developmental Trauma and Adverse Childhood Experiences 168

Chapter 16. Systemic and Structural Trauma 178

Chapter 17. Assessment and Differential Diagnosis 187

Chapter 18. Therapeutic Translation: From Mechanism to Intervention 196

Chapter 19. Research Methods and Evidence Appraisal 205

Chapter 20. Integration, Professional Practice, and Future Directions 214

Back matter

Glossary 223
Acronyms and abbreviations 241
Appendix A. Critical appraisal template 243
Appendix B. Trauma-informed assessment checklist 244
Appendix C. Research protocol outline 245
Appendix D. Statistical and methodological terms 246
Research resources 247
Laboratory and classroom teaching protocols 248
Professional standards and scope of practice 250
Further reading 251
Learner worksheets 253
References 262

Foundations and Historical Development of Trauma Neurobiology

Chapter 1

Central question. How did the study of trauma become a neurobiological discipline, and what standards of evidence allow biological findings to inform explanation, treatment and policy without claiming more than the data support?

In this chapter

Learning objectives 3
Introduction 3
1.1 Scope of neuroscience 4
1.1.1 Levels of explanation 4
1.1.2 Observation, mechanism, and inference 6
1.2 Meaning of trauma in biological research 6
1.2.1 Exposure is not an outcome 6
1.2.2 Timing and development 7
1.2.3 Foundational distinctions 7
1.3 History of stress science 8
1.3.1 Internal regulation and emergency responses 8
1.3.2 Selye and subsequent revisions 8
1.4 Early lesion and behavioural studies 9
1.5 Rise of psychophysiology 10
1.6 Development of neuroendocrinology 10
1.7 Growth of brain imaging 11
1.8 Translation from laboratory to clinic 12
1.8.1 Measurement and research design 12
1.8.2 Clinical formulation and responsible action 13
1.8.3 Communication and professional boundaries 15
1.9 Limits of biological reductionism 16

1.9.1 The person is not the measurement 16
1.9.2 Culture, international relevance, and fairness 16
1.9.3 Ethics and data governance 16
1.10 Integrative contemporary models 17
1.10.1 Linking explanation to context 17
1.10.2 Research development and critical appraisal 18
1.11 Teaching cases and worked applications 18
1.11.1 Disaster response across several communities 18
1.11.2 Recovery after a road traffic collision in Nigeria 19
1.11.3 Worked appraisal: does an association establish causation? 19
1.11.4 Explaining a finding to a professional audience 20
1.12 Summary 20
Review and discussion questions 20
Practical and research assignments 21
Literature-search activities 22
References 22

Learning objectives

After studying this chapter, readers should be able to:

- Distinguish trauma exposure, observed responses, explanatory mechanisms, and clinical interpretations.
- Relate cellular, circuit, endocrine, immune, cognitive, developmental, and social levels of analysis without treating them as interchangeable.
- Explain how research design, measurement, timing, and context constrain the interpretation of biological findings.
- Evaluate a proposed application in relation to safety, professional competence, uncertainty, cultural relevance, and resources.
- Critically appraise a study and formulate a defensible research question with appropriate ethical safeguards.

Introduction

Trauma neurobiology examines how experiences of threat and adversity relate to nervous-system structure, signalling, bodily regulation, behaviour, and recovery. Its subject cannot be reduced to a single brain region, hormone, or test result. Explanation requires attention to the processes being measured, the circumstances in which they occur, and their implications for functioning.

Trauma exposure does not identify a uniform biological state. People may respond differently to apparently similar events, and similar difficulties may arise through different pathways. Neurobiological explanations should therefore clarify processes and probabilities rather than assign a fixed identity to a person. Immediate responses during danger must also be distinguished from difficulties that persist after danger has passed.

The chapter establishes a framework for reading the rest of the book: specify the question, identify the relevant level of analysis, examine the evidence, consider alternative explanations, and assess the consequences of acting on the interpretation. Figure 1.1 locates the ten main topics within that framework. The historical discussion explains how research questions changed as investigators moved from regulation and lesion observations to physiological measurement, endocrine assays, and imaging. These developments should be evaluated through their methods and limits rather than treated as a simple accumulation of increasingly definitive tests.

Figure 1.1. Chapter topics and interpretative framework



Boxes identify the ten main topics in the source outline; their placement does not imply anatomy or causation. Original editorial schematic derived from the supplied chapter; no empirical data are plotted.

1.1 Scope of neuroscience

1.1.1 Levels of explanation

A neurobiological claim may concern ion flow across a membrane, activity within a local circuit, communication among distributed networks, endocrine feedback, immune signalling, or behaviour during a task. These levels interact, but evidence at one level does not automatically establish what has happened at another. A change in a measured biological characteristic is not, by itself, a complete account of a person's experience or functioning.

The first task is to identify the units and relationships relevant to the question. An explanation should distinguish the exposure, the person's perception and appraisal, bodily responses, memory, action, and subsequent adaptation. This sequence is an analytical framework, not a

claim that every response follows a single fixed pathway. Feedback and alternative routes remain important.

Statements such as “trauma changes the brain” are too imprecise to carry much explanatory weight unless they specify what was measured. Readers should ask which tissue or process is involved, when measurement occurred, the direction and magnitude of the reported difference, whether it may change over time, and what it means for functioning. Table 1.1 separates the principal levels of inquiry and their interpretative limits.

Table 1.1. Levels of analysis, methods, and interpretative limits

Level	Question	Evidence or method	Interpretative limit
Cellular and molecular	Which cellular or molecular processes are being examined?	Cell culture, molecular assays, genetics, animal models	Mechanistic evidence requires caution when applied to an individual.
Circuit and systems	How are the relevant processes organised across circuits and systems?	Imaging, electrophysiology, lesion evidence, task performance	Regional activation is not a diagnosis.
Endocrine and immune	How are measured responses related to bodily regulation?	Hormone and immune assays; repeated sampling	Timing, health, medication, sleep, and assay variation affect results.
Behaviour and function	How are observed responses related to daily functioning?	Interviews, questionnaires, behavioural tasks, records	Symptom measures require interpretation alongside function and meaning.
Social context and implementation	How does application vary across settings?	Qualitative and mixed-methods research; implementation and policy evaluation	Resources, culture, law, and unequal access shape application.

Adapted editorially from original PDF pages 130–131. Questions have been clarified without adding measurements or findings; author approval is required. No single row provides a complete explanation.

1.1.2 Observation, mechanism, and inference

An observation describes what was measured. A mechanistic explanation proposes how a process occurs. Researchers may identify a sequence of events, examine intermediate variables, and test whether changing one component affects another. Showing that two observations occur together does not establish such a sequence.

Direct experimental manipulation is often unethical or impracticable in human trauma research. Investigators therefore combine longitudinal observation, experimental learning tasks, physiological recording, imaging, molecular assays, and cautiously interpreted animal models. Each method addresses part of a question. Converging findings can strengthen an explanation, but disagreement between methods should remain visible rather than be dismissed for the sake of a simple narrative.

A defensible account distinguishes established findings, plausible interpretations, and speculative extensions. It also allows for feedback: stress responses can affect attention and memory, while memory and appraisal can influence later responses. The task is to explain these relationships with appropriate evidence, not merely to name additional structures or molecules.

1.2 Meaning of trauma in biological research

1.2.1 Exposure is not an outcome

The manuscript uses trauma to refer to an exposure or experience that may be followed by different responses. Exposure, symptoms, biological measurements, functional impairment, and diagnosis must not be treated as equivalent. A reported event does not establish a particular biological pattern, and a biological difference does not prove that a particular event occurred.

Research should state how exposure and outcomes were defined, how information was obtained, and when it was collected. Interviews, records, behavioural tasks, physiological recordings, imaging, and molecular assays provide different kinds of information. Their agreement cannot be assumed, and differences between studies may reflect different operational definitions rather than incompatible findings.

Clinical interpretation requires an assessment of the person rather than an inference from one research measure. Relevant information includes present safety, symptoms, physical health, medication, pain, sleep, substance use, previous exposure, relationships, resources, cultural

meaning, and goals. Neuroscience may contribute to that account; it does not replace medical examination, safeguarding, diagnosis, or collaborative assessment.

1.2.2 Timing and development

Time changes the meaning of biological evidence. Responses that support survival during immediate danger may interfere with sleep, concentration, relationships, or health when they persist in other circumstances. Interpretation should distinguish acute, recurrent, chronic, delayed, and improving patterns rather than assume that a measured difference represents permanent damage.

Developmental stage also matters. Prenatal life, childhood, adolescence, adulthood, and later life differ in maturation, experience, bodily regulation, and social dependence. Research should therefore document the timing, duration, and repetition of exposure, recovery intervals, prior experiences, protective relationships, and current conditions. These factors help explain why the same exposure may be associated with different outcomes and why similar outcomes may have different histories.

1.2.3 Foundational distinctions

Homeostasis concerns regulation that maintains physiological variables within viable ranges. Stability is actively maintained; it does not mean that a living system is static. **Allostasis** emphasises adjustments in regulation as conditions and demands change. These concepts overlap, and the usefulness of treating them as distinct explanatory frameworks has been debated (Goldstein & Kopin, 2007; Godoy et al., 2018).

Adaptation, in this discussion, denotes physiological or behavioural adjustments through which an organism responds to changing demands. An adjustment that is useful in one setting need not remain useful under persistent or different demands. **Allostatic load** concerns the cumulative burden associated with sustained or repeated regulatory demands; it should not be used as an interchangeable label for a stressful event, a symptom score, or a diagnosis (Goldstein & Kopin, 2007; Godoy et al., 2018).

A **biomarker** is a measured characteristic used to indicate a biological process or a biological response to an exposure or intervention. Biomarkers can be molecular, histological, imaging-based, or physiological. Their intended use must be specified. A biomarker is not the same as a measure of how a person feels or functions, and a measured association alone does not establish diagnostic usefulness (U.S. Food and Drug Administration, n.d.).

A **mechanism** explains how a process occurs; a **correlation** describes an association. **Causal inference** concerns whether a change in one factor contributes to a change in another, rather than merely accompanying it. **Translation** connects research evidence to a defined application and tests whether that application is justified. These working distinctions organise the chapter's methodological discussion; they are not competing diagnoses or distinct biological substances.

1.3 History of stress science

1.3.1 Internal regulation and emergency responses

Claude Bernard's account of the internal environment provided an important foundation for physiological explanations of regulation. Walter Cannon developed the concept of homeostasis and examined coordinated responses to threats. His work linked sympathetic and adrenal responses to the mobilisation of the organism for action, helping establish the framework commonly described as fight or flight. The intellectual shift was from considering organs in isolation towards asking how coordinated physiological adjustments preserve function under changing conditions (Goldstein & Kopin, 2007; Godoy et al., 2018).

Homeostasis did not imply immobility. Its explanatory value lay in showing how stability depends on compensatory processes. A controlled variable can be maintained within a viable range while the activity of the mechanisms regulating it changes. This distinction remains essential when interpreting a hormone or autonomic measure: a changed effector signal does not necessarily mean that regulation has failed (Goldstein & Kopin, 2007).

1.3.2 Selye and subsequent revisions

Hans Selye's 1936 work helped establish a biological research programme concerned with recurring responses to different harmful agents. His general adaptation syndrome described alarm, resistance, and exhaustion. The framework gave prominence to coordinated bodily responses and the potential consequences of sustained demands, but its claim to nonspecificity should be understood as a historical proposition rather than an assumption that every stressor produces the same response in every person (Godoy et al., 2018; Goldstein & Kopin, 2007).

Subsequent systems accounts emphasise patterned responses that depend on the challenge, the organism's interpretation, and its history. Allostasis extends the discussion to changing regulatory demands and anticipatory adjustments, while allostatic load directs attention to cumulative burden. Neither term removes the need to identify the

particular process and time scale under investigation. Historical models are most useful when they generate testable questions, not when their vocabulary substitutes for measurement (Goldstein & Kopin, 2007; Godoy et al., 2018).

The implications for trauma research are methodological as well as conceptual. A study must distinguish the event, the measured response, and its interpretation. The existence of a stress response does not establish a psychiatric disorder, while the absence of a proposed laboratory pattern does not invalidate a person's experience. General stress physiology and the neurobiology of a particular disorder are related fields, not identical explanatory systems.

1.4 Early lesion and behavioural studies

Lesion research contributes to neuroscience by examining function after damage or removal of tissue. Scoville and Milner's 1957 report of memory impairment following bilateral medial temporal surgery is a foundational example. Their observations linked extensive damage involving the hippocampal region to persistent difficulty retaining recent experience. The report also distinguished memory impairment from a uniform loss of general intellectual functioning (Scoville & Milner, 1957).

The significance of this work lies partly in the specificity of the question: which aspects of memory were affected, and how did the pattern relate to the extent of the lesion? It did not demonstrate that memory resided in one isolated point or that all forms of memory were lost. The original authors explicitly considered uncertainty about the contribution of neighbouring structures because the operations did not isolate the hippocampus from all adjacent tissue. Anatomy, behavioural testing, and limits of the intervention therefore had to be interpreted together (Scoville & Milner, 1957).

For trauma neurobiology, this history illustrates how evidence about learning and memory can inform a mechanistic framework without directly establishing the cause of a clinical condition. Findings from neurosurgical lesions are not observations of trauma exposure or PTSD. Applying them to traumatic memory requires additional evidence appropriate to the population and question. Likewise, experimental tasks may isolate a learning process without reproducing the personal and social circumstances of an overwhelming event.

The methodological lesson is not that lesion findings are uninformative, but that their explanatory reach must be specified. Readers should identify the affected tissue, the measured function, the comparison, and

plausible alternative interpretations before extending a finding to a broader theory of memory or behaviour.

1.5 Rise of psychophysiology

Psychophysiological research connects psychological tasks or experiences with recorded bodily responses. In trauma research, this approach made it possible to investigate responding to trauma-related cues rather than rely only on retrospective descriptions. Pitman and colleagues' 2012 review identified heart-rate, skin-conductance, and facial electromyographic responses during trauma-related imagery and cue exposure as important parts of the biological PTSD literature. These measures concern different aspects of responding and should not be treated as interchangeable indicators (Pitman et al., 2012).

The development of this approach shifted the question from whether a person reports distress to how recorded responses vary with cues, experimental conditions, and comparison groups. Its value is analytical: a defined task and recording method make a proposed relationship open to observation and criticism. It does not follow that physiological reactivity is a unique signature of a particular event or a stand-alone diagnostic test. A response observed under one laboratory condition cannot simply be generalised to every setting or every individual with the same diagnosis (Pitman et al., 2012).

Interpretation requires attention to what the measure represents, the recording conditions, timing, health, medication, and alternative influences. Comparison with interviews, behavioural tasks, or imaging needs an explicit rationale. Concordance should be demonstrated rather than assumed. Psychophysiology therefore complements other methods: it adds measurable information while leaving the researcher responsible for showing what conclusions the task and comparison can support.

1.6 Development of neuroendocrinology

Neuroendocrinology developed through work on communication between the nervous and endocrine systems and through advances that made very small quantities of hormones measurable. The 1977 Nobel account highlights two complementary achievements: Roger Guillemin and Andrew Schally's work on hypothalamic releasing hormones, and Rosalyn Yalow's development of radioimmunoassay with Solomon Berson. Identifying regulatory substances and measuring them were distinct but mutually important steps (Karolinska Institutet, 1977).

The same account records the establishment of the structure of thyrotropin-releasing factor in 1969. This is an example of how a proposed regulatory influence became a chemically characterised signal. Sensitive assays also changed the kinds of questions that could be asked about hormone secretion and disease. These developments supported a research programme in which neural regulation could be investigated through defined endocrine signals rather than inferred only from outward behaviour (Karolinska Institutet, 1977).

Stress research draws on the hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal axis alongside sympathetic and other regulatory processes. The importance of endocrine regulation does not imply that every form of traumatic stress involves the same hormonal pattern. Pitman and colleagues specifically cautioned that a simple model of chronically increased hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal activity does not characterise PTSD. General models of stress must therefore be tested rather than transferred uncritically to a clinical diagnosis (Godoy et al., 2018; Pitman et al., 2012).

A hormone result is meaningful only in relation to the sampling conditions, timing, assay, comparison, and question. Health, medication, sleep, and repeated sampling can affect interpretation. Historical advances in assay sensitivity expanded measurement; they did not remove the need for defensible study design or convert a laboratory value into an independent account of an individual's experience.

1.7 Growth of brain imaging

Imaging expanded trauma research beyond peripheral physiological and endocrine measures to investigation of brain structure and function. Hinojosa and colleagues locate the early PTSD neuroimaging literature in the 1990s and describe the subsequent expansion of work on vulnerability, change after exposure, treatment outcomes, and proposed brain-based subgroups. The change in method opened new questions; it did not make biological interpretation independent of study design (Hinojosa et al., 2024).

One central problem is temporal order. A difference measured after exposure may have preceded the event, followed it, or reflect factors related to both exposure and outcome. Cross-sectional group comparisons alone cannot resolve these possibilities. The 2024 review therefore emphasises prospective longitudinal designs with measurements before exposure and at follow-up, as well as replication of proposed subgroups. It also distinguishes progress in research from implementation in routine clinical practice (Hinojosa et al., 2024).

Earlier synthesis had already connected PTSD research to hippocampal, amygdala, cingulate, and prefrontal findings while noting uncertainty about whether some differences represented vulnerability or acquired change. Such findings should be read as claims about specified samples and measures, not as a universal map of a traumatised brain. Regional findings can help formulate hypotheses about memory, threat, and regulation, but a group pattern does not determine a person's diagnosis or establish a particular history (Pitman et al., 2012).

The historical progression from peripheral recording to imaging is therefore not a progression from subjective evidence to an infallible biological answer. It is an expansion of observable information that brings new demands for measurement quality, appropriate comparison, temporal design, reproducibility, and restraint in clinical inference (Hinojosa et al., 2024).

1.8 Translation from laboratory to clinic

1.8.1 Measurement and research design

Measurement translates a construct into observable data. A study should state its operational definitions, instruments, units, timing, preprocessing decisions, quality controls, and expected error. Reliability concerns consistency; validity concerns whether the evidence supports the intended interpretation. Statistical significance alone does not establish clinical usefulness. Equally, a null finding may reflect limited power, poor measurement, restricted variation, or a genuinely small effect.

Design constrains inference. A cross-sectional study can estimate associations at one time but cannot establish temporal order. Longitudinal research can examine change, although attrition and repeated measurement may introduce bias. Experiments can investigate constrained mechanisms, while qualitative research can clarify meaning, acceptability, and implementation. Mixed-methods designs can relate these accounts to measured outcomes when the methods are deliberately integrated.

A protocol should define the primary question, exposure, outcomes, sampling, timing, quality controls, missing-data procedures, analysis, and ethical safeguards. Medical illness, medication, sleep disruption, pain, age, sex-related biology, substance use, social adversity, and previous exposure may influence trauma-related measures. Relevant information about these factors should be collected proportionately. Adding measures does not automatically strengthen a study: each should contribute information needed to answer the question.

1.8.2 Clinical formulation and responsible action

Clinical formulation organises information to guide a decision. It should connect the person's concerns, exposure history, present safety, symptoms, strengths, physical health, relationships, resources, culture, and goals. Neurobiological knowledge can help explain possible processes underlying startle, disturbed recall, bodily alarm, emotional numbing, or concentration difficulties. It does not establish a diagnosis independently of clinical assessment.

A formulation should identify immediate risks, modifiable processes, protective conditions, and measurable outcomes. It must remain open to revision when new information challenges the initial account. Treatment selection requires current professional guidance, patient preference, relevant competence, consideration of contraindications, and outcome monitoring rather than reliance on a speculative biomarker or a single image.

Figure 1.2 presents the manuscript's shared decision framework: define the question and context, examine evidence, consider alternatives, select a proportionate action, and review the outcome. This is an educational sequence, not a validated clinical algorithm. Table 1.2 summarises its application across professional settings.

Figure 1.2. Evidence-to-practice reasoning



Arrows show an educational decision sequence, not biological causation or a validated clinical algorithm. Original editorial schematic derived from the supplied chapter; no empirical data are plotted.

Table 1.2. Professional applications and quality safeguards

Setting	Decision	Evidence or method	Quality safeguard
Clinical services	What action may improve safety or functioning?	Collaborative assessment; outcome monitoring	Avoid unsupported biological testing and deterministic explanations.
Education	What support may improve participation and learning?	Observation, consultation, accessible teaching	Do not infer trauma or diagnosis from behaviour alone.
Healthcare	How can care reduce avoidable threat and improve continuity?	Medical review, communication, referral, quality data	Protect consent, privacy, and appropriate professional scope.
Government	Which population-level action has evidence and resources?	Surveillance, programme evaluation, policy analysis	Examine fairness, opportunity costs, and unintended harm.
Organisations	How can exposure management and recovery support improve?	Risk assessment, confidential referral, workforce indicators	Do not substitute individual training for safer systems.

Adapted editorially from original PDF pages 131–132. These are questions for planning and appraisal, not demonstrated intervention effects.

1.8.3 Communication and professional boundaries

A useful explanation translates technical language without erasing uncertainty. Practitioners should connect the concept to the person's question, explain normal variation, identify what the evidence cannot establish, and check understanding. Technical vocabulary should not substitute for an explanation or imply that every person exposed to trauma shares the same biological pattern.

Neuroscience education does not authorise diagnosis, prescribing, imaging interpretation, brain stimulation, laboratory testing, or trauma processing without appropriate qualifications and supervision. Urgent medical or psychiatric concerns require suitable assessment and referral. The purpose of translation is to improve decisions within a professional role, not to extend that role beyond its limits.

1.9 Limits of biological reductionism

1.9.1 The person is not the measurement

A biological account becomes reductionist when a partial observation is treated as a complete explanation of a person's experience, difficulties, or prospects. A scan, assay, symptom score, or theoretical circuit should not be used to infer a personal history or a fixed condition that the evidence cannot establish. Biological findings are interpreted in relation to development, health, learning, relationships, material conditions, and access to care.

This caution does not diminish the value of neuroscience. It specifies what is required for its responsible use: a clear construct, a suitable method, an appropriate comparison, a justified inference, and a decision that benefits from the information. A technically accurate result may still have little clinical or policy value if it does not improve the decision under consideration.

1.9.2 Culture, international relevance, and fairness

Research varies across countries in sampling, instruments, diagnostic systems, language, exposure patterns, healthcare access, and research infrastructure. Findings from high-income settings should not be assumed to represent every population. Multinational studies should consider measurement equivalence, document translation, include local investigators, and examine the relevance of conflict, displacement, inequality, infectious disease, nutrition, and service access.

Cultural meaning affects how people describe distress, memory, bodily experience, family responsibility, disclosure, and help-seeking. Researchers and practitioners should ask about meaning rather than infer it from group identity. Collaboration should strengthen local research capacity and shared governance instead of extracting data from under-resourced communities without durable benefit.

1.9.3 Ethics and data governance

Ethical practice requires informed consent, privacy, welfare, fairness, professional competence, and protection from avoidable harm. Trauma research may cause distress, reveal safeguarding concerns, or generate sensitive information. Protocols should specify responses to distress, incidental findings, withdrawal, data breaches, and requests for clinical advice. Compensation should recognise participants' time without exerting undue pressure.

Brain images, genomic information, digital traces, and clinical records may be reused in ways participants did not anticipate. Collection should be proportionate to the question, access should be controlled, and the limits of use should be transparent. People affected by trauma should contribute to study design and interpretation where involvement is safe, respectful, and meaningful.

Biological evidence should not be used to justify exclusion, discrimination, compulsory testing, or intrusive surveillance without demonstrated utility and fairness. Policy requires attention to opportunity costs and unintended consequences as well as intended benefits.

1.10 Integrative contemporary models

1.10.1 Linking explanation to context

An integrative account connects biological processes to cognition, development, behaviour, relationships, and social conditions without confusing these levels. It distinguishes an exposure from its interpretation, an observed difference from a mechanism, and an explanation from an intervention. Competing accounts should remain visible when evidence does not justify choosing one with confidence.

Application begins with a real decision: who needs to decide what, which evidence is available, what uncertainty remains, and which action is proportionate? Implementation requires named responsibilities, resources, referral and escalation routes, outcome indicators, and review dates. General neuroscience cannot provide these operational details on its own; local law, service capacity, and unequal access must also be considered.

Hospitals may use this framework to improve communication, pain care, sleep protection, referral, and continuity. Schools can support participation through predictable communication, manageable cognitive demands, and clear referral routes without diagnosing trauma from behaviour. Workplaces and emergency services can review exposure management, supervision, confidential support, and return-to-work procedures. Individual resilience training must not be used in place of safer systems.

1.10.2 Research development and critical appraisal

The manuscript identifies longitudinal measurement, multimodal data, computational analysis, replication, collaborative samples, and participant involvement as areas of methodological development. Their value depends on appropriate design, harmonisation, secure computing, interpretability, and governance. Novelty is not evidence of clinical benefit.

Personalised prediction, passive sensing, wearable physiology, advanced imaging, molecular signatures, digital interventions, and adaptive treatment raise questions about overfitting, biased samples, privacy, false reassurance, unnecessary alarm, and unequal access. Evaluation should compare a proposed approach with a realistic standard of care and assess harm as carefully as benefit. These are research and evaluation priorities, not claims that the approaches are ready for routine use.

Advanced appraisal should examine the proposition, evidence, causal model, and consequences of use. Relevant questions include whether constructs are clear, samples appropriate, measures reliable and valid, analyses suitable, and findings replicated. A defensible protocol distinguishes exploratory from confirmatory analysis, justifies sample size, specifies primary questions, reports planned outcomes, and shares materials or code where lawful. Conclusions should state what the evidence supports, what remains uncertain, and which next study would reduce the most important uncertainty.

1.11 Teaching cases and worked applications

The following cases are fictional teaching composites from the supplied manuscript. They are not research findings, clinical protocols, or reports of identified people or institutions.

1.11.1 Disaster response across several communities

Severe flooding and infrastructure failure affect several communities. A multidisciplinary team encounters disrupted sleep, heightened startle, grief, pain, displacement, interrupted medication, and reduced access to care. The team considers biological responses without assuming that every reaction indicates a disorder.

Its proposed stepped response combines immediate safety, physical healthcare, practical assistance, family contact, psychological first aid, screening where referral is available, and specialist assessment or treatment for persistent impairment. Researchers propose optional

longitudinal measurement with separate consent, secure data handling, community oversight, and feedback of aggregate findings.

The teaching issue is how to connect biological explanation to humane, proportionate decisions. Learners should identify which actions address immediate needs, what would justify further assessment, and how research can remain distinct from access to care.

1.11.2 Recovery after a road traffic collision in Nigeria

At a fictional Nigerian teaching hospital, an adult reports nightmares, bodily alarm, poor concentration, pain, and fear of travelling after a road traffic collision. The clinician reviews injury, medication, sleep, substance use, previous health, present safety, social support, and functional change.

The team uses traumatic stress and adaptation as possible explanatory concepts, not as proof of a diagnosis. It provides plain-language information, coordinates medical and psychological review, agrees measurable goals, and arranges follow-up. A student group considering research on the pathway first examines language validity, transport barriers, phone access, loss to follow-up, and whether biological sampling would have a clear purpose.

Learners should distinguish observed concerns from interpretation, identify the information needed for safe assessment, and consider how access barriers affect both care and research participation. No new diagnosis, outcome, or effectiveness claim is implied by the case.

1.11.3 Worked appraisal: does an association establish causation?

A report describes an association between a biological measure and trauma-related symptoms. No numerical findings are supplied in the original example. The task is to evaluate the inference, not to calculate an effect or assume an experimental result.

1. State the exposure, outcome, population, and measurement times.
2. Identify the design and whether it establishes temporal order.
3. Examine the reliability and validity of the measures.
4. Consider plausible confounding, including age, sleep, medication, physical illness, pain, previous exposure, and social adversity.
5. Inspect the reported effect size and uncertainty rather than relying on statistical significance alone.
6. Assess the comparison group and any replication evidence.

7. Restate the conclusion at the level the design and evidence support, identifying what further work would strengthen causal inference.

1.11.4 Explaining a finding to a professional audience

Begin by identifying the audience and the decision. Replace technical shorthand with accurate plain language, explain variation, and use an observable example. State what the evidence cannot establish and identify urgent concerns that require referral. Offer proportionate actions, check understanding, invite questions, and document the explanation. Review whether the communication improved understanding, safety, participation, or adherence rather than assuming that information alone was helpful.

1.12 Summary

Trauma neurobiology requires explanation across interacting levels, not a single-region or single-molecule account. A useful claim identifies the construct, method, population, timing, uncertainty, and intended use. Exposure, biological measurement, functional impairment, and diagnosis must remain distinct.

Research design determines the inference that evidence can support. Clinical and policy applications require additional attention to safety, professional competence, culture, resources, fairness, and review. Biological knowledge is most useful when it clarifies a decision without reducing a person to a measurement or presenting uncertainty as certainty.

The history of the field shows why methodological advances require conceptual discipline. Improved measurement creates opportunities for more precise questions; it does not remove uncertainty about causation, individual interpretation, or appropriate use.

Review and discussion questions

1. Why must exposure, biological response, functional impairment, and diagnosis be distinguished?
2. How do cellular, circuit, endocrine, immune, behavioural, and social levels contribute different information? Use Table 1.1 to identify a limit at each level.
3. What can cross-sectional and longitudinal studies establish, and what remains uncertain in each design?
4. Why is a statistically significant group association insufficient to determine the condition of an individual?

5. How could development, health, culture, and service access alter the interpretation or application of a finding?
6. What would justify a proposed biological test, and what additional considerations would be needed before clinical use?
7. Compare the two composite cases. Which decisions concern immediate safety, which concern longer-term care, and which concern research?
8. Explain why a single research method cannot provide a complete account of trauma-related behaviour.

Practical and research assignments

- **Concepts and communication:** Explain neuroscience, traumatic stress, homeostasis, allostasis, and adaptation in plain language using verified course sources. State the boundary of each term and identify one common interpretative error. Prepare a one-page handout without deterministic or stigmatising language.
- **Evidence appraisal:** Compare two peer-reviewed studies relevant to psychophysiology, neuroendocrinology, or trauma research. Examine sampling, measurement, analysis, conclusions, and uncertainty. Critically appraise one relevant systematic review.
- **Case formulation:** Prepare a 1,500-word formulation of the road traffic collision case. Include safety, alternative explanations, strengths, culture, goals, and outcome measures. Do not invent findings or diagnose from the vignette alone.
- **Service application:** Design a proposed pathway for a hospital, school, workplace, emergency service, or community programme. Specify responsibilities, resources, referral, escalation, outcome indicators, and review. Explain why its proposed benefits require evaluation.
- **Research design:** Outline a longitudinal or mixed-methods study with a defined biological measure, functional outcome, sampling plan, ethical safeguards, missing-data procedures, and analysis. State why each measure is necessary.
- **Advanced research options:** Develop one of the source's proposed research directions: mediation or moderation; measurement equivalence across groups; externally validated multimodal prediction with fairness and utility assessment; or implementation in under-resourced services. Replace generic labels with a specific construct, measure, population, and defensible question before proposing a study.

Literature-search activities

These activities develop the source's generic Suggested Readings into explicit search tasks. They are not bibliographic entries or claims that particular sources have been selected or verified.

1. Locate a current neuroscience textbook treatment of the scope of neuroscience and the operationalisation of trauma exposure.
2. Locate a recent systematic review relevant to psychophysiology or neuroendocrinology.
3. Identify current professional guidance for trauma assessment or treatment, research ethics, and data protection appropriate to the jurisdiction and role.
4. Find a locally relevant study on translation into practice and service access.
5. Select a methods paper that reports measurement, analysis, uncertainty, and reproducibility in sufficient detail for critical appraisal.

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Functional Neuroanatomy of Threat, Memory, and Regulation

Chapter 2

In this chapter

Learning objectives 26
Introduction 26
2.1 Orientation to the nervous system 27
Divisions and embryological logic 27
Planes, position and the problem of the cephalic flexure 28
Grey matter, white matter and the meaning of "connection" 28
The brainstem, cranial nerves and ascending systems 29
Vasculature, meninges and the limits of inference from lesions 29
2.2 Cerebral cortex and subcortex 30
The cortex as a continuous sheet 30
Cytoarchitecture and cortical hierarchies 30
Subcortical structures 31
Clinical illustration 31
2.3 Amygdala organisation 31
Structure 32
Function 32
Avoidance and behavioural engagement 33
Caveats 33
2.4 The hippocampal formation 34
Structure 34
Function 35
Findings in PTSD and their interpretation 35
Clinical illustration 36
2.5 Prefrontal cortical systems 36
Structure 36
Function and stress effects 36
Imaging findings in PTSD 37

Implications for intervention 37
2.6 Insula and interoception 38
Structure 38
Interoception 38
Relevance to traumatic stress 38
2.7 Anterior cingulate cortex 39
Structure and subdivisions 39
Integration rather than segregation 39
Relevance to trauma 40
2.8 Brainstem and periaqueductal grey 40
The brainstem as an integrative centre 40
The periaqueductal grey 40
Arousal, sleep and the body 41
Clinical implications 41
2.9 Cerebellar contributions 41
Structure 41
Functional topography 41
Why this matters for trauma 42
2.10 Large-scale brain networks 42
From regions to networks 42
What network findings can and cannot establish 43
Synthesis: from anatomy to formulation 43
Measurement and interpretation 45
Cultural and international perspectives 46
Professional practice 46
Ethics and data governance 47
Policy implications 47
Composite case study 48
Local composite case study 48
Worked example 49
Review and discussion questions 49
Research assignments 50
Chapter summary 50
References 50

Central question. How do the structures and systems of the human nervous system generate threat responses, store and update emotional memory, and support regulation—and what can, and cannot, be inferred from evidence about them in traumatic stress?

Learning objectives

By the end of this chapter, doctoral learners should be able to:

- describe the principal divisions of the nervous system and use anatomical terms of position and section accurately;
- explain the organisation of the cerebral cortex, the hippocampal formation, the amygdala, the insula, the anterior cingulate cortex, the brainstem and the cerebellum at a level sufficient for critical reading of trauma neuroscience;
- evaluate claims that a structure or circuit "causes" post-traumatic stress, distinguishing correlational imaging findings from mechanistic evidence;
- compare the strengths and limits of lesion, animal, pharmacological, electrophysiological and neuroimaging methods;
- apply anatomical reasoning to formulation, psychoeducation and service design without treating biology as destiny;
- identify ethical, cultural and data-governance questions raised by neuroanatomical research on trauma.

Introduction

Trauma neuroscience is often taught as a list of regions with assigned emotions: the amygdala for fear, the hippocampus for memory, the prefrontal cortex for control. That shorthand is memorable and almost always misleading. Each structure participates in many processes; each process recruits many structures; and the same anatomy supports adaptive responses in one context and distressing responses in another. A doctoral-level account therefore has to do two things at once. It must give the reader enough anatomical detail to follow the primary literature, and it must teach a disciplined habit of interpretation that resists converting a group-level correlation into a claim about a person.

This chapter supplies both. Sections 2.1 and 2.2 establish the vocabulary and the large-scale layout of the nervous system. Sections 2.3 to 2.9 examine the structures most often implicated in traumatic stress: the amygdala, hippocampal formation, prefrontal cortex, insula, anterior cingulate cortex, brainstem and cerebellum. Section 2.10 turns from individual structures to large-scale networks. The final sections address measurement, cultural and international variation, professional application, ethics, policy and research design.

Three cautions recur throughout. First, anatomy is not function. A structure's presence in a circuit does not tell us what computation it performs, and a bold spot on a brain image does not identify a psychological process. Second, most human trauma research is observational. It can establish association, sequence and plausibility, but rarely the kind of causal isolation available in controlled animal experiments—and animal models carry their own problems of translation. Third, clinical usefulness is a separate question from statistical significance. A finding may be reliable and still too imprecise to guide an individual decision.

> **A note on terminology.** *Trauma in this chapter means exposure to an event or set of conditions that overwhelms ordinary adjustment and may produce persistent distress. It does not name a brain state, a diagnosis, or a fixed neurological signature. Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) is a clinical syndrome defined by diagnostic criteria; most people exposed to trauma do not develop it, and many who develop it recover. The neurobiology described here concerns processes that can be involved in distress and recovery, not a test for who has suffered.*

2.1 Orientation to the nervous system

Divisions and embryological logic

The nervous system is conventionally divided into the central nervous system (CNS)—the brain and spinal cord—and the peripheral nervous system, which connects the CNS to skin, muscle, organs and sensory receptors. The peripheral system is further divided into somatic and autonomic components; the autonomic system into sympathetic, parasympathetic and enteric divisions. These divisions are useful for organising teaching, but they describe overlapping control systems rather than separate machines. The vagus nerve, for example, carries both ascending visceral information and descending parasympathetic output, and its activity is integrated with brainstem and forebrain circuits.

The adult layout is easier to remember when it is derived from development. The neural tube gives rise to three primary vesicles. The prosencephalon becomes the forebrain, dividing into the telencephalon—cerebral hemispheres, basal ganglia, hippocampus and olfactory structures—and the diencephalon—thalamus, hypothalamus, epithalamus and subthalamus. The mesencephalon becomes the midbrain. The rhombencephalon becomes the hindbrain, dividing into the metencephalon (pons and cerebellum) and the myelencephalon

(medulla). The caudal neural tube becomes the spinal cord. The ventricular system follows the same geometry: lateral ventricles in the hemispheres, the third ventricle in the diencephalon, the cerebral aqueduct in the midbrain, and the fourth ventricle between pons and cerebellum. This developmental logic explains why structures that look widely separated in the adult brain—for example, the amygdala and the hippocampus—share embryological origins in the temporal lobe and remain functionally intertwined.

Planes, position and the problem of the cephalic flexure

Neuroanatomical description uses three standard planes. Coronal sections divide the brain into anterior and posterior parts; sagittal sections divide it into left and right; horizontal (axial) sections divide it into superior and inferior parts. Because the human nervous system bends at the junction of midbrain and diencephalon—the cephalic flexure—the same words change meaning between the forebrain and the hindbrain. *Dorsal* means toward the back in the hindbrain but toward the top of the head in the forebrain. *Rostral* points toward the top of the head in the hindbrain but toward the face in the forebrain. *Anterior* and *posterior*, by contrast, follow the long axis of the body and therefore keep a consistent spatial meaning. Confusion about these terms is not a trivial matter of vocabulary: it produces real errors in reading lesion and imaging papers, particularly when coordinates are reported in different conventions.

Grey matter, white matter and the meaning of "connection"

Grey matter contains neuronal cell bodies, dendrites, synaptic neuropil and glia. White matter contains myelinated axons bundled into tracts. Cortical grey matter is organised in layers, and the relative prominence of different layers varies across the cortex, producing the cytoarchitectonic maps associated with Brodmann and later quantitative atlases. Subcortical grey matter forms nuclei—clusters of cell bodies with relatively distinct inputs and outputs—such as the thalamus, basal ganglia, amygdala and brainstem nuclei. White-matter tracts connect these regions. The corpus callosum carries hundreds of millions of axons between hemispheres; the internal capsule carries ascending and descending fibres past the basal ganglia; the fornix connects hippocampus to diencephalon and other targets.

The distinction matters for interpretation. A structural finding in grey matter may reflect cell bodies, dendrites, synapses or vasculature; a diffusion finding in white matter may reflect myelin, axon calibre, fibre

packing or extracellular water. Neither is a direct measure of "connectivity" in the functional sense. When a paper reports reduced white-matter integrity in trauma-exposed groups, the appropriate conclusion concerns a statistical property of a diffusion metric in that sample—not a severed pathway or a broken relationship.

The brainstem, cranial nerves and ascending systems

The brainstem comprises the midbrain, pons and medulla. It contains cranial nerve nuclei serving sensation and movement of the head and neck, ascending and descending long tracts, and the reticular formation—a distributed network of nuclei involved in arousal, sleep–wake regulation, autonomic control, pain modulation and motor tone. Several nuclei project diffusely to the forebrain and are therefore described as neuromodulatory: the locus coeruleus (noradrenaline), the raphe nuclei (serotonin), the ventral tegmental area and substantia nigra (dopamine), and the basal forebrain cholinergic system. Because these nuclei influence large territories, their involvement in stress responses can produce widespread effects that are easy to mistake for regionally specific pathology.

The brainstem also contains the periaqueductal grey (PAG), discussed in Section 2.8, and the parabrachial nucleus, which relays visceral and nociceptive information to the amygdala, insula and hypothalamus. These pathways provide an anatomical basis for the bodily character of threat: the sense of pressure in the chest, the sudden nausea, the impulse to freeze. They do not by themselves explain the meaning a person assigns to those sensations.

Vasculature, meninges and the limits of inference from lesions

The brain is supplied by the anterior and posterior circulations and drained by venous sinuses; the meninges (dura, arachnoid and pia) enclose the CNS and the cerebrospinal fluid. Vascular territory matters clinically because infarcts produce relatively stereotyped lesion patterns, and historically these patterns supplied much of what was known about structure–function relationships. The classic example—patient H.M.'s bilateral medial temporal resection and subsequent anterograde amnesia—established the importance of the medial temporal lobe for declarative memory (Scoville & Milner, 1957). But lesions are rarely pure. They remove fibres passing through as well as cell bodies, they disrupt blood supply to adjacent tissue, and they trigger plasticity over time. A lesion study can demonstrate that a region

is necessary for a function in a particular patient; it cannot by itself specify the mechanism.

2.2 Cerebral cortex and subcortex

The cortex as a continuous sheet

The cerebral cortex is a thin, highly folded sheet of grey matter, typically three to five millimetres thick, containing neuronal cell bodies, dendrites, synapses, glia and blood vessels. Folding increases surface area within the cranial cavity: ridges are gyri, valleys are sulci, and especially deep sulci are fissures. The major lobes—frontal, parietal, temporal and occipital—are defined largely by surface landmarks. The central sulcus separates frontal from parietal cortex on the lateral surface; the lateral (Sylvian) fissure separates the temporal lobe from the frontal and parietal lobes above; the parieto-occipital sulcus marks the medial boundary between parietal and occipital cortex.

These boundaries are conventions, not functional compartments. The cortical sheet is continuous, and the same cytoarchitectonic field can extend across a named boundary. The insula, for example, is buried beneath the opercular cortex of the frontal, parietal and temporal lobes; it is not an island but a continuously connected region hidden by the disproportionate growth of surrounding cortex. Contemporary accounts therefore prefer to describe gradients and networks rather than treating lobes as functional units.

Cytoarchitecture and cortical hierarchies

Cortical areas differ in the relative thickness of their six layers. Primary sensory cortices have a prominent granular layer IV, reflecting dense thalamic input. Primary motor cortex has a prominent layer V, reflecting output to brainstem and spinal cord. Association cortices show less distinct lamination and extensive recurrent and long-range connectivity. This architecture supports a rough hierarchy: unimodal sensory cortex, then multimodal association cortex, then paralimbic and limbic regions that integrate sensory information with internal state, memory and value.

Hierarchy is not the same as control. The phrase "top-down control" is often used as though higher areas issue commands to lower ones. In practice, cortical and subcortical systems interact reciprocally, and the direction of influence depends on the task and the state of the organism. The prefrontal cortex can bias processing in sensory and limbic regions,

but it also receives dense ascending input that shapes what it can compute. Under acute stress, ascending noradrenergic and dopaminergic signals can rapidly alter prefrontal function—sometimes improving simple vigilance while impairing complex working memory.

Subcortical structures

The thalamus is the principal relay for sensory and motor information to the cortex, and it participates in cortico-thalamo-cortical loops that support attention and cognition. The hypothalamus integrates endocrine, autonomic and behavioural responses through its control of the pituitary and its projections to brainstem nuclei. The basal ganglia—caudate, putamen, globus pallidus, subthalamic nucleus and substantia nigra—support action selection, habit learning and reward-based learning. The amygdala and hippocampal formation, treated in the following sections, are anatomically adjacent but functionally distinct.

The basal ganglia deserve more attention in trauma teaching than they usually receive. Avoidance, habitual safety behaviour and reward learning are central to how traumatic stress persists, and these processes depend on corticostriatal circuits. A narrow focus on the amygdala as the "fear centre" can obscure the role of striatal learning in the gradual construction of a narrowed life.

Clinical illustration

Consider a patient who avoids driving after a collision. An amygdala-centred explanation would emphasise conditioned fear to the vehicle. A fuller formulation would also consider hippocampal contextual memory (the specific junction where the collision occurred), prefrontal appraisal (the belief that driving is now inherently dangerous), insular interoception (the nausea and palpitations that precede avoidance), basal ganglia habit (the practised route of avoidance), and brainstem arousal (sleep disruption and exaggerated startle). Each level suggests a different intervention: exposure to the avoided context, cognitive work on appraisal, interoceptive awareness, sleep treatment, or graded return to driving. The anatomy is useful precisely because it generates multiple hypotheses rather than one.

2.3 Amygdala organisation

Structure

The amygdala is an almond-shaped group of nuclei in the medial temporal lobe, anterior to the hippocampus. Its principal subdivisions include the lateral, basal and accessory basal nuclei (often grouped as the basolateral complex), the central nucleus, the medial nucleus and the cortical nuclei, together with the intercalated cell masses that sit between the basolateral complex and the central nucleus. The bed nucleus of the stria terminalis (BNST) is a closely related structure in the extended amygdala, continuous with the central nucleus and involved in sustained anxiety rather than brief phasic fear.

The flow of information is roughly serial and parallel. Sensory information reaches the lateral and basal nuclei from thalamus and cortex. These nuclei project to the central nucleus, directly and through the intercalated cells. The central nucleus, in turn, projects to the hypothalamus, brainstem and PAG, producing autonomic, endocrine and behavioural components of threat responses. The intercalated cells are inhibitory and are thought to gate information from basolateral to central nuclei; they have been implicated in the expression of extinction memories (Milad & Quirk, 2012). Extinction does not erase the original association. It establishes a new, context-dependent inhibitory memory that competes with the original, which is why fear can return after a change of context, the passage of time or a new stressor. Reconsolidation research suggests that a memory can become temporarily labile after retrieval and may be modified during restabilisation (Nader et al., 2000), but the conditions under which this can be used therapeutically in humans remain contested.

Function

The amygdala is not a fear module. It responds to novelty, salience, uncertainty, reward prediction and social signals, and its role in threat learning is best understood as part of a broader system for detecting and evaluating biologically significant events. In Pavlovian fear conditioning, a neutral conditioned stimulus is paired with an aversive unconditioned stimulus; over trials, the conditioned stimulus comes to elicit defensive responses. The lateral amygdala is a principal site of plasticity for this association, while the central nucleus organises the output (LeDoux, 2000; Maren, 2001). Lesions of the amygdala impair acquisition and expression of conditioned fear but do not abolish all defensive behaviour, which can also be organised by brainstem and hypothalamic circuits.

Human neuroimaging consistently shows amygdala responses to threat-related stimuli, including faces, scenes and trauma reminders. In PTSD, several meta-analyses report exaggerated amygdala reactivity to trauma-related or threat-related cues compared with trauma-exposed controls, together with reduced medial prefrontal engagement. These are group-level differences with substantial overlap between groups; they cannot be used to diagnose an individual, and their direction can vary with task, symptom profile and dissociation.

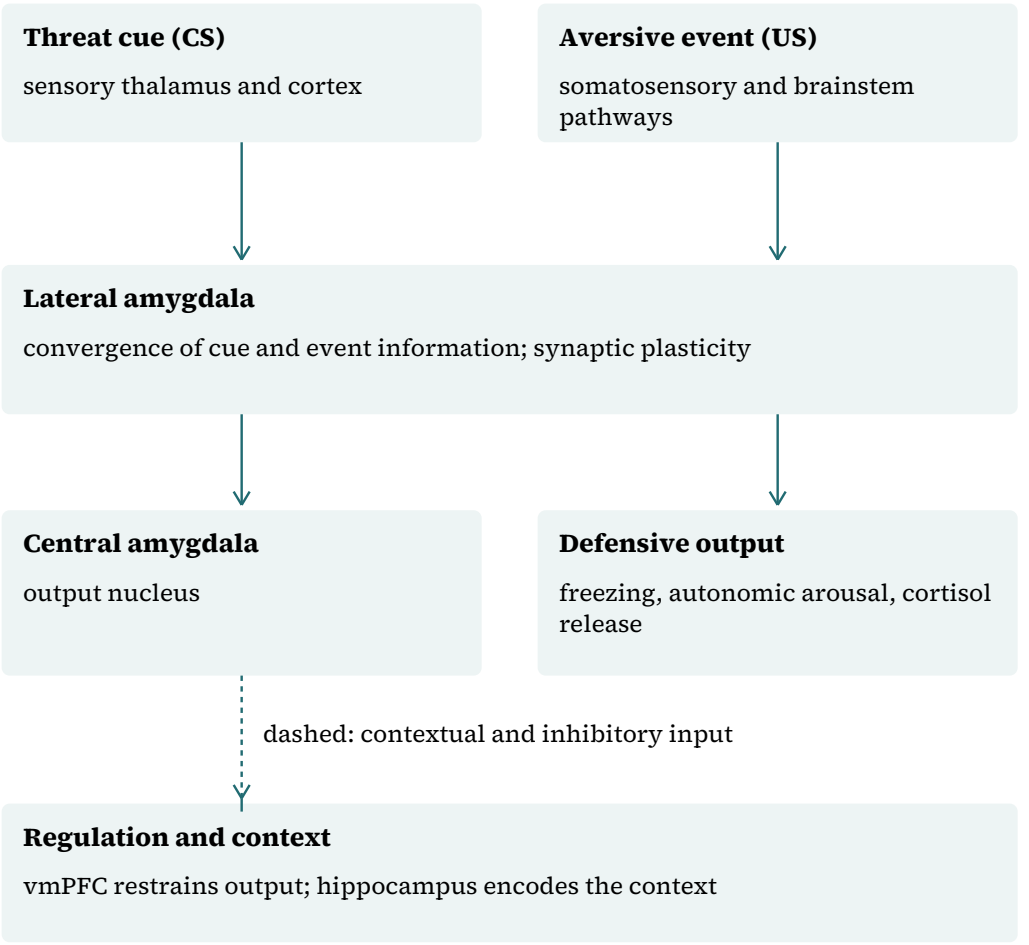
Avoidance and behavioural engagement

Recent work has broadened the amygdala's role from fear conditioning to decision-making about engagement with the environment. In rodent models, passive freezing and active avoidance depend on partially distinct pathways: lateral amygdala to central amygdala to PAG for freezing, and lateral amygdala to basal amygdala to nucleus accumbens for active avoidance, with infralimbic cortex contributing to the latter. These findings matter clinically because avoidance is not a single behaviour. A patient who freezes, a patient who flees, and a patient who quietly reorganises life to avoid reminders may be expressing different circuits and may need different therapeutic emphases.

Caveats

Most detailed microcircuit evidence comes from rodents. Homologies between rodent and human prefrontal cortex are debated, and the translation of optogenetic findings to human PTSD is indirect. Human imaging measures are sensitive to movement, physiological noise, task design and analysis choices. The amygdala is a small, heterogeneous structure; standard voxel sizes blur its subdivisions, so a "basolateral" finding in a typical fMRI study is often an inference rather than a measurement. These limits do not make the findings worthless, but they should temper claims that a specific nucleus has been shown to cause a specific symptom in a patient.

Figure 2.1. A simplified threat-learning circuit



CS, conditioned stimulus; US, unconditioned stimulus; vmPFC, ventromedial prefrontal cortex. Connections are simplified: the amygdala is treated as a functional unit and many parallel routes are omitted.

2.4 The hippocampal formation

Structure

The hippocampal formation lies in the medial temporal lobe and includes the dentate gyrus, the hippocampus proper (cornu ammonis fields CA1, CA2, CA3 and the hilus), the subiculum and the adjacent presubiculum and parasubiculum, with the entorhinal cortex as its principal cortical interface. The dentate gyrus receives input from entorhinal layer II via the perforant path and projects to CA3 via mossy fibres; CA3 projects to CA1 via Schaffer collaterals; CA1 projects to the subiculum and back to entorhinal cortex. This trisynaptic organisation is

the anatomical basis of a widely studied model of learning and memory, although the system also contains extensive parallel and recurrent connections that the simple circuit diagram omits.

The hippocampus is not a single homogeneous structure. Its dorsal (in humans, posterior) and ventral (anterior) portions differ in connectivity and function, with the posterior hippocampus more strongly associated with spatial and episodic memory and the anterior portion more strongly connected to amygdala and affective processing. This gradient is relevant to trauma research, where "hippocampal volume" is often treated as a single variable.

Function

The hippocampal formation is essential for the formation of declarative memory—memory that can be consciously recalled, including episodic memory for events and semantic memory for facts—and for spatial navigation and contextual processing. It supports relational memory: the ability to bind elements of an experience into a coherent representation and to use that representation flexibly (Squire, 2004). It is also involved in imagining future events, which is why hippocampal damage can impair both remembering and prospecting.

In threat learning, the hippocampus provides the contextual frame. A conditioned cue may signal danger only in a particular place, time or internal state; the hippocampus is central to representing that context and to the renewal of fear when a context changes. This has clinical implications: a patient may feel relatively safe at home and overwhelmed in a supermarket, not because the supermarket is inherently more dangerous but because contextual processing has been altered by trauma.

Findings in PTSD and their interpretation

Reduced hippocampal volume is one of the most replicated structural findings in PTSD, reported across trauma types and supported by large imaging consortia. The interpretation, however, is unresolved. Volume reduction may precede trauma and confer vulnerability; it may follow trauma through glucocorticoid-related dendritic remodelling; it may reflect comorbid depression, alcohol use, sleep disturbance or medication; and it may be partly explained by image-processing choices. Longitudinal studies are difficult and relatively few. The appropriate conclusion is that smaller hippocampal volume is associated with PTSD in many samples, that the causal direction is uncertain, and that hippocampal volume is not a diagnostic test.

Animal work provides plausible mechanisms. Chronic stress and glucocorticoid exposure can reduce dendritic arborisation in CA3, suppress neurogenesis in the dentate gyrus and alter long-term potentiation in CA1 (McEwen, 1998). These findings are important, but they come from controlled paradigms with species-specific stress exposures. They establish that stress can alter hippocampal structure and function under particular conditions; they do not establish that a given patient's scan reflects a particular life event.

Clinical illustration

A patient reports fragmented recall of a road collision but vivid, intrusive images of a specific detail—the sound of braking. A hippocampal account would emphasise impaired contextual binding: the fragment is not integrated into a coherent episode with a beginning, middle and end. A therapeutic implication is that rebuilding a coherent narrative, in a safe and paced way, may reduce the fragment's intrusive quality. This is a hypothesis, not a proven mechanism, and it should be offered as part of a broader formulation rather than as a neuroanatomical certainty.

2.5 Prefrontal cortical systems

Structure

The prefrontal cortex occupies the anterior portion of the frontal lobe. Major subdivisions include the dorsolateral prefrontal cortex (dlPFC), important for working memory, planning and cognitive flexibility; the ventrolateral prefrontal cortex, involved in response selection and inhibition; the ventromedial prefrontal cortex (vmPFC), including medial orbital and subgenual regions, involved in value-based decision-making and emotion regulation; and the anterior cingulate cortex (Section 2.7). These regions are densely interconnected with thalamus, basal ganglia, amygdala, hippocampus and brainstem neuromodulatory systems.

Function and stress effects

The prefrontal cortex supports the maintenance and manipulation of information in working memory, the inhibition of prepotent responses, the flexible updating of rules, and the regulation of emotion through reappraisal and related strategies (Ochsner & Gross, 2005). It is also among the most stress-sensitive cortical regions. Work by Arnsten and

colleagues showed that even mild, uncontrollable stress can rapidly impair prefrontal working memory in animals and humans, through high levels of noradrenaline and dopamine acting on alpha-1 and D1 receptors. These signals engage intracellular cascades—calcium–cAMP signalling and protein kinase C—that reduce prefrontal firing and weaken network connectivity. With chronic stress or glucocorticoid exposure, dendritic spines on prefrontal pyramidal cells retract, while dendrites in the amygdala expand. The same neurochemical events that impair prefrontal function can strengthen amygdala-dependent emotional learning, shifting control toward more reflexive responses.

This is one of the clearest mechanistic accounts in the field, and it is worth stating precisely. It does not show that stress damages the prefrontal cortex permanently, nor that trauma survivors have a fixed prefrontal deficit. It shows that under conditions of uncontrollable stress, prefrontal networks become less effective and subcortical defensive systems become more influential—an adaptive shift in the short term, potentially costly when sustained.

Imaging findings in PTSD

Functional imaging in PTSD frequently reports reduced activation of the vmPFC and rostral anterior cingulate during symptom provocation or extinction recall, and reduced functional connectivity between vmPFC and amygdala. These findings are consistent with the idea that extinction memory retrieval is impaired, but they are not uniform. Some studies report increased prefrontal activation during sustained attention, possibly reflecting compensatory effort, and the pattern varies with dissociation, comorbidity and task demands.

The most defensible reading is that PTSD is associated with altered prefrontal regulation of limbic and autonomic systems in many—not all—samples, and that the direction and magnitude of the difference depend on what the person is doing and how the task is designed. A single scan cannot establish that a person's prefrontal cortex is "underactive" in daily life.

Implications for intervention

Prefrontal accounts support interventions that strengthen regulatory capacity: sleep restoration, reducing unnecessary cognitive load, practising reappraisal, and rebuilding predictable routines. They also caution against overloading survivors with complex cognitive demands during acute stress. But "strengthening the prefrontal cortex" is not a clinical prescription. The evidence for generalised cognitive training

improving trauma symptoms is weak, and the most effective treatments—trauma-focused psychotherapy and, for some, medication—work through multiple mechanisms that are not reducible to prefrontal activation.

2.6 Insula and interoception

Structure

The insula is a region of cortex buried within the lateral sulcus, bounded by the frontal, parietal and temporal opercula. It is conventionally divided into posterior, mid and anterior zones. The posterior insula receives visceral and somatosensory input and contains a primary interoceptive representation; the mid insula integrates this information with sensory and affective signals; the anterior insula is connected with anterior cingulate, prefrontal, amygdala and reward-related structures. The insula is also a core node of the salience network (Section 2.10).

Interoception

Interoception refers to the sensing and processing of signals from within the body, including cardiac, respiratory, gastrointestinal and visceral information. It is not a single sense. It includes the detection of internal signals (interoceptive accuracy), the subjective belief about one's sensitivity (interoceptive sensibility), and the correspondence between them (interoceptive awareness). These components are measured differently and do not always agree.

Craig's account proposes a posterior-to-anterior progression in which primary interoceptive representations are re-represented in the anterior insula, providing a basis for subjective feelings and emotional awareness. This is an influential model, but its stronger claims—particularly the proposal that the anterior insula is a neural correlate of consciousness—remain contested. For trauma teaching, the more defensible points are that interoceptive signals contribute to emotional experience, that the insula participates in detecting and integrating them, and that individuals differ markedly in interoceptive accuracy and in how they interpret bodily sensations.

Relevance to traumatic stress

Trauma-related distress is frequently bodily. Panic-like sensations, nausea, tightness, numbness and depersonalisation involve altered

interoceptive processing. Some studies report altered interoceptive accuracy in PTSD and in related conditions, but findings are inconsistent and depend on the task and the comparison group. The clinical value of the interoceptive framework is that it provides a non-mystical language for bodily symptoms and suggests graded, tolerable exposure to internal sensations rather than avoidance.

Dissociation complicates the picture. In the dissociative subtype of PTSD, depersonalisation and derealisation involve a sense of detachment from the body or surroundings. Imaging studies report a pattern opposite to classic re-experiencing: increased vmPFC and dorsal anterior midcingulate activity, reduced amygdala and insula activity, and blunted or reduced heart-rate responses to trauma cues. This does not mean that dissociation is "shutting down" the brain; it suggests a different regulatory configuration, with top-down overmodulation of limbic and autonomic responses.

2.7 Anterior cingulate cortex

Structure and subdivisions

The cingulate cortex is a belt of cortex encircling the corpus callosum on the medial surface of the hemispheres. It is divided into anterior, mid and posterior regions, with further subdivisions based on architecture, connectivity and function. The anterior cingulate cortex (ACC) includes rostral and ventral portions associated with affective processing and autonomic regulation. The midcingulate cortex (MCC), often described as dorsal ACC, includes an anterior portion (aMCC) that has become central to integrative accounts of negative affect, pain and cognitive control.

Integration rather than segregation

A long-standing model assigned emotion to rostral ACC and cognition to dorsal MCC. Shackman and colleagues reviewed physiological, anatomical and functional evidence and concluded that this segregation is difficult to sustain. Negative affect, pain and cognitive control all engage an overlapping region of the dorsal cingulate—the aMCC—which appears to function as a hub linking information about reinforcers to motor centres responsible for expressing affect and executing goal-directed behaviour. On this account, aMCC implements a domain-general process that uses punishment-related information to adapt behaviour.

This is a useful corrective to the habit of labelling ACC activity as "conflict monitoring" or "pain" or "emotion" depending on the study. The same region can be active in many tasks because it is doing something common to them—evaluating the significance of events for action—rather than because the tasks share a hidden emotional content.

Relevance to trauma

ACC and MCC findings in PTSD include altered activation during symptom provocation, altered connectivity with amygdala and insula, and associations between rostral ACC activity and extinction recall. These findings are embedded in the larger prefrontal-limbic literature and should not be read in isolation (Pitman et al., 2012). A particularly important caution concerns pain. Trauma survivors frequently report pain, and the overlap between pain and negative affect in aMCC means that a trauma-informed explanation should not reduce pain to "psychological" causation, nor treat it as unrelated to stress. Both dimensions require assessment.

2.8 Brainstem and periaqueductal grey

The brainstem as an integrative centre

The brainstem is not a passive conduit. It contains the cranial nerve nuclei that serve vision, hearing, taste, facial sensation and movement, swallowing, and parasympathetic control of the heart and viscera. It contains the reticular formation, with ascending systems that regulate cortical arousal and descending systems that modulate pain and autonomic output. It contains the locus coeruleus, the principal source of noradrenaline in the forebrain, and the raphe nuclei, the principal source of serotonin. It also contains the PAG.

The periaqueductal grey

The PAG surrounds the cerebral aqueduct in the midbrain. It is organised into columns with different connectivity and different defensive functions. The dorsolateral and dorsomedial columns have been associated with active defensive responses such as flight and fight; the lateral column with freezing and vigilance; the ventrolateral column with passive coping, quiescence and immobilisation. These associations come largely from animal work and are not rigid; the same column can support different behaviours depending on context and on inputs from amygdala, hypothalamus and prefrontal cortex.

The PAG is a plausible node in the circuitry of trauma-related freezing, shutdown and dissociation. Fenster and colleagues note increased functional connectivity of the ventrolateral PAG with regions linked to passive responses to threat in the dissociative subtype of PTSD compared with classic PTSD. This is an interesting convergence between animal defensive circuitry and human symptom patterns, but it remains a correlational finding in a modest literature.

Arousal, sleep and the body

Brainstem nuclei regulate sleep–wake transitions, REM sleep, breathing and heart rate. Trauma-related sleep disturbance—fragmented sleep, nightmares, hyperarousal at night—is therefore not merely a cortical phenomenon. Noradrenergic activity is reduced during REM sleep under ordinary conditions, and alterations in this system may contribute to the intrusive, emotionally intense quality of traumatic dreams. Sleep disruption, in turn, affects prefrontal function, emotional reactivity and pain sensitivity, creating feedback loops that maintain distress.

Clinical implications

Brainstem reasoning supports attention to basic physiology: breathing, sleep, heart rate, medication effects, thyroid disease, anaemia and substance withdrawal can all mimic or amplify trauma symptoms. It also supports caution about purely psychological formulations of symptoms such as collapse, numbness or inability to move during threat. These responses may reflect conserved defensive systems rather than weakness or unwillingness.

2.9 Cerebellar contributions

Structure

The cerebellum lies behind the brainstem and beneath the occipital lobes. It has a highly folded cortex, deep nuclei (dentate, interposed and fastigial), and extensive connections with the cerebral cortex via the pons and thalamus, and with the spinal cord via the brainstem. Its traditional association is with motor coordination, balance and motor learning. That association is correct but incomplete.

Functional topography

Stoodley and Schmahmann's activation-likelihood meta-analysis of neuroimaging studies found evidence for functional topography within the human cerebellum. Sensorimotor tasks activated the anterior lobe, particularly lobule V and adjacent lobule VI, with additional foci in lobule VIII. Language and verbal working memory engaged lobule VI and Crus I; spatial tasks engaged lobule VI; executive tasks engaged lobules VI, Crus I and VIIB; emotional processing engaged lobules VI, Crus I and medial VII. The posterior lobe was consistently involved in higher-level tasks, consistent with the proposal that distinct cerebellar regions participate in cerebro-cerebellar loops with motor, cognitive and affective cortical areas.

Why this matters for trauma

The cerebellum is not a primary trauma structure, and claims that it "stores trauma" should be treated with scepticism. Its relevance is indirect but real. Cerebellar loops contribute to timing, prediction, error-based learning and the regulation of autonomic and emotional responses. Cerebellar dysfunction can produce symptoms—dizziness, tremor, unsteadiness, abnormal eye movements—that overlap with dissociation and anxiety and that require neurological assessment. Trauma-informed clinicians should be able to recognise when a presentation needs medical review rather than assuming a psychological cause.

The cerebellum also illustrates a broader lesson. A structure can be meaningfully involved in a process without being the site of a disorder. The question is always functional: what computation does this region contribute, under what conditions, and how would we know?

2.10 Large-scale brain networks

From regions to networks

The human brain is organised into large-scale intrinsic connectivity networks—sets of regions that show correlated activity at rest and co-activate across tasks. Three networks have been particularly influential in psychiatry. The central executive network (CEN), anchored in dorsolateral prefrontal and posterior parietal cortex, supports working memory and goal-directed control. The default mode network (DMN), anchored in medial prefrontal cortex, posterior cingulate and angular gyrus, supports self-referential thought, autobiographical memory and social cognition (Menon, 2023). The salience network (SN),

anchored in anterior insula and dorsal anterior cingulate, detects biologically significant events and coordinates switching between CEN and DMN.

Menon's triple network model proposes that many psychiatric conditions involve aberrant salience mapping and impaired access, engagement or disengagement of these networks. In PTSD, studies report altered within-network and between-network connectivity, particularly involving DMN, SN and prefrontal-limbic circuits. These findings are promising but heterogeneous. Connectivity estimates depend on preprocessing, motion correction, atlas choice and analysis strategy; test–retest reliability varies across regions; and group differences are often small relative to individual variation.

What network findings can and cannot establish

A network finding can show that regions covary differently between groups. It cannot show that a network is "overactive" in a person, that a specific thought caused a specific connectivity pattern, or that altering connectivity will relieve symptoms. Network language is nonetheless valuable because it moves the field away from single-region localisation and towards a systems view in which threat detection, memory, interoception and regulation are distributed.

For clinical teaching, the most useful implication is that trauma-related distress is not produced by one faulty node. It is produced by a system that has learned, in a particular body and environment, to prioritise threat. That formulation opens multiple points of intervention—sleep, safety, relationships, meaning, avoidance, physiological regulation—without pretending that any one of them is the whole answer.

Synthesis: from anatomy to formulation

Table 2.1 summarises the structures discussed in this chapter, the processes in which they are most plausibly involved, and the limits that should accompany any clinical or research claim.

Table 2.1. Structures, plausible processes and interpretive limits

Structure or system	Plausible processes	Interpretive limits
Amygdala	Threat detection, Pavlovian fear learning, salience, avoidance	Small and heterogeneous; rodent microcircuits do not map directly onto human symptoms
Hippocampal formation	Declarative and contextual memory, relational binding, spatial navigation	Volume findings are associational; direction and specificity uncertain
Prefrontal cortex	Working memory, inhibition, reappraisal, extinction recall	Acute stress effects are state-dependent; chronic changes are not fixed deficits
Insula	Interoception, salience, emotional awareness	Interoceptive tasks measure different constructs; strong awareness claims are contested
Anterior cingulate	Integration of negative affect, pain and cognitive control	Overlap across domains means activation alone cannot identify a process
Brainstem and PAG	Arousal, autonomic control, defensive behaviour, sleep	Animal-derived defensive columns are not rigid human subtypes
Cerebellum	Timing, prediction, motor and cognitive loops	Indirect relevance to trauma; not a trauma store
Large-scale networks	Distributed coordination of cognition, salience and self-reference	Connectivity depends on analysis choices; group differences are not diagnoses

Table 2.2. Levels of analysis and what each can support

Level	Typical methods	What it can support	What it cannot establish alone
Molecular and cellular	Assays, cell culture, animal models	Mechanisms under controlled conditions	Direct translation to a person's experience
Circuit and systems	Lesions, electrophysiology, optogenetics, imaging	Necessary or sufficient involvement in a task	A diagnosis or a causal life history
Behaviour and function	Interviews, questionnaires, task performance	Functional impact and meaning	Underlying mechanism
Social and implementation	Qualitative, mixed-methods, policy evaluation	Acceptability, access, equity, feasibility	Biological mechanism

Measurement and interpretation

Anatomical claims are only as good as the measurements behind them. Three distinctions are essential.

First, **reliability is not validity**. A measure can be highly reproducible and still not index the construct it is said to index. Amygdala reactivity on fMRI can be reliable across sessions and still reflect arousal, attention, novelty or movement as much as fear.

Second, **group differences are not individual diagnoses**. Most trauma neuroscience compares group means. The distributions overlap substantially, and a threshold that separates groups in a study is rarely suitable for clinical use.

Third, **statistical significance is not clinical utility**. A small association in a large sample may be precise and still useless for deciding what to do for a patient. Conversely, a clinically important effect may fail to reach significance in an underpowered study.

These distinctions should be applied consistently, including to findings that support a favourite theory. The field has a history of overinterpreting each new technique—phrenology, lesion localisation, early PET, candidate genes, and now machine-learning prediction. Each technique added something real; each was also asked to carry more meaning than it could bear.

Cultural and international perspectives

Anatomical knowledge is universal in the sense that human brains share a basic plan. The interpretation of trauma is not. Culture shapes which events are disclosed, which symptoms are salient, how distress is expressed in the body, who is consulted, and what recovery is expected to look like. In many settings, stigma, gender norms, legal status, migration, poverty and the availability of services influence whether a person presents at all.

Cross-cultural research also raises measurement questions. Instruments developed in one language may not be equivalent in another; translation is not validation. Biological measures may be affected by nutrition, infection, medication, sleep and chronic stress in ways that differ across settings. Findings from high-income countries should not be assumed to generalise, and multinational studies should involve local investigators, test measurement equivalence and report constraints honestly.

For the Nigerian and wider African contexts in which this programme is taught, these issues are not peripheral. The evidence base for many trauma interventions was developed elsewhere, and implementation must reckon with workforce shortages, out-of-pocket costs, traditional and religious healing systems, and the role of family and community in recovery. A neurobiological account that ignores these realities will be technically correct and practically useless.

Professional practice

Neuroanatomical knowledge should improve explanation, assessment and referral—not expand the scope of practice beyond qualification.

- **Explain without reducing.** Describe what is known about threat responses in plain language, and state clearly what is not known. Avoid phrases such as "your amygdala is damaged" or "your brain is stuck".
- **Assess before interpreting.** Rule out medical, neurological, pharmacological and substance-related causes of symptoms that resemble trauma responses.
- **Respect the limits of tests.** Do not order imaging, genetic testing or biomarkers for the purpose of "proving" trauma. There is no established clinical indication for these tests in routine PTSD assessment.

- **Use anatomy to generate hypotheses, not conclusions.** A formulation should integrate biological, psychological, social and cultural information and should remain revisable.
- **Protect data.** Brain images, genetic information and clinical records are sensitive. Collect only what is needed, explain retention and sharing, and comply with local law.

Ethics and data governance

Trauma neuroscience carries specific ethical risks. Biological language can stigmatise, imply permanence or shift responsibility from circumstances to individuals. Research can re-traumatise participants, generate incidental findings, or create expectations of clinical benefit that cannot be met. Genetic and neuroimaging data can be re-identifiable and may reveal information about relatives who did not consent.

Good practice includes proportionate collection, secure storage, clear limits on secondary use, accessible explanations, and a plan for incidental findings. Community involvement in design and interpretation is not a formality; it improves the questions asked and the likelihood that findings are used responsibly. Where research is conducted in under-resourced settings, partnerships should build local capacity rather than extract data.

Policy implications

Policy should convert evidence into proportionate, reviewable action. A responsible policy states the problem, population, mechanism, resources, accountable body, implementation plan, indicators and review date. Neuroscience can support investment in prevention, mental healthcare, sleep, occupational safety, maternal and child health, disaster response and research infrastructure. It should not be used to justify surveillance, exclusion, compulsory testing or discrimination when clinical utility and fairness have not been demonstrated.

Policy also has to reckon with uncertainty. A government that waits for definitive neuroscience before acting will fail people; a government that treats preliminary findings as settled will waste resources and may cause harm. The practical task is to act on the best available evidence while building in evaluation and review.

Composite case study

A regional disaster affected several communities after severe flooding and infrastructure failure. A multidisciplinary team observed sleep disruption, heightened startle, grief, pain, displacement, interrupted medication and reduced access to care. The team considered amygdala-dependent threat learning, hippocampal contextual processing, insular interoception, prefrontal regulation and brainstem arousal, but avoided assuming that every response represented a disorder. It created a stepped pathway combining safety, physical healthcare, practical assistance, family contact, psychological first aid, screening only where referral was available, and specialist treatment for persistent impairment. Researchers proposed optional longitudinal measurement, with separate consent, secure data handling, community oversight and feedback of aggregate findings.

The case illustrates a general point. Neurobiological knowledge gains practical value when it supports humane decisions and remains connected to social conditions. The team did not need to know each person's amygdala activity to design a better pathway. It needed to know enough about threat, sleep, memory and regulation to ask the right questions and to avoid harm.

Local composite case study

In a fictional Nigerian teaching hospital, an adult attended after a road traffic collision and later reported nightmares, bodily alarm, poor concentration, pain and fear of travelling. The clinician reviewed injury, medication, sleep, substance use, prior health, current safety, social support and functional change. The formulation used amygdala-dependent threat learning, hippocampal contextual memory, interoceptive signals and prefrontal regulation as possible explanatory concepts, not as proof of diagnosis. The team provided plain-language education, coordinated medical and psychological review, agreed measurable goals, and arranged follow-up.

A student research group considered studying the pathway but first examined language validity, transport barriers, phone access, follow-up loss, and the danger of collecting biological samples without clear clinical or research value. Their caution is part of the science, not an obstacle to it.

Worked example

A learner must decide whether a reported association between hippocampal volume and trauma symptoms supports a causal claim.

State the exposure, outcome, population and timing.

Identify the design and whether temporal order is established.

Examine measurement reliability and validity, including scanner and segmentation choices.

List plausible confounders: age, sex, education, alcohol use, depression, sleep, medication, medical illness and socioeconomic adversity.

Inspect effect size and uncertainty, not only the p value.

Ask whether the finding replicated and whether the comparison group was appropriate.

Restate the conclusion at the level the evidence supports.

A defensible conclusion will usually describe an association in a defined population and specify what design would strengthen causal inference. It will not say that trauma shrank the hippocampus in a particular patient.

Review and discussion questions

Why is it misleading to describe the amygdala as the brain's "fear centre"? What would be a more accurate formulation?

Explain the difference between grey-matter volume, white-matter integrity and functional connectivity. What does each measure, and what does it not measure?

How does the cephalic flexure affect the use of dorsal, ventral, rostral and caudal in neuroanatomy?

What evidence would be required to show that a brain region causes a PTSD symptom rather than merely correlating with it?

Why do group-level imaging findings have limited value for diagnosing an individual?

How should a clinician respond to a patient who asks whether a scan can prove that they have trauma?

What are the ethical risks of researching trauma neurobiology in a low-resource setting, and how can they be reduced?

How might cultural context change the interpretation of bodily symptoms that are assumed to be interoceptive?

Research assignments

- Design a study that could distinguish pre-existing hippocampal differences from trauma-related change. Specify sampling, timing, comparison group and analysis.
- Critically appraise one meta-analysis of amygdala or prefrontal findings in PTSD. Report effect sizes, heterogeneity, publication bias and the limits of the included designs.
- Write a protocol for a cross-cultural validation of an interoception measure, including translation, cognitive interviewing and measurement invariance.
- Propose a study of defensive responses in humans that respects the ethical limits on inducing threat. Explain what the study could and could not conclude.

Chapter summary

This chapter described the anatomical systems most often implicated in threat, memory and regulation. The amygdala supports threat learning and salience, the hippocampal formation supports declarative and contextual memory, the prefrontal cortex supports working memory and regulation, the insula supports interoception, the anterior cingulate integrates affective and cognitive demands, the brainstem organises arousal and defensive behaviour, and the cerebellum contributes to timing and prediction. Large-scale networks coordinate these systems.

The central lesson is not anatomical memorisation but calibrated inference. Each structure participates in many processes; each method answers a narrow question; each finding is embedded in a design, a sample and an analysis. Doctoral-level practice requires the discipline to state what the evidence supports, to preserve what remains uncertain, and to design the next question so that uncertainty is reduced rather than disguised.

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Brain Development Across the Lifespan and Developmental Timing of Trauma

Chapter 3

In this chapter

Learning objectives 54
Introduction 54
3.1 Prenatal neural development 55
3.2 Infancy and early caregiving 55
3.3 Childhood synaptic refinement 56
3.4 Adolescent maturation 57
3.5 Adult plasticity 57
3.6 Ageing and cumulative stress 58
3.7 Sensitive periods 58
3.8 Attachment-related regulation 59
3.9 Developmental adversity 59
3.10 Lifespan recovery 60
Synthesis 60
Composite case study 61
Review and discussion questions 61
Research assignments 62
Chapter summary 62
References 62

Central question. Why does the same adversity produce different outcomes at different ages, and what does developmental evidence actually license us to say about a person?

Learning objectives

- describe the principal events of prenatal and postnatal brain development;
- explain why timing, duration and repetition of adversity matter biologically;
- distinguish sensitive periods from critical periods, and evidence from inference;
- evaluate claims that early adversity causes permanent brain damage;
- apply developmental reasoning to assessment, education and service design.

Introduction

Development is not a single process that switches on at birth and off at maturity. It is a sequence of overlapping windows in which experience shapes structure and function at different rates. The prenatal period is dominated by cell proliferation, migration and the initial wiring of circuits. Infancy and early childhood are dominated by rapid synaptogenesis and activity-dependent pruning. Adolescence involves the maturation of association cortex and of the dopamine system, alongside hormonal change. Adulthood retains substantial plasticity, and ageing brings cumulative exposure and declining repair capacity.

Trauma intersects this sequence unevenly. The same event—a violent assault, a bereavement, displacement—arrives at a brain at a particular stage of myelination, receptor expression and social dependence. That is why developmental timing is one of the most important variables in trauma research, and one of the most poorly measured. Most studies record the age at assessment, not the age at exposure; many record a single exposure category, not its chronicity or the presence of a safe caregiver.

This chapter describes what is reasonably well established, separates that from what is inferred, and shows how developmental reasoning should change clinical and educational practice. It also states the limits clearly, because claims about "damaged developing brains" have been used to justify pessimism, stigma and fatalism that the evidence does not support.

A note on language. *"Sensitive period" is preferable to "critical period" for most human developmental phenomena. A sensitive period is a window of heightened plasticity during which experience has a particularly strong effect; it does not mean that later experience has no effect. Critical periods, in the strict sense, are windows after which a function cannot develop—as in early visual deprivation—and are rare in the domains that concern trauma clinicians.*

3.1 Prenatal neural development

The neural plate forms in the third week of gestation, folds into the neural tube, and closes by about the fourth week. Failures of closure produce conditions such as spina bifida and anencephaly. From the neural tube, three vesicles emerge—prosencephalon, mesencephalon and rhombencephalon—which subdivide into the adult forebrain, midbrain and hindbrain (Chapter 2).

Neurons are generated in the ventricular zone and migrate outward along radial glia to form the cortical plate. Migration follows an inside-out sequence: deeper cortical layers are generated first, superficial layers later. Synapse formation begins before birth, and the foetus responds to sound, movement and maternal physiology. The intrauterine environment is therefore already an environment: maternal nutrition, infection, alcohol, drugs, stress hormones and placental function influence the trajectory.

Human evidence on prenatal stress comes largely from natural experiments and cohort studies. Maternal stress and anxiety during pregnancy are associated with altered infant reactivity and, in some cohorts, with differences in hippocampal and amygdala structure. These are associations, entangled with genetics, socioeconomic conditions and postnatal care. They establish plausibility, not a deterministic pathway from a stressful pregnancy to a disordered child.

3.2 Infancy and early caregiving

The infant brain is not a blank slate; it arrives with organised reflexes, sensory biases and a capacity for social engagement. What it lacks is calibration. Caregiving provides that calibration: repeated cycles of distress, response and soothing teach the infant that arousal is survivable and that another person can help regulate it. This is the biological core of attachment, and it is why neglect can be as damaging as abuse.

Synaptogenesis peaks in the first years, particularly in sensory and language regions. Myelination proceeds rapidly in sensorimotor pathways. The hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal axis matures partly through interaction with caregivers; in rodents, early handling alters stress reactivity in adulthood, and in humans, sensitive care is associated with more regulated cortisol patterns.

Shonkoff and Garner (2012) distinguish positive stress, tolerable stress and toxic stress. Positive stress is brief and buffered by supportive relationships. Tolerable stress is severe but occurs within a context of adequate adult support, allowing recovery. Toxic stress is prolonged, severe and unbuffered, and is the condition under which stress systems may be chronically activated with consequences for learning, behaviour and health. The distinction is useful because it locates the problem not only in the event but in the availability of protection.

3.3 Childhood synaptic refinement

As childhood proceeds, the brain prunes. Synapses that are used are stabilised; those that are not are eliminated. This is not a loss of potential but a specialisation: pruning makes circuits faster and more efficient. It is experience-dependent, which means that the environment selects which connections survive.

Language provides the clearest example. Children exposed to a language in early childhood acquire native phonology and grammar with an ease that declines markedly after puberty. Deaf children deprived of accessible language in early childhood show lasting differences in language and cognitive outcomes, even when they learn a signed language later. This is a genuine sensitive period with real policy consequences: access to language is a right, not an educational luxury.

Adversity during this period interacts with refinement. Chronic threat may bias pruning toward circuits that support vigilance at the expense of those that support deliberate control. Teicher and Samson (2016) synthesise imaging evidence linking childhood maltreatment to altered development of the hippocampus, corpus callosum, anterior cingulate and orbitofrontal cortex, together with heightened amygdala reactivity and diminished reward response. Effect sizes are moderate, samples are often small, and the findings are heterogeneous—but the pattern is consistent with a system that has prioritised threat detection.

3.4 Adolescent maturation

Adolescence is a period of profound reorganisation, not a period of "immaturity" in the pejorative sense. Subcortical reward and threat systems mature earlier than prefrontal control systems, producing a developmental mismatch that is normal and adaptive in many contexts. Sensation-seeking and peer affiliation support independence. The same mismatch makes adolescents vulnerable to risk and, in the presence of threat, to persistent fear learning.

Sex hormones shape this period. Puberty organises and activates differences in stress reactivity, and the onset of depression and anxiety is markedly more common in adolescent girls. Sleep timing shifts, and chronic sleep restriction impairs learning and emotional regulation. Substance use, which frequently begins in adolescence, alters the same circuits.

Trauma during adolescence often occurs in the context of peer violence, sexual assault, bereavement, displacement and family conflict. These exposures rarely occur alone. A developmental formulation therefore asks not only "what happened?" but "what else was happening, and who was available to help?"

3.5 Adult plasticity

The adult brain is not fixed. It continues to form synapses, modify myelin, and reorganise cortical maps in response to practice and injury. Adult neurogenesis in the dentate gyrus remains an area of active investigation; the evidence for substantial adult human neurogenesis has been contested, and its functional significance is uncertain. Claims that a particular intervention "regrows" hippocampal neurons in adults should be treated cautiously.

Learning in adulthood can be rapid and durable. Psychotherapy, skills training and rehabilitation all exploit adult plasticity. The difference from early development is not the absence of change but its conditions: adult plasticity is often slower, more dependent on attention and practice, and constrained by established patterns.

For trauma, this means recovery is possible at any age, and it also means that the habits and interpretations formed after trauma—avoidance, vigilance, self-blame—are themselves learned and can be relearned. The clinical task is to create the conditions under which new learning is possible, not to wait for a developmental window to reopen.

For a lifespan account of how stress hormones shape brain and behaviour, see Lupien et al. (2009).

3.6 Ageing and cumulative stress

Ageing brings changes in vascular health, sleep architecture, inflammatory tone and cognitive speed. Chronic stress across the lifespan accumulates: McEwen's (1998) concept of allostatic load describes the cost of repeatedly mounting stress responses, reflected in measures such as blood pressure, waist circumference, cortisol, inflammatory markers and cholesterol.

Older adults with trauma histories may present with symptoms that are attributed to ageing: sleep disturbance, pain, memory complaints, irritability, withdrawal. These deserve assessment rather than dismissal. At the same time, not every late-life difficulty is trauma-related, and over-attribution can delay diagnosis of treatable conditions such as depression, thyroid disease, vitamin deficiency or dementia.

There is evidence that trauma reminders can become salient again in later life, when roles change, spouses die, or retirement removes structure. This is not evidence that the trauma "returned" biologically; it is evidence that coping depends on resources that can be lost.

3.7 Sensitive periods

Sensitive periods are best understood as windows of elevated plasticity rather than gates that close absolutely. The evidence is strongest for sensory systems and language. For stress regulation and threat learning, the evidence is more indirect: developmental timing clearly matters, but the precise windows, mechanisms and individual variability are not established.

Three cautions follow. First, animal models of sensitive periods typically involve controlled deprivation or stress, which differs from human adversity embedded in families and communities. Second, retrospective reports of the age at which abuse began are subject to recall error and are commonly used as if they were exact. Third, findings of "sensitive periods" in group data do not identify a threshold age for an individual.

A developmental history should therefore record timing as carefully as possible—age at onset, duration, frequency, and the presence of protective relationships—while avoiding the implication that an event at a particular age has fixed a person's future.

The distinction between sensitive and critical periods, and the evidence that early adversity alters developmental trajectories, are reviewed by Lupien et al. (2009) and Shonkoff and Garner (2012).

3.8 Attachment-related regulation

Attachment is a relational system, not a personality type. It describes how a child organises behaviour toward a caregiver under conditions of threat. Secure attachment develops when care is available and responsive; insecure patterns develop when it is inconsistent, rejecting or frightening. Disorganised attachment is associated with frightening or frightened caregiving and with later risk, though it is not itself a diagnosis.

The neurobiology of attachment overlaps with the circuits of threat and reward. Caregiving signals—voice, touch, gaze—engage oxytocin and opioid systems, reduce amygdala reactivity, and support the development of prefrontal regulation. These findings are often oversimplified in popular accounts. Oxytocin is not a "love hormone"; it has context-dependent effects that can include increased in-group favouritism and defensive aggression.

For practice, the important point is that regulation is first interpersonal and only later internalised. A child who has not experienced reliable co-regulation may need explicit, repeated help to tolerate arousal. Blaming such a child for "poor regulation" misreads the developmental evidence.

3.9 Developmental adversity

Adverse childhood experiences research established that cumulative exposure is common and associated with a graded increase in health risk. Felitti and colleagues (1998) reported that adults with four or more categories of childhood exposure had substantially elevated risks of substance misuse, depression, suicide attempt and physical disease. The study has been enormously influential and has shaped policy, but it is cross-sectional and retrospective, and it does not establish causation for any individual.

Later work has refined the picture. Adversity is not a single exposure but a constellation that includes deprivation (absence of expected input) and threat (presence of harmful input), which may have different developmental consequences. Poverty, discrimination, neighbourhood violence and displacement are forms of structural adversity that operate

alongside family-level events. Interventions that address material conditions may be as biologically relevant as those that address individual symptoms.

Estimates of the proportion of childhood-onset disorder attributable to maltreatment come from Teicher and Samson (2016); the original dose–response findings are reported by Felitti et al. (1998).

3.10 Lifespan recovery

Recovery is not a return to a pre-trauma state; it is the development of a life that is livable after it. Developmental evidence supports several principles. Safety and predictability matter. Relationships matter. Sleep matters. Access to language, education and economic participation matters. And timing matters—not because windows close, but because the earlier the support, the less secondary harm accumulates.

The most defensible claim is therefore modest and hopeful: early adversity increases risk and shapes trajectories, and it does not determine outcomes. The factors that modify risk—safe relationships, stable housing, access to care, community support—are precisely the factors that policy can influence.

Synthesis

Table 3.1 summarises developmental periods, dominant processes, and the aspects of trauma response most plausibly linked to each.

Table 3.1. Developmental periods and trauma-relevant processes

Period	Dominant processes	Plausible trauma-relevant effects	Evidence strength
Prenatal	Neurogenesis, migration, initial wiring	Altered reactivity; small structural differences in some cohorts	Moderate, confounded
Infancy	Synaptogenesis, HPA calibration	Dysregulated stress response where caregiving is unavailable	Moderate
Childhood	Pruning, myelination, language	Biased threat learning; altered hippocampal and prefrontal development	Moderate, heterogeneous
Adolescence	Prefrontal maturation, hormonal change	Heightened fear learning; risk exposure; sleep disruption	Moderate
Adulthood	Synaptic and myelin plasticity	Persistent avoidance and appraisal patterns; capacity for new learning	Strong for learning, weaker for structural change
Later life	Vascular and inflammatory change, cumulative load	Re-emergence of symptoms when resources diminish	Limited

Composite case study

A twelve-year-old is referred after two years of escalating conflict at home. The history reveals domestic violence, three school changes, and a mother who is herself unwell. The child is vigilant, sleeps badly, and has stopped attending football. A developmental formulation notes the chronicity of threat, the absence of a consistent protective adult, the loss of a valued activity, and the onset of puberty. It does not conclude that the child's brain is damaged. It identifies what would reduce threat, restore predictable adult support, protect sleep, and re-open a source of competence. The school is asked to provide a named adult and predictable routines. The mother is offered support in her own right.

Review and discussion questions

Why is "sensitive period" a better term than "critical period" for most trauma-related questions?

What does the concept of toxic stress add to a simple count of adverse events, and what does it risk obscuring?

How should a clinician record developmental timing without implying deterministic conclusions?

What are the policy implications of the language sensitive period for deaf children?

Why might adolescent risk-taking be better understood as adaptive than as a deficit?

What would a study need to do to distinguish pre-existing differences from adversity-related change?

Research assignments

- Design a prospective cohort study of childhood adversity that measures exposure timing, chronicity and protective relationships, and specify how attrition will be handled.
- Critically appraise the ACE literature: what can cumulative risk scores support, and what can they not?
- Propose an evaluation of a school-based intervention that aims to improve regulation without diagnosing children.

Chapter summary

Development is a sequence of overlapping windows in which experience shapes a brain that is already organised to learn from its environment. Timing matters, but it does not fix outcomes. The strongest evidence concerns the importance of safe, responsive relationships and of protection from chronic, unbuffered threat. Claims of permanent developmental damage exceed the evidence and can cause harm. A developmental formulation should be specific about what happened, when, for how long, and with whom—and should identify the conditions that would support recovery now.

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Cellular Neuroscience: Neurons, Glia, Myelin, and Neural Tissue Responses

Chapter 4

In this chapter

Learning objectives 65
Introduction 65
4.1 Cell theory and nervous tissue 65
4.2 Neuronal structure 66
4.3 Membrane potentials 66
4.4 Action potentials 67
4.5 Astrocytes 67
4.6 Microglial surveillance 68
4.7 Oligodendrocytes and myelin 69
4.8 Blood–brain barrier 69
4.9 Cellular stress responses 70
4.10 Cellular repair and adaptation 70
Synthesis 71
Composite case study 71
Review and discussion questions 71
Research assignments 72
Chapter summary 72
References 72

Central question. What happens inside and between cells when the nervous system responds to threat, and which of those events can be inferred from human evidence?

Learning objectives

- describe neuronal structure and the ionic basis of membrane and action potentials;
- explain the roles of astrocytes, microglia, oligodendrocytes and the blood–brain barrier;
- distinguish acute cellular stress responses from lasting injury;
- evaluate claims that trauma "damages" or "rewires" cells;
- relate cellular evidence to clinical and research questions.

Introduction

A textbook of trauma neurobiology can be written entirely at the level of circuits, but circuits are made of cells, and cells are where the mechanisms ultimately reside. Synaptic change, hormonal action, immune signalling and gene expression all converge on neurons and glia. Understanding this level prevents two opposite errors: treating the brain as an undifferentiated blob that "lights up", and treating molecular findings as though they explained a person's life.

This chapter describes the cellular machinery that matters most for traumatic stress: how neurons generate and transmit signals, how glia support and modulate them, how the blood–brain barrier regulates what reaches the tissue, and how cells respond to stress. It closes with the interpretive problem that dominates this literature: most of the strongest cellular evidence comes from animals, and the gap between a dendritic spine in a rodent and a symptom in a patient is wide.

> **A note on scale.** *A typical human brain contains roughly 86 billion neurons and a comparable number of glial cells, connected by an estimated 100 trillion synapses. No technique currently measures all of this in a living person. Every human method samples a proxy: blood flow, electrical fields, tissue volume, or post-mortem structure.*

4.1 Cell theory and nervous tissue

The cell theory holds that all living organisms are composed of cells, and that cells arise from existing cells. Its application to the brain was

delayed because neurons have extraordinarily complex shapes and were difficult to resolve with early microscopes. The work of Ramón y Cajal and others established the neuron doctrine: nerve cells are individual units that communicate at contacts rather than forming a continuous network.

Nervous tissue contains neurons and glia. Neurons are electrically excitable and transmit information; glia were long described as support cells but are now recognised as active participants in signalling, immune surveillance, myelination and the regulation of the extracellular environment. Nervous tissue also contains blood vessels, whose endothelial cells form the blood–brain barrier, and extracellular matrix, which influences how cells migrate and connect.

The cellular account given here follows standard neuroscience teaching; its stress-specific implications are summarised by Godoy et al. (2018).

4.2 Neuronal structure

A neuron has a cell body (soma), dendrites, an axon and presynaptic terminals. Dendrites receive input; the axon carries output; terminals release neurotransmitter onto the next cell. The axon hillock is where action potentials are typically initiated; the axon may be myelinated, which increases conduction velocity. Neurons are classified by morphology (pyramidal, stellate, bipolar), by neurotransmitter (glutamatergic, GABAergic, dopaminergic), and by projection pattern (local interneuron versus long-range projection neuron).

Cortical pyramidal cells are the principal output neurons of the cortex. Their apical dendrites extend toward the cortical surface, where they receive input from other cortical areas and from the thalamus. Their structure is plastic: dendritic spines, the small protrusions that host most excitatory synapses, change shape and number with learning and with stress. This is the structural basis of the claim that experience "shapes" the brain—though the changes are typically modest, reversible and regionally specific.

4.3 Membrane potentials

Neurons maintain a resting membrane potential of about −70 millivolts, inside relative to outside. The potential arises from selective permeability and from the unequal distribution of ions, principally sodium, potassium, chloride and calcium, maintained by pumps such as the sodium–potassium ATPase. At rest, the membrane is more

permeable to potassium than to sodium, so the resting potential sits near the potassium equilibrium potential.

Changes in permeability produce graded potentials. Excitatory inputs open cation channels and depolarise the membrane; inhibitory inputs open chloride or potassium channels and hyperpolarise it. These inputs sum over space and time at the axon hillock. If the summed depolarisation reaches threshold—around −55 millivolts—voltage-gated sodium channels open and an action potential is initiated.

This machinery matters clinically because many drugs act on it. Benzodiazepines enhance GABA-A receptor function; anticonvulsants block sodium channels; anaesthetics modulate ion channels and synaptic release. Trauma-related conditions are frequently treated with medications that act at this level, and understanding it clarifies both effects and adverse effects.

4.4 Action potentials

An action potential is a rapid, all-or-none change in membrane potential. Voltage-gated sodium channels open, sodium enters, and the membrane depolarises to about +40 millivolts. Sodium channels then inactivate, potassium channels open, and the membrane repolarises, often overshooting into a brief afterhyperpolarisation. The refractory period that follows limits firing frequency and ensures that the signal travels in one direction.

Action potentials propagate along the axon. In unmyelinated axons, propagation is continuous and relatively slow. In myelinated axons, the signal jumps between nodes of Ranvier—saltatory conduction—which is faster and more energy-efficient. Myelin therefore does not merely insulate; it determines the timing of signals, and timing is functionally important across distributed circuits.

Action potentials are not the whole story of neuronal communication. Many neurons also fire in rhythmic bursts, and subthreshold oscillations coordinate activity across regions. The gamma oscillations implicated in attention and memory, for example, depend on the precise interaction of excitatory and inhibitory cells.

4.5 Astrocytes

Astrocytes are the most abundant glial cells in the central nervous system. They extend processes that contact synapses, blood vessels and

other astrocytes. They regulate the extracellular concentration of ions and neurotransmitters, particularly glutamate, which they take up and convert to glutamine. They contribute to the blood–brain barrier, to metabolic support, and to synapse formation and elimination.

Astrocytes also participate in signalling. They respond to neurotransmitters with calcium transients and can release gliotransmitters that modulate neuronal excitability. The idea that astrocytes form a "tripartite synapse" alongside pre- and postsynaptic elements is influential, though its functional importance in humans is still being established.

In stress and inflammation, astrocytes become reactive: they change morphology, alter glutamate uptake, and release cytokines. This may be protective in the short term and harmful if sustained, because excess glutamate in the extracellular space can be excitotoxic. The balance between astrocytic protection and astrocytic contribution to injury is an active research question, not a settled one.

4.6 Microglial surveillance

Microglia are the resident immune cells of the central nervous system. They derive from yolk-sac progenitors and populate the brain before birth. In the healthy brain they are highly motile, continuously extending and retracting processes to survey the parenchyma. They phagocytose debris, prune surplus synapses during development, and respond to injury and infection.

Activation is not a single state. Microglia adopt a range of phenotypes depending on context, and the older M1/M2 classification is now regarded as an oversimplification. In chronic stress and in some psychiatric conditions, microglial activation has been reported, but human evidence in vivo is limited and methods for measuring it are indirect.

The relevance to trauma is plausible but not established at the level often claimed. Stress can increase inflammatory signalling, and inflammation can affect mood, sleep and behaviour. Whether microglia mediate a specific PTSD symptom in humans remains unknown. Claims that trauma "inflames the brain" should therefore be translated into the more accurate statement that stress is associated with immune changes, some of which may affect the central nervous system.

Microglial involvement in stress-related conditions is reviewed by Hori and Kim (2019).

4.7 Oligodendrocytes and myelin

Oligodendrocytes produce myelin in the central nervous system. Each oligodendrocyte myelinates multiple axon segments, and the thickness and length of myelin sheaths affect conduction velocity. Myelination continues into adulthood in association cortex, and it is activity-dependent: electrically active axons are preferentially myelinated.

Myelin plasticity is a relatively recent addition to the plasticity literature, which for decades focused almost exclusively on synapses. It offers a mechanism by which experience could alter the timing and synchrony of distributed circuits. Stress and social isolation have been reported to affect myelination in animal models, and diffusion imaging in humans shows associations between early adversity and white-matter microstructure.

These findings are important but easy to overread. Diffusion metrics are indirect, affected by crossing fibres, partial volume and water content, and do not measure myelin directly. A group difference in fractional anisotropy is not evidence that a person's myelin is damaged.

4.8 Blood–brain barrier

The blood–brain barrier is formed by tight junctions between endothelial cells of cerebral capillaries, supported by pericytes and astrocytic endfeet. It restricts the passage of many molecules while allowing selective transport of glucose, amino acids and other essentials. It protects the brain from toxins and pathogens and maintains a stable ionic environment.

Circumventricular organs, such as the area postrema and the organum vasculosum of the lamina terminalis, lack a complete barrier and allow the brain to sample circulating signals. This is one route by which peripheral inflammation and hormones influence central function.

The barrier is dynamic, not absolute. Stress, infection and inflammation can increase permeability, and some evidence suggests altered barrier function in psychiatric and neurodegenerative conditions. In trauma research, the barrier matters conceptually because it explains how peripheral immune signals can reach the brain, and practically because it constrains which drugs can be used to treat central conditions.

4.9 Cellular stress responses

Cells respond to stress through conserved programmes. Heat-shock proteins help refold damaged proteins. The unfolded protein response adjusts protein synthesis in the endoplasmic reticulum. Autophagy removes damaged organelles. Antioxidant systems neutralise reactive oxygen species. When these systems are overwhelmed, cells may undergo apoptosis or necrosis.

Neurons are particularly vulnerable to energy failure and excitotoxicity because of their high metabolic demand and their dependence on tight ionic regulation. Ischaemia, hypoglycaemia, prolonged seizures and severe stress can all trigger cascades that begin with glutamate release and calcium influx and end with cell death.

In trauma, the relevant question is usually not whether cells die but whether they adapt. Glucocorticoids, catecholamines and inflammatory mediators alter gene expression, receptor density and dendritic structure. These adaptations can be protective—sharpening vigilance during danger—or costly when sustained. The distinction between adaptation and injury is central, and it is often blurred in popular accounts.

For a review of how stress mediators affect cellular and synaptic function, see Godoy et al. (2018) and McEwen (1998).

4.10 Cellular repair and adaptation

Repair in the central nervous system is limited but real. Axons in the peripheral nervous system can regenerate; those in the central nervous system generally cannot, largely because of inhibitory molecules in myelin and the glial scar. Synapses, however, are continually remodelled, and function can be restored through reorganisation as well as through repair.

Rehabilitation exploits this. Constraint-induced movement therapy, for example, improves function after stroke by forcing use of the affected limb, driving cortical reorganisation. Cognitive and behavioural therapies may work through analogous learning mechanisms, strengthening some circuits and weakening others.

The clinical implication is that the adult brain retains substantial capacity for change. The corollary is that change requires conditions: attention, repetition, safety and sleep. A cell that is chronically stressed, sleep-deprived and inflamed is not well placed to learn.

Synthesis

Table 4.1 summarises the principal cell types and their relevance to traumatic stress.

Table 4.1. Cell types and trauma-relevant functions

Cell type	Principal functions	Trauma-relevant relevance	Evidence limits
Neurons	Excitability, synaptic transmission, plasticity	Fear learning, extinction, regulation	Human measures are indirect
Astrocytes	Ion and glutamate homeostasis, barrier support, synapse regulation	Excitotoxicity risk, neuroimmune signalling	Mostly animal evidence
Microglia	Immune surveillance, synaptic pruning, phagocytosis	Inflammation, synaptic remodelling	Phenotypes oversimplified
Oligodendrocytes	Myelination, conduction timing	Circuit timing, white-matter findings	Diffusion measures indirect
Endothelial cells	Blood–brain barrier	Peripheral–central signalling	Human measurement invasive

Composite case study

A patient with chronic pain and PTSD reports that her symptoms worsen after infections. A cellular formulation would consider inflammatory signalling, sleep disruption, medication effects and pain sensitisation rather than asserting that infection "inflames her trauma". The practical response is to treat the infection, review sleep and analgesia, and monitor symptoms without attributing them to a single mechanism.

Review and discussion questions

Why is the resting membrane potential negative, and what determines the threshold for an action potential?

What does myelin do besides insulating axons?

How convincing is the evidence that microglia mediate trauma-related symptoms in humans?

Why are diffusion imaging findings often overinterpreted?

Distinguish cellular adaptation from cellular injury with an example of each.

What would a study need to show before claiming that a psychological intervention changed synaptic structure?

Research assignments

- Design an animal study of chronic stress and myelination, specifying controls for handling, housing and sex differences.
- Critically appraise one human study linking inflammation to PTSD, noting the limitations of peripheral markers.
- Write a plain-language explanation of the action potential for a non-specialist audience, with one accurate caveat about what it does not explain.

Chapter summary

Neurons generate and transmit electrical signals through ion channels and synaptic release. Glia regulate the environment, modulate signalling, myelinate axons and mount immune responses. The blood–brain barrier governs what reaches the tissue. Cells adapt to stress through changes in gene expression, receptor density and structure, and these adaptations can be protective or costly. Most detailed cellular evidence comes from animals, and the translation to human experience is indirect. Cellular knowledge should therefore inform mechanism and caution in equal measure.

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Molecular Neuroscience and Synaptic Transmission in Traumatic Stress

Chapter 5

In this chapter

Learning objectives 74
Introduction 74
5.1 Molecular organisation of synapses 75
5.2 Electrical and chemical signalling 75
5.3 Vesicle release 76
5.4 Receptor families 76
5.5 Second-messenger systems 77
5.6 Gene transcription 77
5.7 Protein synthesis 78
5.8 Oxidative stress 78
5.9 Mitochondrial regulation 79
5.10 Molecular adaptation after stress 79
Synthesis 79
Composite case study 80
Review and discussion questions 80
Research assignments 81
Chapter summary 81
References 81

Central question. How do molecules, receptors and gene expression produce the synaptic changes associated with threat learning, and what can human studies infer about them?

Learning objectives

- describe the molecular architecture of the synapse and the cycle of neurotransmitter release;
- distinguish ionotropic from metabotropic receptors and explain second-messenger signalling;
- explain how experience alters gene transcription and protein synthesis;
- evaluate the roles of oxidative stress and mitochondrial function;
- distinguish molecular mechanism from molecular speculation in trauma research.

Introduction

Synapses are where computation becomes chemistry. A presynaptic terminal converts an electrical signal into vesicle fusion and neurotransmitter release; the postsynaptic membrane converts that chemical signal back into electrical or biochemical change. Around this core, an elaborate machinery of scaffolding proteins, receptors, kinases and transcription factors determines whether a synapse strengthens, weakens or persists.

Trauma research has borrowed heavily from this machinery. Long-term potentiation and long-term depression provide models of learning; reconsolidation research suggests memories can become labile; stress hormones alter receptor trafficking and gene expression. These are genuine mechanisms, studied in detail. The interpretive challenge is that most of the detailed work is in reduced preparations and animals, and the gap to a human symptom is large.

This chapter describes the molecular events most relevant to traumatic stress, with attention to what each finding does and does not establish.

> **A note on terminology.** *"Molecular" findings often refer to mRNA or protein levels in tissue, not to activity in a living human brain. A change in receptor expression after stress is a real biological observation; it is not a measurement of a thought, a feeling or a diagnosis.*

5.1 Molecular organisation of synapses

A chemical synapse has three components: the presynaptic terminal, the synaptic cleft (about 20 nanometres wide), and the postsynaptic density. The terminal contains synaptic vesicles filled with neurotransmitter, anchored to the cytoskeleton and poised for release. The active zone is the site of fusion, organised by proteins including RIM, Munc13 and the SNARE complex.

The postsynaptic density is a dense protein network containing receptors, scaffolding molecules such as PSD-95, signalling enzymes and cytoskeletal linkers. Its composition determines which receptors are present, how they cluster, and how they respond to activity. Changes in the postsynaptic density are one mechanism by which synaptic strength is regulated.

Astrocytic processes often surround the synapse, forming the tripartite arrangement described in Chapter 4. They remove neurotransmitter, buffer ions and release modulators, and thus shape the signal that the postsynaptic cell receives.

5.2 Electrical and chemical signalling

Signals travel within neurons electrically and between neurons chemically. An action potential arriving at the terminal depolarises it, opens voltage-gated calcium channels, and triggers vesicle fusion. Neurotransmitter diffuses across the cleft and binds to receptors on the postsynaptic membrane.

Ionotropic receptors are ligand-gated ion channels: binding opens a pore and produces a fast electrical response lasting milliseconds. Metabotropic receptors are G-protein-coupled and produce slower, longer-lasting effects through second messengers. The same neurotransmitter can act through both types; glutamate, for example, acts at ionotropic AMPA and NMDA receptors and at metabotropic glutamate receptors.

This dual organisation allows a single transmitter to serve fast signalling and slow modulation. It also explains why drugs targeting a transmitter system can have diverse effects: blocking a receptor may alter rapid transmission, sustained excitability, or both.

5.3 Vesicle release

Synaptic vesicles are filled with neurotransmitter by specific transporters. They dock at the active zone, become primed, and fuse with the membrane in response to calcium entry. Fusion is mediated by SNARE proteins—syntaxin, SNAP-25 and synaptobrevin—which form a complex that pulls the vesicle and plasma membranes together.

Release has multiple modes. Synchronous release produces fast transmission. Asynchronous release, which occurs after the initial calcium transient, can prolong signalling. Spontaneous release occurs without action potentials and contributes to the maintenance of synaptic connections.

After fusion, vesicle membrane is retrieved by endocytosis and recycled. This cycle must be tightly regulated, because sustained high-frequency firing would otherwise deplete the terminal. Toxins that cleave SNARE proteins—botulinum and tetanus toxins—abolish release, which is why they are both dangerous and clinically useful.

5.4 Receptor families

Glutamate receptors mediate most excitatory transmission. AMPA receptors produce fast depolarisation and are the workhorses of synaptic transmission. NMDA receptors are permeable to calcium and are blocked by magnesium at resting potential; they open when the membrane is depolarised and glutamate is bound, making them coincidence detectors. This property underlies their role in long-term potentiation. Kainate receptors modulate transmission and excitability.

GABA receptors mediate most fast inhibition. GABA-A receptors are chloride channels modulated by benzodiazepines, barbiturates and alcohol. GABA-B receptors are metabotropic and produce slower inhibition through potassium channels.

Other families matter for trauma. Noradrenergic alpha-1 and beta receptors mediate arousal and are implicated in stress effects on prefrontal cortex. Dopamine D1 receptors modulate working memory in an inverted-U fashion, so that both too little and too much signalling impair performance (Arnsten, 2009). Serotonin receptors modulate mood, sleep and appetite, though the relationship between serotonin and depression is more complex than early theories suggested. Cannabinoid CB1 receptors regulate neurotransmitter release and are involved in fear extinction and stress coping.

5.5 Second-messenger systems

Metabotropic receptors activate intracellular cascades. A common pathway involves G proteins that stimulate adenylate cyclase, producing cyclic AMP, which activates protein kinase A. Another involves phospholipase C, producing inositol trisphosphate and diacylglycerol, which mobilise calcium and activate protein kinase C.

These cascades amplify signals and can produce lasting change by phosphorylating receptors, ion channels and transcription factors. The cAMP response element-binding protein (CREB) is a key node: phosphorylation of CREB recruits co-activators and drives transcription of genes involved in synaptic plasticity, including BDNF.

Stress engages these pathways directly. High catecholamine levels during stress activate cAMP and protein kinase C signalling in prefrontal cortex, weakening network connectivity and impairing working memory (Arnsten, 2009). The same signalling can strengthen amygdala function. This is a molecular account of the shift from reflective to reflexive control under threat.

5.6 Gene transcription

Experience changes gene expression. Transcription factors such as CREB, NF-κB and the glucocorticoid receptor bind to regulatory regions and alter the rate at which genes are transcribed into mRNA. This is how a transient signal can produce a durable change.

Epigenetic mechanisms regulate access to DNA. DNA methylation typically represses transcription when it occurs in gene promoters; histone acetylation generally increases it. These marks can be altered by experience, including stress, and can persist for some time. The most discussed example in trauma research is FKBP5, a co-chaperone of the glucocorticoid receptor. Early-life stress has been associated with altered FKBP5 methylation and with altered stress reactivity in adulthood.

The evidence is genuine but limited. Human epigenetic studies often use peripheral tissue—blood or saliva—because brain tissue is rarely available. Whether peripheral marks reflect brain marks is uncertain. Effects are small, samples are modest, and replication is incomplete. Claims that trauma is "written into the genome" overstate what has been shown.

5.7 Protein synthesis

Long-lasting synaptic change requires new protein synthesis. Blocking protein synthesis shortly after learning prevents the consolidation of long-term memory in many paradigms. This is the basis of the reconsolidation literature: after retrieval, a memory may become temporarily labile and require new protein synthesis to be restabilised (Nader et al., 2000).

Reconsolidation has attracted clinical interest because it suggests a window in which a traumatic memory could be modified. The evidence in humans is mixed. Some studies report that administering a beta-blocker or performing extinction training during the reconsolidation window reduces fear responses; others fail to replicate, and the boundary conditions—timing, strength of reactivation, age of memory—are not settled (Vervliet et al., 2013).

Protein synthesis is also required for the structural changes that accompany learning: new dendritic spines, altered receptor composition, and changes in presynaptic release probability. These changes are not permanent; they turn over, which is why maintenance matters.

5.8 Oxidative stress

Reactive oxygen species are normal products of metabolism and participate in signalling. When production exceeds antioxidant capacity, oxidative stress damages lipids, proteins and DNA, and can trigger cell death. The brain is vulnerable because of its high metabolic rate, high lipid content and relatively modest antioxidant defences.

Stress and inflammation can increase oxidative stress. In animal models, chronic stress is associated with oxidative damage in the hippocampus and prefrontal cortex, and antioxidant treatment can attenuate some behavioural effects. In humans, markers of oxidative stress are elevated in some psychiatric conditions, but the findings are non-specific and affected by diet, smoking, exercise and medication.

Claims that antioxidant supplements treat trauma-related conditions are not supported by adequate trials. The biological rationale is plausible; the clinical evidence is not there.

5.9 Mitochondrial regulation

Mitochondria generate ATP, buffer calcium, regulate apoptosis and participate in signalling. Neurons have high energy demands, particularly at synapses, and mitochondria are transported to sites of high activity. Mitochondrial dysfunction impairs synaptic function and increases vulnerability to excitotoxicity.

Chronic stress affects mitochondrial function. Glucocorticoids alter mitochondrial metabolism, and inflammatory mediators impair oxidative phosphorylation. In some studies, mitochondrial DNA copy number and respiratory capacity differ in people with stress-related conditions, but these findings are preliminary and methodologically demanding.

Mitochondria also participate in the response to psychological stress through their role in cortisol synthesis in the adrenal cortex, which is a reminder that the relevant biology is distributed across organs, not confined to the brain.

5.10 Molecular adaptation after stress

The molecular response to stress is adaptive in the short term and potentially costly when sustained. Acute catecholamine release sharpens attention and mobilises energy. Acute glucocorticoid release supports glucose availability and consolidates emotionally significant memory. Inflammatory signalling recruits immune defences.

When these systems remain activated, the consequences include impaired prefrontal function, altered hippocampal structure, increased amygdala reactivity, sleep disruption, insulin resistance and impaired immune function. This is the molecular version of allostatic load (McEwen, 1998).

The clinical implication is that interventions which restore the conditions for regulation—sleep, safety, exercise, social connection—act on the same systems that stress has perturbed. That does not make them "molecular treatments"; it means that molecular biology and everyday life are connected.

Synthesis

Table 5.1 summarises molecular processes and their relevance to traumatic stress.

Table 5.1. Molecular processes and trauma-relevant significance

Process	Function	Trauma relevance	Interpretive caution
Receptor trafficking	Changes synaptic strength	Fear learning, extinction	Measured mostly in animals
Second messengers	Amplify and integrate signals	Stress effects on prefrontal cortex	Inverted-U dose effects
Transcription	Converts transient signals to lasting change	Consolidation, adaptation	Peripheral tissue limits in humans
Protein synthesis	Stabilises long-term change	Reconsolidation window	Boundary conditions unresolved
Oxidative stress	Damage when antioxidants overwhelmed	Hippocampal vulnerability	Non-specific markers
Mitochondrial function	Energy supply, calcium buffering	Synaptic resilience	Difficult to measure in vivo

Composite case study

A patient asks whether a supplement will "repair" the molecular damage caused by childhood abuse. A careful answer distinguishes what is known—chronic stress affects inflammatory, endocrine and synaptic systems—from what is not: no supplement has been shown to reverse trauma-related changes or to treat PTSD. The clinician offers evidence-based treatment and explains that sleep, exercise and social support have measurable biological effects without being "cures".

Review and discussion questions

Why is the NMDA receptor described as a coincidence detector, and why does this matter for learning?

How does the inverted-U relationship between catecholamines and prefrontal function change the way we think about "stress hormones"?

What are the limits of inferring brain epigenetics from blood samples?

Why has reconsolidation been difficult to translate into reliable clinical treatment?

Distinguish a marker of oxidative stress from a mechanism of harm.

Why should molecular findings not be described as measuring thoughts or feelings?

Research assignments

- Design a study that could test whether a psychotherapy changes a molecular marker, specifying the tissue, timing and confounding variables.
- Critically appraise one human epigenetic study of childhood adversity, noting sample size, tissue, replication and effect size.
- Write a one-page briefing for clinicians on what "molecular" evidence does and does not mean for treatment decisions.

Chapter summary

Synaptic transmission depends on vesicle release, receptor activation and intracellular signalling. Metabotropic pathways and transcription factors convert brief signals into lasting change, and protein synthesis stabilises long-term memory. Stress engages these systems through catecholamines, glucocorticoids and inflammatory mediators, producing adaptive changes that can become costly when sustained. The evidence is strongest in animal and cellular preparations; human studies rely on indirect markers. Molecular knowledge should sharpen both mechanism and humility.

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Neurotransmitters, Neuromodulators, and Neuroendocrine Signalling

Chapter 6

In this chapter

Learning objectives 83
Introduction 83
6.1 Glutamate signalling 84
6.2 GABA inhibition 84
6.3 Noradrenergic arousal 85
6.4 Serotonergic modulation 85
6.5 Dopamine and salience 86
6.6 Acetylcholine and attention 86
6.7 Endogenous opioids 87
6.8 Endocannabinoid regulation 87
6.9 Neuropeptides 87
6.10 Hormone–brain communication 88
Synthesis 88
Composite case study 89
Review and discussion questions 90
Research assignments 90
Chapter summary 90
References 91

Central question. How do chemical signalling systems coordinate threat responses across the brain and body, and why does the same molecule produce different effects in different contexts?

Learning objectives

- distinguish neurotransmitters, neuromodulators and hormones;
- describe the principal transmitter systems relevant to threat and regulation;
- explain why "too much" or "too little" of a transmitter is rarely a sufficient explanation;
- relate neuroendocrine signalling to autonomic and behavioural responses;
- evaluate popular claims about "chemical imbalance" in trauma.

Introduction

The brain does not have a separate system for trauma. It uses the same transmitters, modulators and hormones that support movement, appetite, sleep, reward and reproduction. What changes in traumatic stress is the pattern of their engagement: which systems are recruited, for how long, and in what context.

This chapter surveys the principal signalling systems. It is organised around function rather than alphabet. Glutamate and GABA provide fast excitation and inhibition. Noradrenaline, dopamine, serotonin and acetylcholine modulate widely distributed circuits. Opioids and endocannabinoids regulate pain, reward and stress coping. Neuropeptides, including corticotropin-releasing hormone, oxytocin and neuropeptide Y, coordinate social and defensive responses. Hormones—glucocorticoids, catecholamines and gonadal steroids—carry signals between brain and body.

A caution runs through the chapter. Popular accounts often translate complex findings into a "chemical imbalance" story: too much cortisol, too little serotonin, an overactive noradrenergic system. These stories are attractive because they are simple and seem to reduce blame. They are also inaccurate. Signalling systems are nonlinear, context-dependent and reciprocal, and no single measurement in a living person reliably indexes them.

> **A note on names.** *A neurotransmitter is released at a synapse and acts locally. A neuromodulator alters the responsiveness of circuits over a wider*

area and a longer time. A hormone is released into the bloodstream and acts on distant targets. Many molecules act in more than one mode; noradrenaline, for example, is a neurotransmitter in the brainstem, a modulator in the cortex, and a hormone when released from the adrenal medulla.

6.1 Glutamate signalling

Glutamate is the principal excitatory neurotransmitter in the central nervous system. It acts at ionotropic AMPA, NMDA and kainate receptors and at metabotropic receptors. Fast excitatory transmission is mediated mainly by AMPA receptors; NMDA receptors contribute to plasticity and to slower calcium-dependent signalling; metabotropic receptors modulate release and excitability.

Glutamate is also potentially toxic. Excess extracellular glutamate overstimulates receptors, allows calcium to flood cells, and triggers cascades that can damage or kill neurons. This is why glutamate uptake by astrocytes is essential, and why conditions that impair energy supply—ischaemia, hypoglycaemia, prolonged seizures—can produce excitotoxic injury.

In trauma, glutamatergic plasticity underlies fear learning. Strengthening of thalamic and cortical inputs to the lateral amygdala, and of hippocampal and prefrontal connections, depends on NMDA receptor-dependent plasticity. This is the cellular basis of conditioned fear, and it explains why extinction is a form of new learning rather than erasure.

6.2 GABA inhibition

Gamma-aminobutyric acid is the principal inhibitory neurotransmitter. GABA-A receptors are chloride channels that produce fast inhibition; GABA-B receptors are metabotropic and produce slower, longer-lasting inhibition. Inhibitory interneurons shape the timing and synchrony of principal cell firing, and their dysfunction is implicated in epilepsy, anxiety and schizophrenia.

GABAergic function is relevant to trauma in several ways. Benzodiazepines, which enhance GABA-A receptor activity, reduce acute anxiety but are not recommended as routine treatment for PTSD because they do not address the underlying learning and may interfere with extinction. Alcohol acts on GABA-A receptors, which partly explains its use as self-medication and its withdrawal syndrome.

Inhibitory interneurons also gate fear expression. In rodents, parvalbumin-expressing interneurons in the prelimbic cortex regulate fear responses, and intercalated cells in the amygdala gate information between basolateral and central nuclei. These findings suggest that modulating inhibition, not only excitation, could change fear behaviour.

6.3 Noradrenergic arousal

Noradrenaline is produced mainly by the locus coeruleus, a small brainstem nucleus that projects throughout the forebrain. It increases arousal, alertness and vigilance, and it modulates attention, memory and stress responses. During acute stress, noradrenaline release sharpens detection of threat and supports the encoding of emotionally significant events.

Noradrenaline also has costs. High levels impair prefrontal working memory through alpha-1 receptor signalling (Arnsten, 2009), while strengthening amygdala-dependent fear learning. This is a neurochemical account of why people make worse decisions under acute threat and why traumatic memories are often vivid and fragmentary.

In PTSD, noradrenergic activity has been reported to be elevated, and drugs that reduce noradrenergic signalling—such as alpha-1 antagonists and beta-blockers—have been studied for nightmares and hyperarousal. Propranolol has been investigated for prevention after trauma and for reconsolidation-based intervention, but the evidence is not sufficient to support routine use.

6.4 Serotonergic modulation

Serotonin is produced by raphe nuclei and projects widely. It modulates mood, sleep, appetite, sexual function, pain and impulse control. Selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors are first-line pharmacotherapy for PTSD in several guidelines, with modest effect sizes.

The relationship between serotonin and trauma is not a simple deficit. Acute stress increases serotonin turnover in some regions, and chronic stress alters receptor sensitivity. Genetic variation in the serotonin transporter has been studied extensively, but candidate-gene findings have not replicated reliably in large samples, and claims that a single genotype determines trauma response should be rejected.

Serotonergic drugs also carry risks: initial anxiety, sexual dysfunction, discontinuation effects, and, in young people, increased suicidal

ideation during early treatment. These are not arguments against use; they are arguments for informed consent and monitoring.

6.5 Dopamine and salience

Dopamine is produced by the ventral tegmental area and substantia nigra and projects to striatum, prefrontal cortex and limbic regions. It signals reward prediction error, motivates approach, and modulates salience and effort. Dopamine also influences working memory in an inverted-U fashion: moderate levels optimise performance, while high or low levels impair it.

Chronic stress alters dopamine function. In animal models, stress increases dopamine release in prefrontal cortex and alters D1 receptor signalling, contributing to working-memory impairment. In humans, imaging studies report altered striatal responses to reward in PTSD, consistent with the anhedonia and diminished motivation that many patients describe.

Dopamine's role in salience makes it relevant to hypervigilance: a system that assigns excessive salience to threat-related cues will capture attention repeatedly. This is not a "dopamine excess" in the simplistic sense; it is a change in the weighting of cues within a circuit.

6.6 Acetylcholine and attention

Acetylcholine is produced by basal forebrain and brainstem nuclei and acts at nicotinic and muscarinic receptors. It supports attention, learning and memory, and it modulates cortical excitability and plasticity. Cholinergic signalling in the hippocampus and cortex is important for encoding new information.

Stress can alter cholinergic function. Acute stress increases acetylcholine release in some regions, which may support vigilance, while chronic stress is associated with cholinergic changes that impair memory. Anticholinergic drugs, common in older adults, can cause confusion and memory complaints that are sometimes mistaken for cognitive decline.

Nicotine acts at nicotinic acetylcholine receptors and is highly addictive. Smoking is common in people with trauma histories, partly because nicotine temporarily reduces anxiety and improves attention. Treating smoking as a moral failure rather than a dependence is both ineffective and unjust.

6.7 Endogenous opioids

Endogenous opioids include endorphins, enkephalins, dynorphins and endomorphins. They act at mu, delta and kappa receptors and modulate pain, reward, stress and social bonding. Endogenous opioid release can produce analgesia during injury and a sense of relief after danger.

Opioid signalling is implicated in dissociation and numbing. Animal studies suggest that kappa opioid receptor activation can produce aversive, dysphoric states and social withdrawal, while mu receptor activation produces analgesia and euphoria. In humans, opioid blockade has been used experimentally to study the role of endogenous opioids in stress responses.

The clinical implications are complicated. Prescription opioids carry substantial risks and are not indicated for PTSD. Buprenorphine, a partial mu agonist and kappa antagonist, has been studied for treatment-resistant depression and, more recently, for PTSD, but the evidence is preliminary.

6.8 Endocannabinoid regulation

Endocannabinoids—anandamide and 2-arachidonoylglycerol—are synthesised on demand and act at CB1 receptors, which are abundant in cortex, hippocampus, amygdala and striatum. They regulate neurotransmitter release, modulate stress responses, and support fear extinction.

CB1 receptor activation in the amygdala and prefrontal cortex facilitates extinction learning and reduces anxiety-like behaviour in animal models. In humans, cannabis use is common among people with PTSD, often for sleep and anxiety. However, cannabis use is also associated with worse outcomes in some studies, and the evidence for cannabinoids as treatment is limited and mixed.

The endocannabinoid system illustrates a general problem: a plausible mechanism does not make an intervention effective or safe. Clinical decisions require trials, not mechanistic enthusiasm.

6.9 Neuropeptides

Neuropeptides are short chains of amino acids that act as neurotransmitters or modulators. Corticotropin-releasing hormone (CRH) drives the HPA axis and also acts centrally to increase anxiety.

Oxytocin is involved in social bonding, childbirth and lactation, and has context-dependent effects on trust and defence. Neuropeptide Y is associated with stress resilience. Substance P and calcitonin gene-related peptide are involved in pain signalling.

CRH is a central target in trauma research. CRH receptor antagonists have been studied for depression and anxiety, with mixed results. Oxytocin has been studied for PTSD with small and inconsistent effects. Neuropeptide Y has attracted interest because higher levels have been associated with resilience in some studies, including in military populations.

These systems are promising but immature. Clinical claims should be proportionate to the evidence, and "natural" peptides are not automatically safe.

For an overview of stress neurobiology, including transmitter and neuropeptide systems, see Godoy et al. (2018).

6.10 Hormone–brain communication

Hormones reach the brain through the bloodstream and act on receptors in the hypothalamus, hippocampus, amygdala and prefrontal cortex. Glucocorticoids (cortisol in humans, corticosterone in rodents) are released from the adrenal cortex under HPA-axis control. They mobilise energy, modulate immune function, and shape memory.

Glucocorticoids have inverted-U effects on memory: moderate levels support consolidation, while very high or very low levels impair it. They also exert rapid non-genomic effects through membrane receptors, distinct from slower genomic effects. This helps explain why the same hormone can produce different effects at different timescales.

Gonadal steroids—oestrogen, progesterone and testosterone—modulate stress reactivity, fear learning and extinction. Oestrogen, for example, appears to enhance extinction recall in some studies, which may contribute to sex differences in PTSD prevalence. These findings are important and under-studied.

The endocrine detail is reviewed by Herman et al. (2016).

Synthesis

Table 6.1 summarises the principal signalling systems.

Table 6.1. Signalling systems and trauma-relevant functions

System	Main source	Principal functions	Trauma relevance	Cautions
Glutamate	Cortical and subcortical neurons	Fast excitation, plasticity	Fear learning, excitotoxicity	Context-dependent
GABA	Interneurons	Fast inhibition, network timing	Fear gating, anxiety	Benzodiazepines not first-line for PTSD
Noradrenaline	Locus coeruleus	Arousal, vigilance, attention	Hyperarousal, intrusive memory	Inverted-U effects
Serotonin	Raphe nuclei	Mood, sleep, impulse control	PTSD pharmacotherapy	Effect sizes modest
Dopamine	VTA, substantia nigra	Salience, reward, effort	Anhedonia, hypervigilance	Nonlinear dose effects
Acetylcholine	Basal forebrain, brainstem	Attention, encoding	Memory complaints	Measured indirectly
Opioids	Distributed	Analgesia, reward, numbing	Dissociation, self-medication	Dependence risk
Endocannabinoids	On demand	Modulate release, extinction	Sleep, anxiety, extinction	Evidence mixed
CRH	Hypothalamus, extended amygdala	HPA drive, anxiety	Stress response	Trials disappointing
Glucocorticoids	Adrenal cortex	Energy, immunity, memory	Consolidation, feedback	Inverted-U effects

Composite case study

A patient reports that alcohol is the only thing that helps him sleep. A neurotransmitter-informed formulation recognises that alcohol enhances GABA-A signalling and temporarily reduces noradrenergic arousal, which explains the relief and the rebound insomnia. It does not conclude that he has a GABA deficiency. The plan addresses sleep,

trauma reminders and alcohol withdrawal, with medication reviewed for interactions.

Review and discussion questions

Why is "chemical imbalance" a poor explanation of trauma-related distress?

How do the effects of noradrenaline on prefrontal cortex and amygdala differ, and why does this matter clinically?

What is the evidence for and against benzodiazepines in PTSD?

Why are candidate-gene findings in psychiatry often unreliable?

How might endocannabinoid signalling explain why some people use cannabis after trauma, and what are the risks?

Why is it difficult to measure neurotransmitter function in living humans?

Research assignments

- Design a study of sex differences in extinction recall, specifying hormonal assessment and cycle phase.
- Critically appraise the evidence for a CRH antagonist in PTSD.
- Write a patient information leaflet on SSRIs for PTSD that is accurate about benefits and adverse effects.

Chapter summary

Neurotransmitters and hormones coordinate threat responses across brain and body. Glutamate and GABA provide fast excitation and inhibition; noradrenaline, dopamine, serotonin and acetylcholine modulate attention, salience, mood and memory; opioids and endocannabinoids regulate pain, reward and coping; neuropeptides and hormones link brain and body. Effects are nonlinear and context-dependent, and no single chemical measure identifies trauma. Popular "imbalance" stories should be replaced by accurate accounts of systems, contexts and uncertainty.

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Neuroplasticity, Learning, Memory, and Reconsolidation

Chapter 7

In this chapter

Learning objectives 93
Introduction 93
7.1 Forms of neuroplasticity 93
7.2 Long-term potentiation 94
7.3 Long-term depression 94
7.4 Memory systems 95
7.5 Encoding and consolidation 96
7.6 Retrieval and updating 97
7.7 Reconsolidation 97
7.8 Extinction learning 98
7.9 Habit and procedural learning 98
7.10 Experience-dependent recovery 98
Synthesis 99
Composite case study 99
Review and discussion questions 100
Research assignments 100
Chapter summary 100
References 100

Central question. How does the brain learn about danger, store that learning, and update it—and why does traumatic memory behave differently from ordinary memory?

Learning objectives

- distinguish the main forms of neuroplasticity;
- explain long-term potentiation and long-term depression;
- describe the memory systems involved in trauma;
- evaluate the evidence on reconsolidation and its clinical use;
- explain extinction as new learning rather than erasure.

Introduction

Trauma is a learning problem as well as an endocrine and immune one. A neutral cue—a street, a smell, a tone of voice—becomes a signal of danger through associative learning. The body responds accordingly. Avoidance then prevents the correction of the prediction, and the learning persists.

This chapter describes the mechanisms of that learning. It covers synaptic plasticity, the memory systems that support different kinds of knowledge, the stages of encoding, consolidation and retrieval, and the special case of extinction. It also examines reconsolidation, which has generated both excitement and disappointment.

A theme runs through the chapter: memory is reconstructive, not reproductive. Recalling an event alters it. This is true of ordinary memory and it is central to understanding traumatic memory, which is often vivid but incomplete, confident but inconsistent, and subject to change over time.

> **A note on "repression".** *The idea that traumatic memories are routinely pushed out of awareness and later recovered in pristine form is not supported by the memory literature. Forgetting, avoidance, dissociation and fragmented recall are real; the notion of a complete memory stored intact and inaccessible is not. This matters for clinical practice and for legal contexts.*

7.1 Forms of neuroplasticity

Plasticity is the capacity of the nervous system to change with experience. It operates at several levels. Synaptic plasticity changes the strength of individual connections. Structural plasticity changes

dendritic spines, axon terminals and synapse number. Intrinsic plasticity changes the excitability of a neuron. Network plasticity changes the effective connectivity of circuits. Myelin plasticity changes conduction timing.

Plasticity is not always beneficial. It is the mechanism by which both adaptive skills and maladaptive habits are acquired. Chronic pain, addiction and PTSD all involve plasticity: the system has learned something that is now costly.

Developmental plasticity is greater than adult plasticity for some functions, but adults retain substantial capacity. The practical question is not whether an adult brain can change but what conditions make change likely: attention, repetition, sleep, safety and reinforcement.

7.2 Long-term potentiation

Long-term potentiation (LTP) is a lasting increase in synaptic strength following high-frequency stimulation. At hippocampal CA1 synapses, it depends on NMDA receptor activation, calcium influx, and activation of calcium/calmodulin-dependent protein kinase II. Early LTP involves phosphorylation and receptor trafficking; late LTP requires gene transcription and protein synthesis.

LTP is the leading cellular model of learning and memory. It has properties that match memory: it is input-specific, it can last for hours or longer, and it is disrupted by the same manipulations that disrupt learning. It is not identical to memory, but it provides a mechanistic vocabulary.

In the amygdala, LTP-like processes support fear conditioning. In the prefrontal cortex, they support the maintenance of task rules and the consolidation of extinction memories. The same basic mechanism, deployed in different circuits, produces different psychological functions.

7.3 Long-term depression

Long-term depression (LTD) is a lasting decrease in synaptic strength. It can be induced by low-frequency stimulation, by spaced pairing of presynaptic and postsynaptic activity, or by metabotropic glutamate receptor activation. It depends on calcium signalling, phosphatases and receptor internalisation.

LTD is not simply the absence of LTP. It is an active process that weakens specific connections, and it contributes to learning by eliminating inaccurate predictions and refining maps. In the cerebellum, LTD is important for motor learning. In the cortex, it contributes to the pruning of unused connections.

The balance between LTP and LTD determines the net strength of a connection. Stress can shift this balance: high glucocorticoid levels impair LTP and facilitate LTD in the hippocampus, which may contribute to memory difficulties under chronic stress.

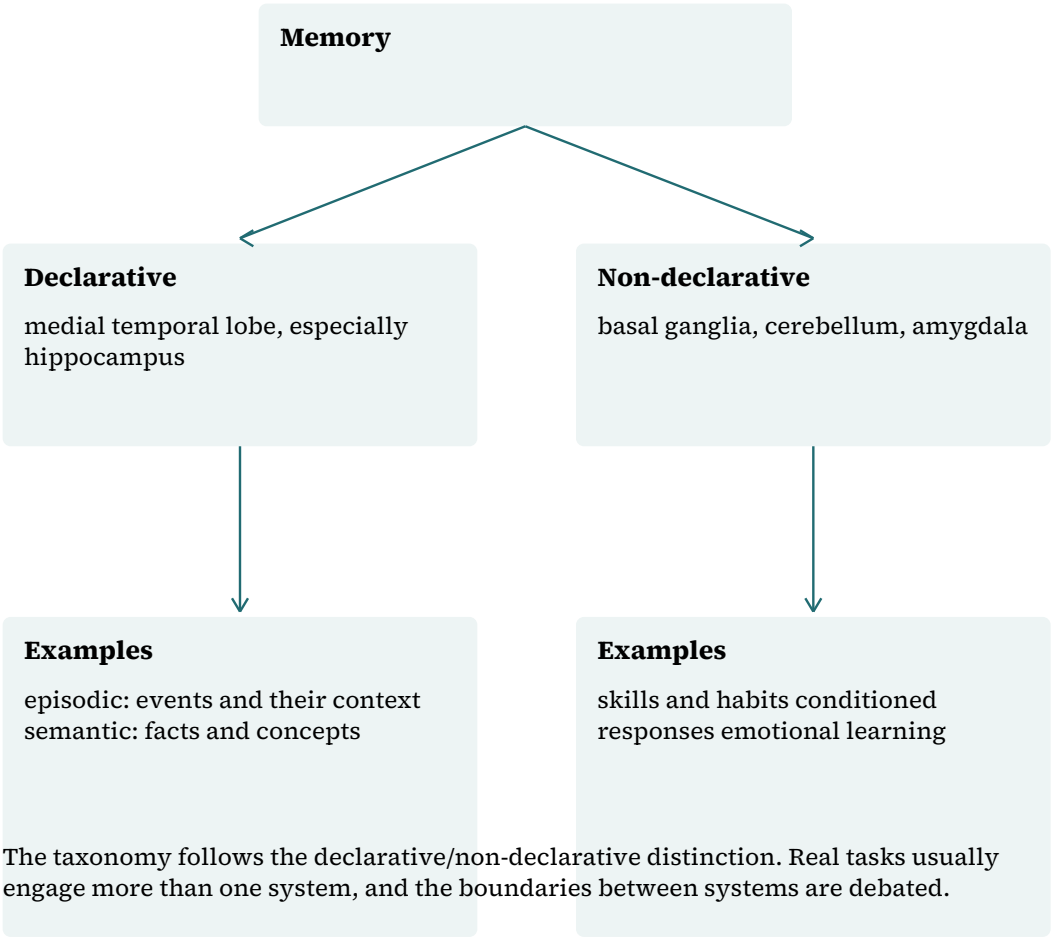
7.4 Memory systems

Memory is not a single faculty. Declarative memory—conscious recall of facts and events—depends on the medial temporal lobe, particularly the hippocampus. Non-declarative memory—skills, habits, conditioning—depends on the basal ganglia, cerebellum and amygdala. Working memory, the temporary maintenance and manipulation of information, depends on prefrontal and parietal networks.

The distinction matters for trauma. A person may have no coherent narrative of an event (impaired declarative memory) while still showing strong physiological reactions to cues (intact non-declarative learning). The body remembers what the story cannot reconstruct. This is not evidence of a "body memory" in a mystical sense; it is evidence that different memory systems encode different aspects of experience.

Scoville and Milner's (1957) study of patient H.M. established the declarative/non-declarative distinction. H.M. could learn new motor skills without recalling the practice sessions. The dissociation remains one of the most instructive findings in memory research.

Figure 7.1. Memory systems relevant to trauma



The taxonomy follows the declarative/non-declarative distinction. Real tasks usually engage more than one system, and the boundaries between systems are debated.

7.5 Encoding and consolidation

Encoding is the process by which experience is transformed into a memory trace. It depends on attention, arousal and the depth of processing. Emotionally arousing events are typically better remembered than neutral ones, an effect mediated partly by amygdala–hippocampal interactions and by stress hormones.

Consolidation is the stabilisation of the trace over time. It involves synaptic changes, gene expression and, for declarative memory, hippocampal–cortical dialogue during sleep. Sleep is not optional for memory: sleep deprivation impairs consolidation and alters emotional reactivity.

Consolidation can be modulated. Cortisol administered after learning enhances memory for emotionally arousing material in some studies; noradrenergic activity has similar effects. This is adaptive in

principle—remembering danger is useful—but it means that highly stressful events may be encoded with unusual strength, which is part of why traumatic memories can be intrusive.

7.6 Retrieval and updating

Retrieval is the reactivation of a memory trace. It is reconstructive: each retrieval can incorporate new information and alter the memory. This is why eyewitness testimony is fallible and why repeated retelling can change a narrative.

Retrieval can also update memory. When a memory is retrieved, it may become temporarily labile and require re-stabilisation—the reconsolidation window described below. Alternatively, retrieval may trigger extinction if the expected outcome does not occur, producing a new inhibitory memory.

These two possibilities—reconsolidation and extinction—are not mutually exclusive. Which occurs depends on the conditions of retrieval: the strength of the prediction error, the age and strength of the memory, and the context.

7.7 Reconsolidation

Reconsolidation is the process by which a retrieved memory is restabilised. In rodents, infusing a protein synthesis inhibitor into the amygdala after retrieval produces amnesia for the memory, while the same infusion without retrieval has no effect (Nader et al., 2000). This finding revived interest in memory modification.

In humans, the evidence is more complicated. Some studies report that reactivating a fear memory followed by extinction training, or by propranolol, reduces subsequent fear responses; others find no effect. A systematic review of extinction and relapse concluded that the conditions for reliable reconsolidation-based modification are not established (Vervliet et al., 2013).

Clinically, reconsolidation has been used to justify brief interventions in which a drug or a behavioural procedure is timed to the retrieval window. The rationale is elegant; the evidence base is not yet sufficient to support routine use. Claims that a single session can "erase" a traumatic memory should be treated as marketing, not science.

7.8 Extinction learning

Extinction is the gradual reduction of a conditioned response when the conditioned stimulus is repeatedly presented without the unconditioned stimulus. It does not erase the original association. It creates a new, context-dependent inhibitory memory that competes with the original.

This is why fear can return. Renewal occurs when the extinguished cue is tested in a different context. Reinstatement occurs after an unsignalled aversive event. Spontaneous recovery occurs with the passage of time. These phenomena are not failures of treatment; they are signatures of the underlying learning.

Extinction depends on the ventromedial prefrontal cortex, the amygdala and the hippocampus (Milad & Quirk, 2012). In PTSD, extinction recall is often impaired, and vmPFC–amygdala connectivity is altered. Exposure therapy is built on extinction principles, which is why it works and why it requires within-session and between-session learning.

7.9 Habit and procedural learning

Habits are learned associations between cues and actions that become automatic with repetition. They depend on corticostriatal circuits, particularly the dorsal striatum. Habits are efficient but inflexible; they persist when the outcome changes.

Trauma-related avoidance often becomes habitual. A person may avoid a route, a conversation or a social situation without deciding to do so. The behaviour is triggered by context and executed with little deliberation, which is why insight alone rarely changes it.

Procedural learning also supports recovery: new routines, sleep habits, grounding skills and social behaviours can become automatic with practice. Rehabilitation is, in part, the deliberate construction of helpful habits.

7.10 Experience-dependent recovery

Recovery from trauma involves new learning at multiple levels: that reminders are not necessarily dangerous, that arousal can be tolerated, that the world contains safe people, and that one's own responses are understandable. Each of these is a prediction that must be tested against experience.

This is why avoidance is so costly. It prevents the prediction error that would update the threat association. It is also why safety must be real, not merely asserted: a person cannot learn that a situation is safe if it is not.

The clinical implications are consistent with the learning literature: graded exposure, context variation, sleep protection, and the gradual rebuilding of activities that matter. These principles are not new, but they are grounded in mechanisms that are now quite well understood.

Synthesis

Table 7.1 summarises memory processes and their trauma relevance.

Table 7.1. Memory processes and trauma relevance

Process	Mechanism	Trauma relevance	Clinical implication
Encoding	Attention, arousal, amygdala–hippocampal interaction	Vivid, fragmentary trauma memory	Do not assume completeness
Consolidation	Protein synthesis, sleep-dependent replay	Strong emotional memory	Protect sleep
Retrieval	Reactivation, reconstruction	Memory can change on recall	Caution in testimony
Reconsolidation	Labilisation and restabilisation	Potential treatment window	Evidence not yet sufficient
Extinction	New inhibitory learning	Exposure therapy	Context variation matters
Habit learning	Corticostriatal circuits	Automatic avoidance	Practice new routines

Composite case study

A patient avoids driving after a collision. Exposure begins with sitting in a parked car, then short drives on quiet roads, then the route of the collision. Each step is repeated in different contexts and at different times of day to reduce renewal. Sleep is treated because sleep deprivation impairs extinction consolidation. The patient is told that

fear may return after a stressful week and that this is expected, not failure.

Review and discussion questions

Why is extinction described as new learning rather than forgetting?

What are the three main forms of fear relapse, and what do they imply for treatment?

How strong is the human evidence for reconsolidation-based therapy?

Why might a person have physiological reactions to a cue without a coherent memory of the event?

What is the difference between a habit and a deliberate avoidance strategy, and why does it matter?

Why is the concept of repression not supported by memory research?

Research assignments

- Design an exposure study that tests renewal, reinstatement and spontaneous recovery.
- Critically appraise one reconsolidation trial, noting blinding, sample size and outcome measurement.
- Write a protocol for a sleep intervention adjunct to exposure therapy.

Chapter summary

Learning and memory are the mechanisms by which trauma becomes persistent. Synaptic plasticity supports the acquisition of threat associations; declarative and non-declarative systems encode different aspects of experience; consolidation stabilises memory; retrieval can update it. Extinction creates new inhibitory learning rather than erasing the original, which explains relapse. Reconsolidation is a promising but unproven clinical route. Recovery depends on new learning under conditions of safety, repetition and sleep.

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Stress Physiology: HPA Axis, Autonomic Regulation, and Allostasis

Chapter 8

In this chapter

Learning objectives 103
Introduction 103
8.1 Definition of stress 104
8.2 Acute stress response 104
8.3 HPA axis sequence 104
8.4 Glucocorticoid feedback 106
8.5 Sympathetic activation 106
8.6 Parasympathetic regulation 107
8.7 Cardiorespiratory responses 107
8.8 Allostatic load 107
8.9 Sleep and circadian regulation 108
8.10 Recovery and physiological flexibility 108
Synthesis 109
Composite case study 109
Review and discussion questions 110
Research assignments 110
Chapter summary 110
References 110

Central question. What happens in the body during and after threat, and how do we distinguish a normal stress response from a system that has become stuck?

Learning objectives

- define stress, stressors, allostasis and allostatic load;
- describe the sequence of HPA-axis activation and feedback;
- explain sympathetic and parasympathetic contributions to threat responses;
- describe the physiological measures used in trauma research and their limits;
- relate sleep and circadian regulation to stress recovery.

Introduction

Stress physiology is the bridge between experience and biology. An event is appraised as threatening; neural circuits activate endocrine and autonomic outputs; the body mobilises energy, increases vigilance, and prepares for action. When the event ends, the response is normally terminated. When it does not end, or when it is repeated, the cost accumulates.

This chapter describes the major systems involved. It begins with definitions, because "stress" is used loosely in both research and everyday language. It then follows the HPA axis from hypothalamic drive to glucocorticoid feedback, describes autonomic regulation, and introduces allostasis and allostatic load. It closes with sleep and circadian rhythms, which are both affected by stress and important for recovery.

A caution is necessary at the outset. Physiological measures are often treated as biomarkers of trauma, but cortisol, heart rate and blood pressure are non-specific. They vary with time of day, posture, food, caffeine, medication, exercise, infection and anticipation of measurement. A single cortisol sample tells us very little about a person's trauma history.

> **A note on definitions.** *A stressor is an event or condition that challenges homeostasis. The stress response is the physiological and behavioural reaction to it. Allostasis is the process of achieving stability through change—adjusting set points to meet anticipated demand. Allostatic load is the cumulative cost of repeated or sustained adjustment.*

8.1 Definition of stress

The concept of stress has a complicated history. Selye introduced the general adaptation syndrome, describing a non-specific response to diverse demands. Later work distinguished the stimulus (stressor), the response (stress response) and the appraisal that links them. Lazarus and Folkman emphasised that stress depends on whether an event is appraised as threatening and whether the person believes they can cope.

Contemporary definitions combine these elements. Stress is a real or anticipated challenge to homeostasis, appraised as significant, that engages physiological and behavioural responses. The appraisal is not merely cognitive; it is shaped by prior experience, current state and social context.

Goldstein and Kopin (2007) trace how the term evolved and argue for precision: stress is not a single entity but a category of processes. This matters for research, because different studies operationalise stress differently and therefore measure different things.

8.2 Acute stress response

The acute stress response has two phases. The fast phase is neural and hormonal: sympathetic activation releases noradrenaline from nerve terminals and adrenaline from the adrenal medulla within seconds. Heart rate rises, blood pressure increases, blood flow is redirected to muscles and brain, pupils dilate, digestion slows, and glucose is mobilised.

The slower phase is endocrine: the HPA axis releases glucocorticoids over minutes to hours. Glucocorticoids mobilise energy, suppress non-essential immune activity, and modulate memory and appraisal. They also help terminate the response through negative feedback.

This two-phase organisation is adaptive: the fast phase prepares for immediate action, and the slow phase sustains the response and then shuts it down. Problems arise when the fast phase is repeatedly triggered without resolution, or when the slow phase fails to terminate.

8.3 HPA axis sequence

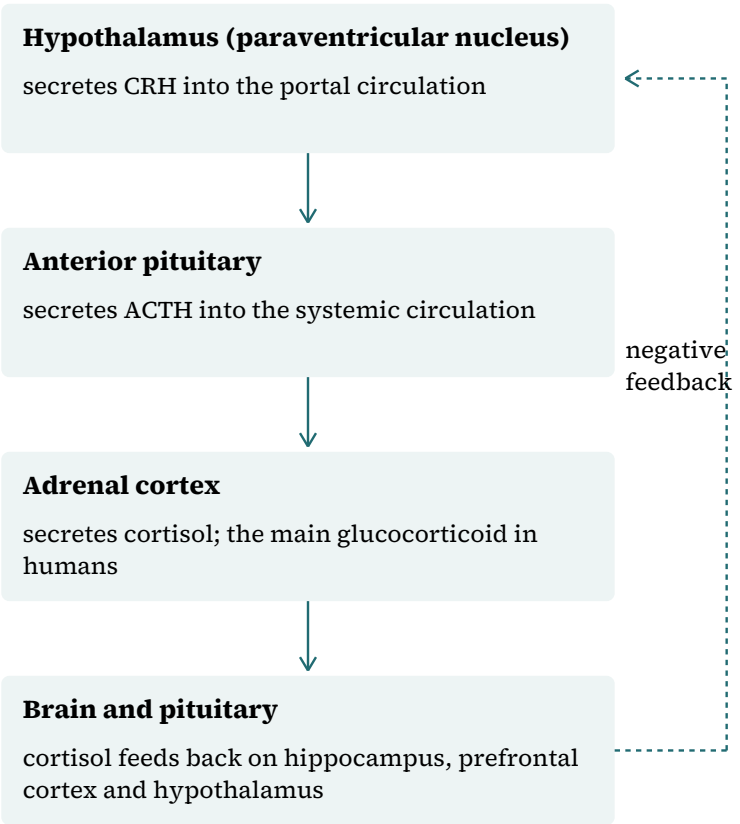
The HPA axis begins in the paraventricular nucleus of the hypothalamus, where neurons release corticotropin-releasing hormone (CRH) into the portal circulation. CRH stimulates the anterior pituitary

to release adrenocorticotropic hormone (ACTH), which travels in the blood to the adrenal cortex and stimulates glucocorticoid synthesis and release.

The axis is regulated by inputs from the brainstem, amygdala, hippocampus and prefrontal cortex. The amygdala promotes activation; the hippocampus and prefrontal cortex contribute to inhibition; the brainstem provides rapid relay of visceral and nociceptive signals. The balance of these inputs determines the magnitude and duration of the response (Ulrich-Lai & Herman, 2009).

The axis is also regulated by circadian rhythms. Cortisol peaks shortly after waking and declines through the day, reaching a nadir in the early hours of the morning. This rhythm is important for interpreting measurements and for understanding sleep disruption.

Figure 8.1. The hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal axis and glucocorticoid feedback



CRH, corticotrophin-releasing hormone; ACTH, adrenocorticotrophic hormone. Solid arrows indicate stimulation; the dashed arrow indicates negative feedback. The diagram is schematic and omits many inputs and timescales.

8.4 Glucocorticoid feedback

Glucocorticoids exert negative feedback at multiple levels: they inhibit CRH release in the hypothalamus, ACTH release in the pituitary, and drive from upstream regions. Feedback operates over different timescales—rapid non-genomic effects within minutes, and slower genomic effects over hours.

Feedback sensitivity is a key variable. In some people with PTSD, cortisol levels are lower than expected and feedback is enhanced; in others, particularly those with chronic stress or depression, cortisol is elevated and feedback is blunted. The heterogeneity is real, and it reflects differences in trauma type, timing, comorbidity and measurement.

Glucocorticoid receptors are expressed throughout the brain, with high density in the hippocampus, amygdala and prefrontal cortex. Their activation alters gene transcription, which is one route by which stress affects memory and mood over time.

8.5 Sympathetic activation

The sympathetic nervous system prepares the body for action. Preganglionic neurons in the spinal cord project to sympathetic ganglia, which innervate the heart, blood vessels, lungs, gut and sweat glands. The adrenal medulla releases adrenaline and noradrenaline directly into the bloodstream.

Cardiovascular effects include increased heart rate and contractility, vasoconstriction in the skin and gut, and vasodilation in skeletal muscle. Respiratory effects include bronchodilation and increased rate. Metabolic effects include glycogenolysis and lipolysis. These changes are adaptive in the short term.

Chronic sympathetic activation is associated with hypertension, cardiovascular disease, insulin resistance and immune dysregulation. For trauma survivors, this is one pathway by which psychological distress becomes physical illness—not through belief alone, but through sustained physiological load.

8.6 Parasympathetic regulation

The parasympathetic nervous system promotes rest, digestion and recovery. The vagus nerve provides the main parasympathetic supply to the heart, lungs and gut. High vagal tone is associated with efficient cardiac regulation and with better emotional regulation in some studies.

The polyvagal theory, developed by Porges, proposes that the vagus has distinct branches with different evolutionary histories and that withdrawal of vagal tone produces the immobilisation responses seen in trauma. The theory has been influential in clinical practice, but its anatomical and physiological claims have been criticised by comparative physiologists. It is best treated as a clinical metaphor with some empirical support, not as an established mechanism.

The practical point is that recovery requires parasympathetic engagement: sleep, digestion, social connection and periods of safety. Interventions that promote these—rather than only reducing sympathetic arousal—are likely to be more effective.

8.7 Cardiorespiratory responses

Heart rate variability (HRV) is the variation in the interval between heartbeats. It reflects the interplay of sympathetic and parasympathetic influences and is associated with emotional regulation, resilience and cardiovascular health. Low HRV has been reported in PTSD, but effect sizes are modest and findings are affected by medication, fitness, age and breathing rate.

Respiratory rate and depth change under stress, and hyperventilation can produce dizziness, tingling and a sense of unreality that overlap with dissociative symptoms. Breathing retraining is sometimes helpful, though the evidence for it as a stand-alone trauma treatment is limited.

Blood pressure, heart rate and respiration are useful in research and in clinical monitoring, but they are not diagnostic. A person can be highly distressed with normal vitals, and a person can be physiologically aroused for reasons unrelated to trauma.

8.8 Allostatic load

Allostatic load is the cumulative physiological cost of adapting to stress. It is indexed by a panel of measures that typically includes blood pressure, waist circumference, cortisol, cholesterol, glucose,

inflammatory markers and heart rate variability. Higher scores predict functional decline and mortality in longitudinal studies.

McEwen's (1998) formulation describes four patterns of allostatic load: repeated activation, failure to habituate, failure to terminate, and inadequate response. These patterns help explain why both over- and under-activity of stress systems can be harmful.

For trauma, allostatic load provides a way to connect psychological adversity to physical health without claiming that stress directly causes a specific disease. It also supports early intervention: reducing load may have benefits beyond symptom relief.

8.9 Sleep and circadian regulation

Sleep is essential for memory consolidation, emotional regulation, immune function and metabolic health. Trauma commonly disrupts sleep: difficulty falling asleep, frequent waking, nightmares, and a fear of sleeping. These problems are not merely consequences of trauma; they maintain it, because sleep deprivation increases amygdala reactivity and impairs prefrontal function.

Circadian rhythms are regulated by the suprachiasmatic nucleus and synchronised by light, activity, meals and social cues. Trauma and displacement can disrupt these cues, particularly in refugees, shift workers and hospitalised patients. Jet lag, shift work and irregular schedules produce physiological stress even without psychological trauma.

Sleep interventions—stimulus control, sleep restriction, cognitive therapy for insomnia—are effective and can be delivered alongside trauma-focused therapy. Nightmares can be treated with imagery rehearsal therapy, which has good evidence.

8.10 Recovery and physiological flexibility

Recovery is not the absence of stress; it is the capacity to mount a response and then return to baseline. Physiological flexibility—the ability to shift between states—is a marker of health. Rigidity, whether in the direction of chronic hyperarousal or chronic shutdown, is a marker of dysfunction.

Several factors support flexibility: sleep, exercise, nutrition, social connection, predictable routines and a sense of control. These are not soft extras; they are biological requirements. Interventions that address

them can improve symptoms even when trauma-specific therapy is not available.

The clinical task is to help the body relearn that arousal is survivable and that rest is possible. That relearning happens through experience, not through instruction alone.

Synthesis

Table 8.1 summarises the principal physiological systems.

Table 8.1. Stress systems and measures

System	Key mediators	Time course	Common measures	Limits
Sympathetic	Noradrenaline, adrenaline	Seconds	Heart rate, blood pressure, skin conductance	Non-specific
HPA axis	CRH, ACTH, cortisol	Minutes to hours	Salivary or serum cortisol, dexamethasone suppression	Diurnal variation
Parasympathetic	Acetylcholine, vagal tone	Seconds to minutes	HRV, respiratory sinus arrhythmia	Affected by fitness, medication
Allostatic load	Multiple	Months to years	Composite index	Indirect
Sleep	Circadian and homeostatic	Hours	Polysomnography, actigraphy, self-report	Measurement burden

Composite case study

A patient presents with palpitations, dizziness and a sense of unreality. Medical assessment excludes cardiac and neurological causes. The physiological formulation considers chronic sympathetic activation, hyperventilation, sleep deprivation and caffeine intake. The plan includes sleep regularisation, reduced caffeine, breathing retraining and trauma-focused therapy. Symptoms improve as sleep and arousal regulation improve, without any claim that the original trauma has been erased.

Review and discussion questions

Distinguish homeostasis, allostasis and allostatic load.

Why is a single cortisol measurement of limited value in assessing trauma?

What are the strengths and limitations of polyvagal theory?

How does sleep deprivation maintain trauma symptoms?

Why is physiological flexibility a better marker of health than low arousal?

What would a study need to do to show that an intervention reduced allostatic load?

Research assignments

- Design a study of cortisol rhythms in PTSD that controls for time of sampling, medication and sleep.
- Critically appraise the evidence on HRV biofeedback for trauma-related conditions.
- Write a protocol for a sleep intervention in a low-resource setting.

Chapter summary

Stress engages fast neural and slower endocrine systems that mobilise the body for action and then terminate the response. The HPA axis and autonomic nervous system are tightly regulated and highly context-dependent. Allostatic load describes the cumulative cost of repeated or sustained activation. Sleep and circadian rhythms are both affected by trauma and essential for recovery. Physiological measures are useful but non-specific, and clinical interpretation requires attention to time, context, medication and individual variation.

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Genetics, Epigenetics, and Gene–Environment Interplay

Chapter 9

In this chapter

Learning objectives 113
Introduction 113
9.1 Genetic variation 113
9.2 Heritability and its limits 114
9.3 Candidate gene history 114
9.4 Genome-wide association 115
9.5 Gene–environment interplay 115
9.6 DNA methylation 116
9.7 Histone modification 116
9.8 Non-coding RNA 117
9.9 Intergenerational questions 117
9.10 Ethical genomics and precision research 117
9.11 Model organisms and what they can show 118
9.12 Reading genetic association studies critically 118
Synthesis 119
Composite case study 120
Review and discussion questions 120
Research assignments 120
Chapter summary 120
References 121

Central question. How much of trauma response is inherited, what does heritability actually mean, and why have simple genetic explanations failed?

Learning objectives

- distinguish genetic variation, heritability and genetic risk;
- explain why candidate-gene findings often fail to replicate;
- describe what genome-wide association studies can and cannot show;
- explain gene–environment interplay without genetic determinism;
- evaluate claims about epigenetic inheritance of trauma.

Introduction

Few areas of trauma research have produced more public misunderstanding than genetics. Headlines announce "the trauma gene", "the resilience gene" or "the gene that makes you vulnerable to PTSD". The underlying science is more interesting and much more uncertain. Post-traumatic stress disorder is polygenic, meaning that many variants of small effect contribute to risk; it is also strongly environmental, because exposure to trauma is a prerequisite; and the two interact in ways that are difficult to disentangle.

This chapter explains the concepts needed to read the literature critically. It distinguishes heritability from determinism, describes the shift from candidate genes to genome-wide studies, and examines epigenetics—the study of how gene expression is regulated without changes in DNA sequence. It closes with the ethical questions raised by genomic research on trauma.

> **A note on heritability.** *Heritability is the proportion of variation in a trait, within a particular population at a particular time, that is attributable to genetic variation. It is not the proportion of a person's condition caused by genes. A heritability of 40% does not mean that 40% of a person's PTSD is genetic and 60% environmental; it means that, in that population, 40% of the variance in the trait is associated with genetic differences.*

9.1 Genetic variation

The human genome contains about three billion base pairs. Most variation between people consists of single nucleotide polymorphisms (SNPs), common variants at a single position, together with insertions,

deletions and structural variants such as copy-number changes. Most common variants have small effects; rare variants can have larger effects and are often associated with Mendelian disorders.

Genetic variation influences trauma risk in several ways. It can affect stress physiology—for example, through variants in genes regulating the HPA axis. It can affect temperament and reactivity. It can affect the probability of exposure to certain environments, a phenomenon known as gene–environment correlation. And it can affect response to treatment.

None of these pathways is deterministic. A genetic variant changes a probability, usually slightly, in a particular context.

Definitions of the genetic terms used in this chapter follow the National Human Genome Research Institute glossary (n.d.-a).

9.2 Heritability and its limits

Twin studies compare concordance in monozygotic and dizygotic twins to estimate heritability. For PTSD, estimates cluster around 30–50%, varying with trauma type and sample. These estimates are useful for showing that genetic factors matter; they do not identify which genes, and they can be inflated by gene–environment correlation and by assumptions about equal environments.

Heritability can change with context. If everyone is exposed to the same environmental risk, genetic differences account for more of the variation in outcome; if environments vary greatly, environmental factors account for more. This is why heritability estimates from one population should not be generalised to another.

The concept of "missing heritability"—the gap between twin-study estimates and the variance explained by identified variants—remains relevant. Much of the genetic contribution to complex traits is distributed across many small effects that are difficult to detect.

9.3 Candidate gene history

Candidate-gene studies test a small number of variants chosen on theoretical grounds. The serotonin transporter variant 5-HTTLPR is the most famous example. Early studies reported an interaction with stressful life events in predicting depression; later meta-analyses found much weaker or inconsistent effects.

The candidate-gene era produced many findings that did not replicate. Reasons include small samples, flexible analysis choices, publication bias and the fact that the underlying biology is more complex than the hypotheses assumed. A variant that affects serotonin transport in vitro may have modest effects on behaviour in a person embedded in an environment.

Candidate-gene findings are not worthless—some, such as FKBP5, have replicated in multiple studies—but they should be treated as hypotheses rather than established risk factors. Clinical genetic testing for trauma vulnerability is not supported.

9.4 Genome-wide association

Genome-wide association studies (GWAS) test millions of variants for association with a trait in large samples. They require stringent correction for multiple testing and very large samples to detect small effects. For PTSD, GWAS have identified several loci, but the variance explained remains small and replication across ancestries is limited.

GWAS findings are useful for understanding biology at scale and for constructing polygenic scores, which aggregate the effects of many variants. Polygenic scores for PTSD are currently weak predictors and are not validated for clinical use. Their predictive power is lower in populations of different ancestry from the discovery sample, which raises fairness concerns.

The most important lesson from GWAS is that complex traits are polygenic and that single-gene explanations are inadequate. This is a scientific advance even though it has not yet produced clinical tools.

9.5 Gene–environment interplay

Gene–environment interaction means that the effect of an environmental exposure depends on genotype, or vice versa. Gene–environment correlation means that genetic factors influence exposure to environments—for example, through temperament, risk-taking or selection into circumstances.

Both phenomena complicate the interpretation of observational research. If a study finds that a variant moderates the effect of childhood adversity, it may be capturing interaction, correlation or confounding. Large samples, preregistered hypotheses and replication are essential.

The practical implication is that neither genes nor environments should be treated as fixed causes. Risk emerges from their interplay over development, and interventions that change environments can change outcomes regardless of genotype.

9.6 DNA methylation

DNA methylation is the addition of a methyl group to cytosine, usually in CpG dinucleotides. It typically represses transcription when it occurs in gene promoters. Methylation patterns are established during development and can be modified by experience.

In trauma research, methylation of FKBP5 and NR3C1 (the glucocorticoid receptor gene) has been studied in relation to childhood adversity. Some studies report associations with altered stress reactivity; others do not. Samples are often small, and peripheral tissue (blood, saliva) is used as a proxy for brain.

The epigenetic clock—measures of biological age based on methylation—has been used to study accelerated ageing in trauma-exposed populations. Findings are interesting but preliminary, and the clinical significance is unclear.

The description of epigenetic mechanisms follows the National Human Genome Research Institute epigenomics fact sheet (n.d.-b).

9.7 Histone modification

Histones are proteins around which DNA is wrapped. Chemical modifications—acetylation, methylation, phosphorylation—alter chromatin structure and gene accessibility. Histone acetylation generally increases transcription; certain histone methylations repress it.

Animal studies show that stress and caregiving experiences can alter histone modifications in brain regions relevant to stress regulation. In rodents, variations in maternal care are associated with lasting epigenetic differences in offspring, including in the glucocorticoid receptor gene.

Human evidence is limited by the difficulty of obtaining brain tissue. Post-mortem studies exist but are small and affected by agonal state and tissue quality. Peripheral measures are indirect. The field is promising but not yet able to support clinical claims.

9.8 Non-coding RNA

Non-coding RNAs regulate gene expression post-transcriptionally. MicroRNAs bind to messenger RNAs and inhibit translation or promote degradation. They are involved in synaptic plasticity, inflammation and stress responses.

Circulating microRNAs in blood have been studied as potential biomarkers for PTSD and other conditions. Some studies report differences between groups, but findings are inconsistent and the biological meaning of circulating microRNAs is unclear. They may reflect immune activation, tissue damage or stress-related changes in blood cells rather than brain processes.

Long non-coding RNAs are less well understood but are increasingly recognised as regulators of chromatin and transcription. Their role in trauma is largely unexplored.

9.9 Intergenerational questions

Interest in intergenerational transmission intensified after studies reported epigenetic changes in the offspring of people exposed to famine, genocide or trauma. The mechanisms proposed include altered maternal care, altered stress physiology, and direct epigenetic inheritance through gametes.

The evidence is strongest for indirect pathways: trauma affects parenting, family functioning, economic stability and exposure to adversity, all of which affect children. Direct epigenetic inheritance in humans is plausible in principle but has not been convincingly demonstrated for trauma-related outcomes.

Claims that trauma is "passed down in the genes" should therefore be translated into more accurate statements: children of trauma survivors may face higher risk through multiple pathways, including caregiving, environment and possibly biology. This framing supports support for families rather than fatalism.

9.10 Ethical genomics and precision research

Genomic research on trauma raises ethical issues. Genetic data are identifiable and can reveal information about relatives who did not consent. Findings may be misused to justify stigma, discrimination or deterministic claims about groups. Research in under-resourced settings

must involve local scientists and communities and must not extract data without capacity building.

Genetic testing for trauma vulnerability is not clinically indicated. Direct-to-consumer tests that claim to assess trauma risk are not supported by evidence. Researchers should communicate uncertainty clearly and avoid reinforcing genetic essentialism.

9.11 Model organisms and what they can show

Much of what is known about the molecular biology of stress comes from rodents. Animal models allow controlled exposure, direct tissue sampling and experimental manipulation that would be impossible in humans.

Rodent models of chronic stress—restraint, social defeat, unpredictability—produce behavioural and endocrine changes that resemble aspects of human stress-related disorders. Maternal separation and limited bedding models are used to study early adversity. These models have identified mechanisms: glucocorticoid receptor regulation, CRH expression, hippocampal plasticity, microglial activation and epigenetic modification.

The limitations are substantial. A mouse is not a person, and a laboratory stressor is not a traumatic event embedded in meaning, relationship and culture. Measures such as freezing and corticosterone are proxies, not equivalents of human symptoms. Sex differences are often ignored because early studies used male animals, and this has distorted the literature.

Findings should therefore be treated as mechanistic hypotheses to be tested in humans, not as direct evidence about human experience. When a paper reports that a stress paradigm "causes depression-like behaviour" in rodents, the phrase in quotation marks is doing important work.

9.12 Reading genetic association studies critically

Several questions help in appraising a genetic study of trauma-related outcomes.

What was the sample size, and was it adequate for the effect being sought? Small studies in this field have produced many findings that later shrank or disappeared.

Was the phenotype well defined? "PTSD" assessed by self-report questionnaire is not the same as a clinical diagnosis, and trauma exposure is often measured retrospectively.

Was the analysis preregistered? Candidate-gene studies with flexible covariates and subgroup analyses are particularly prone to false positives.

Was the finding replicated in an independent sample, and in more than one ancestry group? Polygenic scores derived from European samples often perform poorly elsewhere.

Were confounders addressed? Population stratification, gene–environment correlation and assortative mating can produce spurious associations.

Does the effect size matter? A variant that changes risk by a few per cent may be scientifically interesting and clinically useless.

A single paper rarely justifies a change in practice. The most useful genetic findings are those that replicate across consortia, converge with other lines of evidence, and illuminate a mechanism.

Synthesis

Table 9.1 summarises genetic concepts and their clinical status.

Table 9.1. Genetic concepts and clinical status

Concept	Meaning	Current status for trauma	Caution
Heritability	Variance attributable to genetic differences in a population	30–50% in twin studies	Not individual causation
Candidate gene	Hypothesis-driven variant	Mostly unreplicated	Do not test clinically
GWAS	Genome-wide association	Several loci, small effects	Limited ancestry diversity
Polygenic score	Aggregated variant effects	Weak predictor	Not clinical
Methylation	DNA modification affecting expression	Associations reported	Peripheral tissue only
Intergenerational	Transmission across generations	Indirect pathways strongest	Avoid genetic determinism

Composite case study

A patient asks whether a genetic test can explain why she developed PTSD while her sister did not. The clinician explains that PTSD is polygenic and environmentally contingent, that no test can identify a specific cause, and that differences in exposure, support and coping are likely to matter more than any single variant. The conversation addresses the underlying wish—to understand why—without offering false certainty.

Review and discussion questions

Why is heritability not a measure of individual causation?

Why did candidate-gene studies largely fail to replicate?

What can polygenic scores currently do, and what can they not do?

Distinguish gene–environment interaction from gene–environment correlation.

Why is peripheral methylation an imperfect proxy for brain methylation?

What are the ethical risks of genetic research on trauma in low-resource settings?

Research assignments

- Design a GWAS of PTSD that includes diverse ancestries and specifies replication.
- Critically appraise one study of FKBP5 methylation and childhood adversity.
- Write a plain-language explanation of heritability for a community audience.

Chapter summary

Trauma risk is influenced by many genetic variants of small effect, interacting with environment throughout development. Heritability describes population variance, not individual causation. Candidate-gene findings have mostly not replicated; GWAS has shown that PTSD is highly polygenic. Epigenetic mechanisms regulate gene expression and

are affected by experience, but human evidence, especially for intergenerational inheritance, is limited. Genomic research must be conducted and communicated with attention to uncertainty and justice.

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Threat Learning, Fear Conditioning, and Traumatic Memory

Chapter 10

In this chapter

Learning objectives 123
Introduction 123
10.1 Pavlovian conditioning 123
10.2 Unconditioned and conditioned responses 124
10.3 Acquisition of threat learning 124
10.4 Context conditioning 125
10.5 Fear generalisation 125
10.6 Avoidance learning 125
10.7 Extinction and renewal 126
10.8 Prediction error 126
10.9 Intrusive memory 127
10.10 Clinical translation of learning science 127
10.11 Safety learning and inhibition 127
10.12 Beyond fear: disgust, shame and moral injury 128
Synthesis 129
Composite case study 129
Review and discussion questions 130
Research assignments 130
Chapter summary 130
References 130

Central question. How does a neutral event become a danger signal, and why does the learning sometimes fail to extinguish?

Learning objectives

- explain the basic elements of Pavlovian conditioning;
- describe acquisition, generalisation and contextual control of fear;
- distinguish extinction, habituation and habituation-like phenomena;
- explain prediction error and its role in updating threat beliefs;
- evaluate the translation of learning science into clinical practice.

Introduction

Fear conditioning is the best-understood model of how trauma-related learning occurs. A neutral stimulus is paired with an aversive event; the neutral stimulus acquires the capacity to elicit defensive responses; and the learning can persist long after the aversive event has ended. The model is powerful because it is experimentally tractable, conserved across species and grounded in identified circuits.

It is also incomplete. Human trauma rarely consists of a single, well-timed pairing in a laboratory. It involves complex events, uncertain threat, social meaning and repeated exposure. The translation from conditioning experiments to clinical trauma is therefore indirect, and the chapter is careful to mark where the model illuminates and where it misleads.

> **A note on fear versus anxiety.** *Fear is typically described as a response to imminent, identifiable threat; anxiety as a response to uncertain, anticipated threat. The distinction is useful clinically but not absolute, and the underlying circuits overlap. Much of what trauma survivors describe is closer to sustained anxiety than to phasic fear.*

10.1 Pavlovian conditioning

Pavlovian conditioning pairs a conditioned stimulus (CS), initially neutral, with an unconditioned stimulus (US) that elicits an unconditioned response (UR). After repeated pairings, the CS elicits a conditioned response (CR). In fear conditioning, the US is typically an aversive shock or loud noise, and the CR includes freezing, autonomic arousal and potentiated startle.

The conditioning preparation allows precise control of stimulus timing, intensity and contingency. This control is why it has been so productive: researchers can manipulate variables and measure outcomes with rigour. It is also why findings do not map neatly onto real-world trauma, where contingencies are ambiguous and exposures are uncontrolled.

10.2 Unconditioned and conditioned responses

The unconditioned response to threat is organised by brainstem and hypothalamic circuits. It includes cardiovascular changes, respiration, analgesia, freezing and endocrine activation. These responses are adaptive in the presence of danger and can be elicited without cortical processing, which is why they can occur before a person has consciously identified the threat.

The conditioned response is acquired through learning and is more flexible. It can be modulated by context, expectation and prior experience. In humans, conditioning can occur with subliminal stimuli, which shows that awareness is not always necessary—though the interpretation of such findings is debated.

Conditioned responses are not a single thing. Different measures—skin conductance, startle, freezing, heart rate—can dissociate. A person may show physiological conditioning without reporting fear, or report fear without physiological change. This matters for assessment.

10.3 Acquisition of threat learning

Acquisition depends on contingency, contiguity and salience. The CS must predict the US; the closer in time, the stronger the learning, though there are exceptions. The intensity of the US matters: more intense aversive events produce stronger conditioning.

At the circuit level, sensory information about the CS reaches the lateral amygdala from the thalamus and cortex. The US information also reaches the amygdala. Convergence of the two inputs produces synaptic plasticity, so that the CS alone can later activate the central nucleus and produce defensive responses (LeDoux, 2000; Maren, 2001).

Acquisition is modulated by stress hormones. Noradrenaline and glucocorticoids enhance consolidation of fear learning, which is adaptive in danger but can produce overly strong memories when stress is extreme.

10.4 Context conditioning

Contexts—the places, times and internal states in which an event occurs—become associated with threat through a process that depends on the hippocampus and amygdala. Contextual fear is often more diffuse than cue-specific fear: a person may feel unsafe without knowing why.

Context processing is relevant to PTSD, where symptoms often fluctuate with setting. A survivor may feel relatively calm at home and overwhelmed in a crowd, not because the crowd is inherently dangerous but because it resembles the context of the event. Hippocampal dysfunction may impair the ability to distinguish safe from dangerous contexts.

Context also matters for extinction. Extinguished fear can return when the context changes—renewal—which is why exposure therapy should be conducted across multiple contexts rather than in a single clinic room.

10.5 Fear generalisation

Generalisation is the tendency to respond to stimuli that resemble the CS. It is adaptive: a person who has been attacked by one dog may reasonably be wary of others. It becomes maladaptive when generalisation is excessive, so that many neutral situations elicit fear.

Generalisation gradients depend on perceptual similarity, prior experience and anxiety. People with PTSD and anxiety disorders often show broader generalisation than controls, and this has been studied with conditioning paradigms in which participants are trained to discriminate between a threat cue and a safety cue.

The clinical implication is that exposure should include discrimination training: helping the person learn not only that the feared situation is safe but that similar situations can also be safe. This is more demanding than simple habituation.

10.6 Avoidance learning

Avoidance is a learned response that prevents the US from occurring. It is negatively reinforced because it reduces anxiety, which makes it resistant to extinction. Avoidance can be passive (freezing, not going out) or active (leaving, checking, reassurance-seeking).

At the circuit level, active avoidance depends on amygdala–striatal pathways, while passive freezing depends on amygdala–brainstem

pathways (Fenster et al., 2018). The distinction matters because the two patterns may respond to different interventions. A patient who freezes may need graded exposure; a patient who flees may need to learn that staying is tolerable.

Avoidance is central to the maintenance of PTSD. Each avoidance prevents the disconfirmation of the threat prediction, so the belief remains unchanged. Treatment therefore requires reducing avoidance in a planned, tolerable way.

10.7 Extinction and renewal

Extinction is the reduction of the conditioned response when the CS is repeatedly presented without the US. It is new learning, not erasure, and it depends on the ventromedial prefrontal cortex and the amygdala (Milad & Quirk, 2012).

Extinction is context-dependent. Renewal occurs when the CS is tested in a context different from the extinction context. Reinstatement occurs after an unsignalled aversive event. Spontaneous recovery occurs with the passage of time. These phenomena explain relapse after apparently successful treatment.

Clinical translation requires attention to context. Exposure should be conducted in multiple settings, at different times, and with varied stimuli. Relapse should be anticipated and normalised rather than treated as failure.

10.8 Prediction error

Prediction error is the difference between what is expected and what occurs. Learning is driven by prediction error: if the US is fully predicted, little new learning occurs; if it is surprising, learning is stronger.

This principle has practical implications. Exposure that is conducted in a way that confirms the person's expectation ("I knew this would be awful") produces little learning. Exposure that violates the expectation ("I expected to panic and I did not") produces more. Contemporary exposure therapy therefore emphasises expectancy violation rather than mere repetition (Craske et al., 2014).

Prediction error also explains why safety behaviours can undermine treatment: if a person only manages because they carry a water bottle,

they may attribute safety to the bottle rather than learning that the situation is tolerable.

10.9 Intrusive memory

Intrusive memories are involuntary recollections that intrude into awareness. They can be sensory (images, sounds, smells), emotional or somatic. They differ from ordinary memories in their vividness, their sense of presentness and their resistance to voluntary control.

Several mechanisms have been proposed: strong perceptual encoding, impaired contextual binding, and failure of prefrontal inhibition. The evidence supports a role for each, but no single account explains all intrusions. Intrusions can occur in people without PTSD, and not everyone with PTSD has them.

Treatment approaches include trauma-focused cognitive therapy, imagery rescripting and eye movement desensitisation and reprocessing. The evidence supports trauma-focused therapies generally; debates about specific mechanisms are less settled.

Cognitive models emphasise the role of negative appraisals and of poor contextual integration in the persistence of intrusions (Ehlers & Clark, 2000).

10.10 Clinical translation of learning science

Learning science has influenced clinical practice in several ways: exposure therapy, extinction-based models, prediction-error accounts and reconsolidation-based interventions. It has also produced cautionary findings: extinction is not erasure, relapse is normal, and context matters.

The translation is not one-to-one. Clinical exposure is more complex than laboratory extinction: it involves meaning, relationship, safety and the person's goals. A good clinician uses learning principles without reducing the person to a conditioning preparation.

10.11 Safety learning and inhibition

Fear learning has a counterpart: safety learning. A cue that predicts the absence of danger acquires the capacity to reduce fear, and discrimination between threat and safety cues is fundamental to adaptive functioning.

Safety signals differ from extinction. Extinction involves the omission of an expected aversive outcome for a cue that previously predicted it; safety learning involves a distinct cue that predicts safety. In experimental paradigms, safety cues reduce fear and cortisol responses, and they engage ventromedial prefrontal and hippocampal circuits.

In PTSD, discrimination between threat and safety cues is often impaired. A person may respond as if everything is dangerous, which is exhausting and self-reinforcing: overgeneralisation leads to avoidance, avoidance narrows experience, and narrower experience provides fewer opportunities to learn safety.

Treatment implications are practical. Exposure should include explicit discrimination—this situation is safe, this one is uncertain, this one is dangerous—rather than global reassurance. Safety behaviours, however, are not the same as safety learning: carrying a water bottle may reduce anxiety without teaching anything, whereas systematic experience of safety with the behaviour reduced provides new information.

The distinction also matters for services. A clinic that feels unsafe, a waiting room that is chaotic, or a clinician who is unpredictable undermines safety learning regardless of the therapy protocol.

10.12 Beyond fear: disgust, shame and moral injury

Fear is not the only emotion organised by learning, and it is not always the central one in trauma.

Disgust is acquired through associative learning and is more resistant to extinction than fear. It features in sexual trauma, in experiences of contamination and in some forms of self-directed revulsion. Exposure that works for fear may need adaptation for disgust, because the response is not easily reduced by repeated contact alone.

Shame is a self-conscious emotion involving global negative evaluation of the self. It is common after interpersonal trauma, particularly childhood abuse, and it predicts depression, self-harm and social withdrawal. Shame is maintained by concealment and by imagined or actual rejection; interventions that address it directly—compassion-focused approaches, trauma-focused cognitive therapy—may be more useful than exposure alone.

Moral injury describes enduring distress following actions or experiences that violate deeply held moral expectations: perpetrating

harm, witnessing injustice, failing to prevent harm, or being betrayed by trusted authorities (Litz et al., 2009). The concept originated in military contexts and has been extended to other settings. It overlaps with PTSD and with shame, guilt and anger, and its distinctiveness is debated.

These phenomena should not be bolted on to fear models and treated as variants of conditioning. They require formulations that include meaning, identity and value. A veteran who feels contaminated by what he did is not simply exhibiting a conditioned response, and treating him as though he were would miss the point.

Synthesis

Table 10.1 summarises conditioning phenomena and clinical analogues.

Table 10.1. Learning phenomena and clinical parallels

Phenomenon	Laboratory description	Clinical parallel	Implication
Acquisition	CS paired with US	Event followed by danger	Threat learning is rapid
Generalisation	Response to similar cues	Fear of many situations	Discrimination training
Context conditioning	Hippocampus-dependent	Setting-dependent symptoms	Vary exposure contexts
Extinction	CS without US	Exposure therapy	New learning, not erasure
Renewal	Context change	Relapse after treatment	Multi-context practice
Reinstatement	Unsigned aversive event	Relapse after stress	Plan for recurrence
Avoidance	Prevented US	Safety behaviours	Reduce gradually

Composite case study

A patient avoids buses after an assault. Treatment begins with imaginal exposure to the memory, then graded use of buses, then travel at different times and routes. Safety behaviours are reduced gradually. The patient is told that anxiety may return after a stressful event and that this is a normal feature of extinction, not a sign of failure.

Review and discussion questions

Why is extinction not the same as forgetting?

What are the clinical implications of renewal and reinstatement?

How does prediction error change the way exposure should be conducted?

Why can avoidance persist even when the person knows it is unhelpful?

What are the limits of the conditioning model for understanding human trauma?

How should a clinician respond when a patient's fear returns after successful treatment?

Research assignments

- Design a conditioning study that tests generalisation in PTSD, specifying comparison groups and measures.
- Critically appraise one trial of exposure therapy, noting the mechanism it claims to test.
- Write a session-by-session exposure plan for a specific fear, including expectancy violation and context variation.

Chapter summary

Threat learning is the process by which neutral cues acquire the capacity to elicit defensive responses. It depends on amygdala plasticity, is modulated by stress hormones and context, and is maintained by avoidance. Extinction is new inhibitory learning, not erasure, and is subject to relapse. Prediction error determines how much is learned. These principles inform exposure therapy and explain both its effectiveness and its limitations.

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Emotion Regulation, Interoception, and Dissociation

Chapter 11

In this chapter

Learning objectives 133
Introduction 133
11.1 Emotion generation 133
11.2 Regulatory strategies 134
11.3 Cognitive reappraisal 134
11.4 Attention and inhibition 135
11.5 Interoceptive processing 135
11.6 Body awareness 135
11.7 Depersonalisation 136
11.8 Derealisation 136
11.9 State-dependent responding 136
11.10 Assessment of dissociative phenomena 137
11.11 Stabilisation skills 137
11.12 Cultural and spiritual dimensions 138
Synthesis 139
Composite case study 139
Review and discussion questions 139
Research assignments 140
Chapter summary 140
References 140

Central question. How do people manage intense emotion, how do they sense their own bodies, and what happens when these processes become disrupted?

Learning objectives

- distinguish emotion generation from emotion regulation;
- describe major regulatory strategies and their neural correlates;
- explain interoception and its measurement;
- distinguish depersonalisation from derealisation;
- evaluate the assessment of dissociative phenomena.

Introduction

Emotion regulation is the set of processes by which people influence which emotions they have, when they have them, and how they express them. It is not the suppression of feeling; it is the modulation of feeling in the service of goals. Interoception is the sense of the internal state of the body. Dissociation is a disruption of the normally integrated functions of consciousness, memory, identity, body awareness and perception.

These three topics belong together because trauma often disrupts all of them. A survivor may be flooded by emotion, cut off from bodily sensation, or feel detached from themselves and their surroundings. Understanding the mechanisms helps clinicians respond precisely rather than offering generic reassurance.

> **A note on "regulation".** *Regulation is not the same as control. Trying to suppress an emotion often increases it. Effective regulation includes accepting emotion, changing its trajectory, and choosing behaviour that is consistent with one's values.*

11.1 Emotion generation

Emotion generation involves appraisal of a stimulus, physiological response, action tendency and subjective feeling. The classic debate between basic-emotion and constructivist accounts continues: are emotions discrete entities with dedicated circuits, or constructed from more general processes of interoception, memory and categorisation?

For trauma, the practical point is that emotion is not a single event but a process with multiple entry points. A person can intervene at the level of

attention, appraisal, bodily state or behaviour. Different interventions target different points.

The amygdala, insula, prefrontal cortex and brainstem all participate in emotion generation. The amygdala is involved in detecting salient and threat-related stimuli; the insula in representing bodily states; the prefrontal cortex in appraisal and regulation. No single region generates an emotion.

11.2 Regulatory strategies

Gross's process model distinguishes antecedent-focused strategies, which act before the emotion is fully generated, from response-focused strategies, which act after. Reappraisal is antecedent-focused: it changes the meaning of a situation. Suppression is response-focused: it inhibits emotional expression.

Reappraisal is generally associated with better outcomes than suppression, though the distinction is not absolute and depends on context. Other strategies include acceptance, problem-solving, distraction, social support and situation selection.

People with PTSD often rely on avoidance and suppression, which reduce distress in the short term but maintain it in the long term. Therapy aims to broaden the repertoire rather than to prescribe a single strategy.

11.3 Cognitive reappraisal

Reappraisal involves changing the interpretation of an event to change its emotional impact. It depends on prefrontal and cingulate control systems interacting with emotion-generative regions (Ochsner & Gross, 2005).

Reappraisal is effective for many people, but it is not universally helpful. It can be difficult under high arousal, and it can be experienced as invalidating if offered too early. In trauma treatment, reappraisal is usually introduced after safety and stabilisation, and it is distinguished from premature "reframing" that asks the person to minimise what happened.

Cultural context matters. Some reappraisal strategies emphasise acceptance, community or spiritual meaning; others emphasise individual control. Clinicians should ask what is meaningful to the person rather than assuming a single model.

11.4 Attention and inhibition

Attention is the gateway to emotion regulation. Selective attention to threat maintains anxiety; attentional avoidance prevents corrective learning. Both patterns occur in trauma.

Inhibitory control—the capacity to suppress a prepotent response—is supported by prefrontal circuits and is impaired under stress. This is why people make impulsive decisions when highly aroused and why "just stop" is not a useful instruction.

Attention training and mindfulness-based approaches aim to improve attentional control. Evidence is mixed; mindfulness can be helpful for some and can be distressing for others, particularly when interoceptive exposure is introduced too quickly.

11.5 Interoceptive processing

Interoception includes the detection of internal signals, the interpretation of those signals, and the beliefs about one's sensitivity. These components are related but distinct, and they are measured differently.

The insula is central to interoceptive representation. Craig (2009) proposed a posterior-to-anterior progression from primary representation to integrated awareness. This model is influential but its stronger claims remain debated.

Interoceptive accuracy is often measured with heartbeat detection tasks. Performance varies widely, and the relationship between accuracy, anxiety and trauma is inconsistent. Some studies report reduced accuracy in PTSD, others report no difference or increased sensitivity.

11.6 Body awareness

Body awareness is the subjective sense of one's body, including posture, movement, tension and sensation. It can be heightened, diminished or distorted.

Trauma can produce both hyperawareness—scanning for signs of danger in the body—and numbing. Somatic symptoms are common, and they are real: they involve physiological changes, not imagined ones. Assessment should include medical review where indicated.

Body-oriented therapies use awareness, movement and breathing to improve regulation. Evidence for specific approaches is limited, but the general principle—that helping people tolerate and interpret bodily sensations can reduce avoidance—is reasonable.

11.7 Depersonalisation

Depersonalisation is a feeling of detachment from oneself: one's thoughts, feelings, body or actions feel unreal, as if one is an outside observer. It is common in trauma, particularly in the immediate aftermath, and it can be persistent.

Neuroimaging studies of depersonalisation report altered activity in insular, prefrontal and limbic regions, but findings are inconsistent. The experience is subjective and difficult to capture in a scanner.

Clinically, depersonalisation should be distinguished from psychosis: the person retains reality testing—they know the experience is strange, not that it is literally true. It should also be distinguished from absence seizures and other neurological conditions.

11.8 Derealisation

Derealisation is a feeling that the external world is unreal, distant, dreamlike or visually distorted. It often co-occurs with depersonalisation but is conceptually distinct: depersonalisation concerns the self, derealisation the surroundings.

Both are listed in DSM-5 as dissociative symptoms and as part of the dissociative subtype of PTSD. Their presence suggests a different regulatory configuration, with overmodulation rather than undermodulation of affect (Lanius et al., 2010).

Assessment should ask specifically about these experiences, because people may not volunteer them and may not have language for them.

11.9 State-dependent responding

Dissociative states can be state-dependent: memory, affect and behaviour differ depending on which state the person is in. A person may recall an event in one state and be unable to access it in another.

State-dependent learning is not fully understood, and the concept has been overused to explain complex clinical phenomena. It is nonetheless

useful for understanding why a patient may seem inconsistent across sessions and why continuity of care matters.

11.10 Assessment of dissociative phenomena

Assessment should be structured and gentle. Instruments include the Dissociative Experiences Scale and the Clinician-Administered Dissociative States Scale. These are screening tools, not diagnoses.

Assessment should distinguish dissociation from absorption, daydreaming, fatigue and substance effects. It should also consider cultural context: experiences interpreted as spiritual or trance-like may not be pathological.

The clinical response should be proportionate. Mild dissociation may need psychoeducation and grounding; severe dissociation may require staged trauma treatment with attention to stabilisation before processing.

11.11 Stabilisation skills

Stabilisation aims to help a person tolerate arousal without avoidance, so that trauma-focused work becomes possible. It is not a preliminary that must be completed before any meaningful therapy; the evidence supports trauma-focused treatment as the core, with stabilisation as preparation and support.

Grounding techniques direct attention to present sensory information: the feel of a chair, the temperature of the room, the sound of traffic. They work partly by competing with trauma-related imagery and partly by restoring a sense of context. They are more effective when practised before they are needed, and when the person chooses techniques that suit them.

Orienting responses—looking around, naming objects, moving—interrupt the immobility and narrowing of attention that accompany threat. Controlled breathing can reduce hyperventilation-related dizziness, but it is not a universal remedy, and forcing slow breathing can increase panic in some people.

Affect labelling—putting feelings into words—is associated with reduced amygdala reactivity in imaging studies, though the effect is modest and not specific to trauma. Naming an emotion is not the same as explaining it away, and clinicians should avoid implying that a correct label will resolve distress.

The "window of tolerance" is a widely used clinical metaphor for optimal arousal. It has intuitive value but limited empirical grounding, and it should not be treated as a measured physiological boundary. Used as a shared language for pacing, it is helpful; used as a precise diagnostic criterion, it is not.

Stabilisation should be evaluated like any other component: if it is not helping the person engage, the plan should change rather than the person being judged unprepared.

11.12 Cultural and spiritual dimensions

Emotion regulation is shaped by culture. Some traditions emphasise restraint and emotional control; others value expression, lament or collective mourning. What counts as appropriate distress, and what counts as recovery, varies.

Spiritual and religious practices—prayer, meditation, ritual, community observance—are used by many people to regulate emotion and to make meaning of suffering. Research on religion and mental health reports modest associations with wellbeing, but the mechanisms are nonspecific and the effects depend on content, community and context. Religious coping can support resilience; it can also intensify guilt, fear or exclusion.

Clinical practice should ask, without presumption, whether spirituality or religion matters to the person and whether they want it included. Clinicians should not prescribe religious practice, denigrate it, or substitute it for evidence-based treatment. Nor should they treat a person's faith as a symptom.

Where a person's distress is expressed through spiritual language—possession, curse, ancestral displeasure—the clinician's task is to understand the meaning, exclude medical and psychiatric causes, and negotiate a plan that respects the person's framework while offering what the service can provide. Collaboration with trusted community figures may help, provided confidentiality and consent are respected.

Cultural competence is not a list of traits attached to groups. It is a disciplined curiosity about this person's language, history, family and expectations, combined with humility about what the clinician does not know.

Synthesis

Table 11.1 summarises regulatory and dissociative phenomena.

Table 11.1. Regulation, interoception and dissociation

Process	Description	Trauma pattern	Clinical response
Reappraisal	Changing meaning	Often impaired under high arousal	Introduce after stabilisation
Suppression	Inhibiting expression	Common but costly	Broaden repertoire
Interoception	Sensing internal state	Hyper- or hypo-awareness	Graded exposure to sensation
Depersonalisation	Detachment from self	Common in dissociation	Grounding, assessment
Derealisation	Unreality of surroundings	Common in dissociation	Safety, orientation
State dependence	Access varies by state	Inconsistent presentation	Continuity of care

Composite case study

A patient describes feeling "outside my body" during arguments and being unable to remember what she said. Assessment identifies depersonalisation and state-dependent memory. The plan includes grounding skills, reducing conflict triggers, and trauma-focused therapy with attention to dissociative barriers. Medication is reviewed for any contribution.

Review and discussion questions

Why can suppression increase distress?

What are the limits of reappraisal as a trauma intervention?

Why is interoceptive accuracy not a straightforward marker of trauma?

How would you distinguish depersonalisation from psychosis?

What are the risks of using dissociation as an explanation for all inconsistency?

How should cultural meaning be incorporated into assessment of dissociation?

Research assignments

- Design a study of interoceptive accuracy in PTSD that controls for anxiety and medication.
- Critically appraise one measure of dissociation, noting reliability and validity.
- Write a clinical protocol for responding to dissociation during trauma-focused therapy.

Chapter summary

Emotion regulation, interoception and dissociation are interrelated processes that are frequently disrupted by trauma. Regulation includes appraisal, attention, acceptance and behaviour; interoception involves sensing and interpreting internal signals; dissociation involves disruptions of awareness, memory and identity. Assessment should be specific, culturally informed and medically alert. Treatment should be staged, with attention to stabilisation before processing.

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Neuroimmunology and Inflammation

Chapter 12

In this chapter

Learning objectives 142
Introduction 142
12.1 Innate immunity 142
12.2 Adaptive immunity 143
12.3 Cytokines and the brain 143
12.4 Neuroinflammation 144
12.5 Sickness behaviour 144
12.6 PTSD and inflammation 144
12.7 Early-life adversity and immune programming 145
12.8 Anti-inflammatory treatment 145
12.9 Immune consequences of chronic stress 146
12.10 Translational caveats 146
12.11 The gut–brain axis 146
12.12 Measuring immune markers in trauma research 147
Synthesis 148
Composite case study 148
Review and discussion questions 148
Research assignments 149
Chapter summary 149
References 149

Central question. How does the immune system influence the brain, and what role does inflammation play in trauma-related conditions?

Learning objectives

- describe the main immune signalling pathways relevant to the brain;
- explain how the brain and immune system communicate;
- evaluate evidence on inflammation in PTSD and depression;
- explain sickness behaviour and its overlap with trauma symptoms;
- describe the limits of anti-inflammatory treatment strategies.

Introduction

The immune system is not separate from the brain. It influences mood, cognition, sleep and behaviour, and the brain influences the immune system. This reciprocal relationship means that trauma-related psychological processes can leave biological traces in immune function, and that immune activation can produce psychological states that resemble trauma symptoms.

The chapter begins with basic immunology, describes neuroimmune communication, examines the evidence on inflammation in PTSD, and considers clinical implications. It is careful about causality: inflammation is unlikely to be a single cause of PTSD, but it may be a mechanism in some people and a promising target for some treatments.

> **A note on "inflammation".** *In popular usage, inflammation refers vaguely to something wrong. In immunology, it refers to a coordinated response to injury or infection, involving immune cells, cytokines and vascular changes. Chronic low-grade inflammation means persistent elevation of markers such as C-reactive protein and interleukin-6 without an obvious acute source. It is a statistical concept applied to populations, not a diagnosis for an individual.*

12.1 Innate immunity

Innate immunity is the first line of defence. It includes physical barriers, phagocytes, natural killer cells and complement proteins. It recognises molecular patterns associated with pathogens or damage through pattern-recognition receptors such as Toll-like receptors.

Innate immune activation produces cytokines—small signalling proteins including interleukins, tumour necrosis factor and interferons. These

molecules coordinate the response and can enter the brain or signal across the blood–brain barrier.

The innate immune system is fast and nonspecific. It does not require prior exposure, and it does not produce immunological memory. It is nonetheless powerful, and its activation can produce behavioural changes within hours.

12.2 Adaptive immunity

Adaptive immunity is slower and specific. It involves T and B lymphocytes, which recognise particular antigens and generate memory. It is the basis of vaccination and of long-lasting protection against pathogens.

Adaptive immunity can also produce autoimmunity, in which the response targets the body's own tissues. Some autoantibody-mediated conditions—such as anti-NMDA receptor encephalitis—present with psychiatric symptoms, which is why sudden psychiatric presentations sometimes warrant neurological investigation.

The relevance to trauma is indirect. Chronic stress can alter adaptive immune function, including antibody responses to vaccination and latency of latent viruses. These effects suggest that psychological stress has measurable immunological consequences.

12.3 Cytokines and the brain

Cytokines communicate with the brain through several routes: through circumventricular organs that lack a blood–brain barrier, through vagal signalling, through active transport, and through local production by microglia and astrocytes.

In the brain, cytokines affect neurotransmitter metabolism, synaptic plasticity and neuroendocrine function. Interleukin-1 and tumour necrosis factor can alter serotonin metabolism, affect hippocampal neurogenesis and produce behavioural changes. This is a mechanism by which systemic illness affects mood and cognition.

Peripheral cytokine changes do not map directly onto brain cytokine changes. The compartments are related but not identical, and this limits the interpretation of blood-based biomarkers.

12.4 Neuroinflammation

Neuroinflammation refers to immune activation within the central nervous system, involving microglia, astrocytes and immune cells. It is a normal response to injury or infection and becomes problematic when it is excessive or persistent.

Microglia are the resident immune cells of the brain. They survey the environment, respond to damage and remove debris. In chronic stress models, microglia show altered morphology and increased expression of inflammatory markers, and this has been linked to behavioural changes.

Human evidence on neuroinflammation is limited by the difficulty of imaging immune activity in the brain. Positron emission tomography with translocator protein ligands has been used to study microglial activation, but the method has limitations and findings are preliminary.

12.5 Sickness behaviour

Sickness behaviour is a coordinated set of responses to infection: fever, fatigue, reduced appetite, social withdrawal, anhedonia and slowed cognition. It is adaptive in the short term because it conserves energy for immune defence.

Sickness behaviour overlaps substantially with depression and with some trauma symptoms. This overlap has led to the hypothesis that some cases of depression involve inflammatory processes, and to trials of anti-inflammatory treatments.

The overlap also means that the same behaviour can have different causes. Fatigue and social withdrawal in a trauma survivor may reflect depression, inflammation, sleep disruption or all three. Assessment should not assume a single mechanism.

12.6 PTSD and inflammation

Meta-analyses report elevated levels of C-reactive protein, interleukin-6, interleukin-1 beta and tumour necrosis factor in people with PTSD compared with controls. Effect sizes are small to moderate, and there is substantial heterogeneity.

Several explanations are possible, and they are not mutually exclusive. Trauma and PTSD may cause inflammation through stress physiology. Inflammation may contribute to PTSD risk or severity. Depression, smoking, alcohol use, obesity and sleep disturbance may confound the

relationship. Childhood adversity itself is associated with elevated inflammation, which suggests a developmental pathway.

Longitudinal studies are needed to establish temporality, and they are limited. At present, inflammation is a promising marker and candidate mechanism, not a diagnostic test or proven treatment target.

A review of this literature reports elevated interleukin-6 and other inflammatory markers in PTSD, with substantial heterogeneity across studies (Hori & Kim, 2019).

12.7 Early-life adversity and immune programming

Early-life adversity is associated with altered immune function in adulthood, including elevated inflammatory markers and altered antibody responses. This may be one mechanism by which childhood adversity increases risk for a broad range of physical and mental health conditions.

Proposed mechanisms include stress-induced glucocorticoid resistance, altered HPA–immune communication, changes in the gut microbiome and accelerated biological ageing. Each has some support, none is fully established.

The implication is not that adversity determines immune fate. It is that adversity can shift developmental trajectories, and that interventions which improve social conditions may have immunological benefits.

12.8 Anti-inflammatory treatment

Anti-inflammatory drugs have been studied for depression, with modest effects in some subgroups. For PTSD, the evidence is much more limited, and no anti-inflammatory treatment is established.

Risks are significant: immunosuppression, gastrointestinal bleeding, cardiovascular events and interactions with other medication. The use of anti-inflammatory drugs for trauma-related conditions should be within research or specialist care, not general recommendation.

Non-drug approaches that reduce inflammation—exercise, sleep, diet, social connection—have better safety profiles and broader benefits. They are not a substitute for trauma treatment, but they are reasonable adjuncts.

12.9 Immune consequences of chronic stress

Chronic stress alters immune function through glucocorticoid signalling, catecholamines and the sympathetic nervous system. It can suppress some aspects of immunity, such as antiviral responses, and enhance others, such as inflammatory responses.

This dual effect helps explain why chronically stressed people may be more susceptible to infections and also more prone to inflammatory conditions. The immune system is not simply suppressed or enhanced; it is differently regulated.

Clinically, this argues for attention to infection, vaccination, wound healing and chronic disease in trauma-exposed populations, particularly where access to care is limited.

12.10 Translational caveats

The immune literature is often oversold. Headlines claim that trauma causes inflammation, that inflammation causes depression, or that a drug will cure both. The reality is more cautious.

Cytokines are pleiotropic, meaning they have many effects depending on context, concentration and target. Blood markers do not reliably reflect brain processes. Animal models do not fully capture human trauma. And the populations studied often differ in ways that affect immune measures.

A responsible account presents the evidence as suggestive rather than definitive and emphasises the need for well-powered longitudinal and intervention studies.

12.11 The gut–brain axis

The gastrointestinal tract contains a large and diverse microbial community, and it is innervated by the vagus and by enteric neurons (Cryan et al., 2019). Signals travel in both directions: the brain influences motility, secretion and permeability, and the gut influences immune function, satiety and behaviour.

Several mechanisms are plausible. Microbial metabolites, including short-chain fatty acids produced by fermentation of dietary fibre, influence epithelial integrity and immune signalling. The vagus carries information from the gut to the brainstem, where it can influence autonomic and limbic activity. Intestinal permeability, sometimes

described loosely as a "leaky gut", allows bacterial products to enter the circulation and stimulate inflammatory responses.

The evidence in humans is mostly correlational. Studies report differences in microbial composition between groups defined by trauma history, depression or inflammation, but the effect sizes are modest, the confounders are numerous (diet, medication, housing, smoking, sleep), and the direction of causality is unresolved. Probiotic trials in psychiatry have produced small and inconsistent effects.

Commercial microbiome testing and probiotic marketing frequently outrun the evidence. A clinician should be cautious about attributing trauma-related symptoms to microbial imbalance or recommending expensive supplements on that basis. General measures that support metabolic and immune health—adequate diet, sleep, exercise and treatment of gastrointestinal disease—are reasonable and do not depend on speculative mechanisms.

12.12 Measuring immune markers in trauma research

The most commonly reported markers are C-reactive protein, interleukin-6 and tumour necrosis factor. Each behaves differently, and each is affected by factors unrelated to trauma.

C-reactive protein is produced by the liver in response to interleukin-6. It rises acutely with infection or injury and is influenced by body mass, smoking, medication and chronic disease. A single value cannot distinguish trauma-related inflammation from a mild respiratory infection or metabolic condition.

Interleukin-6 is secreted in pulses, has a short half-life, and varies with time of day, sleep and exercise. A single plasma measurement is therefore a poor summary of chronic inflammatory state. Tumour necrosis factor is similar: concentrations are low, assays vary, and the signal is easily obscured by pre-analytical handling.

Measurement quality matters as much as study design. Sample timing, fasting status, anticoagulant, centrifugation delay, storage temperature, freeze–thaw cycles and assay sensitivity all influence results. Studies that do not report these details are difficult to interpret, and comparisons across laboratories require standardisation.

For research, preregistration of the primary marker, adjustment for the main confounders, reporting of assay limits and avoidance of multiple

uncorrected comparisons are minimum standards. For clinical practice, immune markers should be ordered to answer a specific medical question, not to confirm a psychological formulation.

Synthesis

Table 12.1 summarises immune pathways and trauma relevance.

Table 12.1. Immune pathways and trauma relevance

Pathway	Key mediators	Function	Trauma relevance	Evidence
Innate immunity	Cytokines, phagocytes	Rapid defence	Elevated CRP, IL-6 in PTSD	Moderate cross-sectional
Adaptive immunity	T and B cells	Specific defence, memory	Altered antibody response to stress	Limited
Microglia	Brain immune cells	Surveillance, pruning	Stress-related activation	Mostly animal
HPA–immune	Glucocorticoids	Immune modulation	Glucocorticoid resistance	Moderate
Sickness behaviour	Cytokines	Energy conservation	Overlap with depression	Conceptual

Composite case study

A patient with PTSD and depression has elevated inflammatory markers and asks whether she has "brain inflammation". The clinician explains that elevated markers are common in many conditions, are not specific to brain inflammation, and do not currently guide treatment. The plan addresses sleep, exercise, smoking and depression, with trauma-focused therapy as the core treatment.

Review and discussion questions

How do cytokines communicate with the brain?

Why is elevated CRP not a diagnostic test for PTSD?

What is sickness behaviour, and how does it overlap with depression?

Why are longitudinal studies needed in psychoneuroimmunology?

What are the risks of anti-inflammatory treatment for trauma-related conditions?

How might early adversity alter immune development?

Research assignments

- Design a longitudinal study of inflammation and PTSD that controls for smoking and sleep.
- Critically appraise one trial of an anti-inflammatory drug in depression.
- Write a plain-language explanation of the immune findings for clinicians without immunology training.

Chapter summary

The immune system communicates with the brain through cytokines, vagal pathways and microglial activity, influencing mood, cognition and behaviour. PTSD is associated with small elevations in inflammatory markers, but causality and clinical utility are unresolved. Sickness behaviour overlaps with depression and trauma symptoms. Anti-inflammatory treatment is not established for PTSD, and non-drug approaches with broader benefits should be considered. Claims in this field should be proportionate to the evidence.

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Neuroimaging: Methods, Findings, and Limits

Chapter 13

In this chapter

Learning objectives 151
Introduction 151
13.1 Structural imaging 151
13.2 Functional MRI 152
13.3 Positron emission tomography 152
13.4 Connectivity and networks 152
13.5 Replicated findings in trauma 153
13.6 Fear circuitry 153
13.7 Childhood maltreatment 154
13.8 Predictive modelling 154
13.9 Publication bias and replicability 154
13.10 Ethical communication 155
13.11 Designing an imaging study 155
13.12 Multimodal and longitudinal designs 156
Synthesis 156
Composite case study 157
Review and discussion questions 157
Research assignments 157
Chapter summary 158
References 158

Central question. What can brain imaging tell us about trauma, and what can it not tell us?

Learning objectives

- describe the main neuroimaging methods and what each measures;
- explain the difference between structure, function, connectivity and chemistry;
- evaluate replicated findings in trauma neuroimaging;
- recognise common misinterpretations of imaging results;
- explain the limits of imaging as a diagnostic tool.

Introduction

Neuroimaging has transformed the study of trauma by allowing researchers to observe the living brain. It has also generated some of the most misleading claims in the field. This chapter explains what imaging methods measure, summarises replicated findings, and sets out the limits of inference.

The central point is that imaging measures biological signals that are related to brain activity indirectly. Functional magnetic resonance imaging, for example, measures changes in blood oxygenation, not neuronal firing. Interpreting those signals requires assumptions, models and statistics, and the results depend on the task, the sample, the analysis pipeline and the comparison group.

> **A note on brain images.** *A brain image in a news article is usually a statistical map overlaid on an anatomical template. Coloured areas indicate where a statistical test exceeded a threshold. They do not show "activity" in the way a photograph shows a face, and a difference between groups does not establish cause, diagnosis or individual prediction.*

13.1 Structural imaging

Structural imaging includes computed tomography and magnetic resonance imaging. CT is fast and useful in acute settings for detecting haemorrhage, fracture and mass lesions. MRI provides higher resolution and better soft-tissue contrast, and is used for volumetry, cortical thickness and white-matter imaging.

Structural studies in PTSD have reported reduced hippocampal volume, reduced anterior cingulate and orbitofrontal cortex volume, and altered

amygdala volume. Effect sizes are modest, findings are heterogeneous, and direction of causality is unclear. Childhood adversity, depression, alcohol use and medication may all contribute.

Importantly, group differences do not translate into individual diagnosis. The distributions overlap substantially, and no structural measure can identify a person with PTSD.

13.2 Functional MRI

Functional MRI measures blood-oxygen-level-dependent (BOLD) signal, which reflects changes in deoxygenated haemoglobin and is coupled to neural activity through neurovascular mechanisms. It has good spatial resolution and moderate temporal resolution.

Task-based fMRI compares activity during different conditions. In trauma research, common paradigms include fear conditioning, extinction recall, emotional face processing, symptom provocation and working-memory tasks. Results depend heavily on the paradigm, and a finding in one task may not generalise.

Resting-state fMRI measures spontaneous fluctuations in BOLD signal and is used to estimate functional connectivity between regions. It is attractive because it does not require a task, but connectivity estimates are sensitive to preprocessing, motion and physiological noise.

13.3 Positron emission tomography

PET uses radiotracers to measure metabolic activity or receptor availability. Fluorodeoxyglucose PET measures glucose metabolism; ligand-based PET can measure receptors, transporters or immune markers.

PET has lower spatial and temporal resolution than MRI and involves radiation exposure. It is used mainly in research and in specific clinical questions, such as distinguishing neurodegenerative conditions. In trauma research, PET has been used to study receptor systems and, more recently, microglial activation.

13.4 Connectivity and networks

Connectivity analyses examine how regions co-vary or interact. Functional connectivity is typically estimated from correlations in time series; effective connectivity attempts to model directed influence.

Graph-theoretic approaches describe network properties such as modularity, efficiency and hub structure.

The triple-network model describes interactions among the default mode network, the salience network and the central executive network (Menon, 2011). In PTSD, studies have reported altered coupling among these networks, but findings vary with analysis method and sample.

Connectivity findings should be interpreted cautiously. Correlation does not establish direction, and network boundaries are defined by analysis choices rather than by anatomical borders.

13.5 Replicated findings in trauma

Several findings have been reported repeatedly, though with heterogeneity. The amygdala tends to show heightened reactivity to threat-related stimuli (Etkin & Wager, 2007). The ventromedial prefrontal cortex tends to show reduced activation and reduced connectivity with the amygdala. The hippocampus shows altered structure and function, particularly in relation to contextual processing and memory.

The dissociative subtype shows a different pattern, with heightened prefrontal control over limbic regions rather than reduced control (Lanius et al., 2010). This is an important corrective to the assumption that PTSD always involves "under-regulation".

These findings are group-level and probabilistic. They do not describe any individual patient, and they should not be used to justify claims about a person's brain based on a single scan.

Recent reviews of the imaging literature in adults and youth reach broadly similar conclusions about amygdala and prefrontal involvement, while noting persistent methodological limitations (Hinojosa et al., 2024).

13.6 Fear circuitry

The fear circuitry model emphasises the amygdala, hippocampus, insula, anterior cingulate and prefrontal cortex. The amygdala detects salience and supports threat learning; the hippocampus provides context; the insula represents bodily state; the anterior cingulate integrates conflict, pain and affect; the prefrontal cortex regulates responses.

This model is useful for organising findings but should not be reified. Fear is not located in a single region, and the same regions participate in many other functions.

13.7 Childhood maltreatment

Neuroimaging studies of childhood maltreatment report structural and functional differences, including reduced hippocampal and corpus callosum volume, altered amygdala reactivity and altered prefrontal connectivity. Teicher and Samson (2016) reviewed this literature and estimated that maltreatment accounts for a substantial proportion of the population attributable risk for childhood-onset psychiatric disorders.

The interpretation is complicated by confounding: maltreatment often co-occurs with poverty, neglect, family instability and other adversities. Studies that attempt to isolate maltreatment effects find smaller and more specific differences than studies that compare broadly disadvantaged groups.

13.8 Predictive modelling

Machine-learning approaches have been used to classify individuals as having PTSD versus not, or to predict treatment response. Reported accuracies are often inflated by small samples, overfitting and lack of independent validation.

For a biomarker to be clinically useful, it must add value beyond existing assessment, be validated in diverse populations, and have acceptable cost and burden. No neuroimaging biomarker currently meets these criteria for PTSD.

13.9 Publication bias and replicability

Neuroimaging has well-documented problems with replicability. Small samples produce unstable estimates; flexible analyses allow many possible results; selective reporting of significant findings is common; and effect sizes in published studies tend to be larger than in replication attempts.

Larger consortia, preregistration, data sharing and multiverse analyses are improving the situation. Readers should check sample size, replication status and whether the analysis was preregistered before accepting a finding.

13.10 Ethical communication

Imaging findings are persuasive to the public and to courts. They can be used to argue that a person is damaged, that they are not responsible, or that their symptoms are real. These uses may sometimes serve justice, but they can also reinforce stigma and biological determinism.

Communicating imaging research responsibly means avoiding claims that exceed the data, explaining group-level findings, and resisting the temptation to localise complex experiences to a single region. It also means involving people with lived experience in how findings are represented.

13.11 Designing an imaging study

An imaging study begins with a question that imaging can answer. "What does trauma do to the brain" is not a research question; "do adults with PTSD show greater amygdala response to masked threat faces than trauma-exposed controls without PTSD" is.

Power is the first constraint. Effect sizes in psychiatric imaging are small, and underpowered studies produce unstable and inflated estimates. Sample sizes in the dozens are common and usually inadequate for anything beyond a large effect. Power calculations should be reported, and they should be based on realistic effect sizes rather than optimistic ones.

Comparison groups determine interpretation. Healthy controls differ from trauma-exposed people in many ways beyond diagnosis, so trauma-exposed controls without PTSD are often more informative. Comorbidity, medication, substance use, sleep and motion must be measured and, where possible, modelled.

Task design matters. A task that does not reliably engage the process of interest will produce null or ambiguous results. Pilot testing, manipulation checks and reporting of behavioural data are essential; a group difference in brain activation is uninterpretable if the groups also differ in performance or effort.

Analysis choices multiply degrees of freedom. Preprocessing pipelines, smoothing, motion correction, region definitions, contrast specification and multiple-comparison correction all affect results. Preregistration, analysis code and reporting of the full pipeline reduce the risk that a finding reflects the analyst rather than the brain.

13.12 Multimodal and longitudinal designs

No single imaging method captures the brain. Structure, function, connectivity, chemistry and blood flow provide different views, and combining them can constrain interpretation. A structural difference without a functional correlate, or a connectivity difference without a behavioural one, is a hypothesis rather than a mechanism.

Multimodal studies are expensive and analytically demanding. Combining datasets requires attention to registration, scaling and missing data, and the risk of spurious findings increases with each additional analysis.

Longitudinal designs are more informative than cross-sectional ones because they can distinguish pre-existing differences from consequences of trauma. They are difficult: attrition is often related to symptoms, repeated scanning is burdensome, and the interval between assessments may miss the relevant change.

Consortia and data-sharing initiatives have increased sample sizes and improved reproducibility. They have also revealed how much variation exists across sites, scanners and populations, and how poorly some findings generalise. The ENIGMA-style approach—harmonised analysis of many cohorts—is now standard for genetic and structural questions, though it cannot fix weak measurement.

For trauma research, the most valuable longitudinal questions are about prediction and mechanism: which responses shortly after an event predict later symptoms, and which changes accompany recovery. Answering them requires repeated measurement, low attrition and clear prespecification.

Synthesis

Table 13.1 summarises imaging methods.

Table 13.1. Neuroimaging methods and their limits

Method	Measures	Strengths	Limits
CT	X-ray attenuation	Fast, accessible	Radiation, low soft-tissue contrast
Structural MRI	Anatomy	High resolution	Correlation not causation
Task fMRI	BOLD during task	Spatial localisation	Indirect, task-dependent
Resting-state fMRI	Spontaneous BOLD	No task required	Sensitive to motion and preprocessing
PET	Metabolism, receptors	Molecular specificity	Radiation, cost, low resolution
EEG/MEG	Electrical/magnetic fields	Millisecond timing	Poor spatial resolution

Composite case study

A patient brings a private fMRI report claiming "amygdala hyperactivity consistent with trauma". The clinician explains that group-level findings cannot be applied to an individual, that the scan does not establish diagnosis, and that the report should not be treated as evidence in a legal dispute without expert review. The clinical assessment proceeds on the basis of history and symptoms.

Review and discussion questions

What does BOLD signal actually measure?

Why do group differences not support individual diagnosis?

How does the dissociative subtype complicate the fear-circuitry model?

What are the main sources of irreplicability in imaging research?

How should imaging evidence be presented in legal settings?

What would a clinically useful biomarker need to demonstrate?

Research assignments

- Critically appraise one task-fMRI study of PTSD, noting sample size and correction methods.

- Design a preregistered replication of an amygdala reactivity finding.
- Write guidance for journalists on reporting brain imaging studies.

Chapter summary

Neuroimaging provides indirect measures of brain structure, function, connectivity and chemistry and has identified replicable group-level differences in trauma. These findings have advanced mechanistic understanding but do not support individual diagnosis, and the field faces serious replicability challenges. Responsible communication requires accuracy about what the methods measure, humility about inference, and resistance to biological determinism.

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Sleep, Circadian Rhythms, and Trauma

Chapter 14

In this chapter

Learning objectives 160
Introduction 160
14.1 Sleep architecture 160
14.2 Two-process model 161
14.3 Sleep and emotional memory 161
14.4 Trauma and insomnia 162
14.5 Nightmares 162
14.6 Sleep and fear extinction 162
14.7 Circadian disruption 163
14.8 Sleep in special populations 163
14.9 Assessment of sleep 163
14.10 Sleep interventions 164
14.11 Measuring sleep in clinical and research settings 164
14.12 Nightmares, dreams and emotional processing 165
Synthesis 165
Composite case study 166
Review and discussion questions 166
Research assignments 167
Chapter summary 167
References 167

Central question. Why is sleep so often disrupted after trauma, and why does treating sleep matter for recovery?

Learning objectives

- describe normal sleep architecture and regulation;
- explain the relationship between sleep and emotional memory;
- identify the main trauma-related sleep disorders;
- evaluate treatments for insomnia and nightmares;
- explain circadian disruption in displaced and shift-working populations.

Introduction

Sleep is not a passive state. It is an active process that consolidates memory, regulates emotion, restores immune and metabolic function, and clears metabolic waste. Trauma disrupts sleep, and disrupted sleep maintains trauma symptoms. This reciprocal relationship makes sleep both a consequence and a driver of illness, and it makes sleep an unusually tractable treatment target.

This chapter describes normal sleep, the effects of trauma on sleep, and evidence-based interventions. It also considers circadian rhythms, which are often overlooked in trauma care but are central to sleep, mood and metabolism.

> **A note on sleep measurement.** *Polysomnography measures brain activity, eye movements and muscle tone, and is the reference standard for sleep staging. Actigraphy estimates sleep from movement and is useful for patterns over time. Self-report is valuable but correlates imperfectly with objective measures. Research findings depend heavily on which method was used.*

14.1 Sleep architecture

Sleep consists of non-rapid eye movement (NREM) and rapid eye movement (REM) stages. NREM includes N1, N2 and N3 (slow-wave sleep). Sleep cycles through these stages roughly every 90 minutes, with more slow-wave sleep early in the night and more REM later.

Slow-wave sleep is associated with memory consolidation, particularly for declarative memory, and with growth hormone release and metabolic restoration. REM sleep is associated with emotional

processing, dream content and memory integration, although its functions remain debated.

Sleep architecture changes across the lifespan: slow-wave sleep declines with age, and sleep becomes more fragmented. These changes affect the interpretation of studies that compare trauma survivors with controls of different ages.

Sleep disturbance is now regarded as a central rather than secondary feature of PTSD, and may be a modifiable risk factor for poor outcome (Germain, 2013).

14.2 Two-process model

The two-process model describes sleep regulation by a homeostatic process and a circadian process. The homeostatic process tracks sleep pressure, which increases with time awake and dissipates during sleep. The circadian process is driven by the suprachiasmatic nucleus and regulates the timing of sleep and wakefulness.

The interaction of these processes determines sleep timing and quality. Irregular schedules, daytime napping and light exposure at night disrupt the interaction, producing insomnia-like symptoms even in people without trauma.

For trauma survivors, regularity is therapeutic. Consistent wake times, morning light and limited naps support the circadian system and reduce sleep pressure dysregulation.

14.3 Sleep and emotional memory

Sleep supports the consolidation of emotional memory and the integration of emotional experience. Some studies suggest that REM sleep specifically supports the processing of emotional content, reducing the affective charge of memories while preserving their informational content.

Sleep deprivation increases amygdala reactivity and reduces prefrontal control, producing emotional dysregulation. This is one mechanism by which insomnia maintains trauma symptoms: poor sleep makes emotional responses more intense and regulation more difficult.

The relationship is bidirectional. Trauma disrupts sleep, and poor sleep increases reactivity to trauma reminders. Treating sleep can therefore produce benefits beyond sleep itself.

14.4 Trauma and insomnia

Insomnia is common after trauma and is a risk factor for the development of PTSD. It includes difficulty initiating sleep, maintaining sleep and early waking, with associated daytime impairment.

Cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia (CBT-I) is first-line treatment. It includes stimulus control, sleep restriction, cognitive restructuring and relaxation. It is effective in trauma populations, though clinicians sometimes worry that sleep restriction will exacerbate distress; with appropriate monitoring, it is usually well tolerated.

Medication can be useful short-term but carries risks of dependence, tolerance and falls, particularly in older adults. Antidepressants with sedating effects are sometimes used, but the evidence in PTSD is limited.

Insomnia frequently precedes and predicts PTSD, and targeted sleep treatment may accelerate recovery (Germain, 2013).

14.5 Nightmares

Nightmares are vivid, distressing dreams that awaken the sleeper and are remembered. They are common after trauma and can be chronic.

Imagery rehearsal therapy is a well-supported treatment. It involves recording the nightmare, changing its content to a less distressing version, and rehearsing the new version during the day. It reduces nightmare frequency and severity in many patients.

Other approaches include exposure, relaxation and medication. Prazosin, an alpha-1 antagonist, has been studied for trauma nightmares with mixed results; a large randomised trial in military veterans did not find a significant benefit over placebo (Raskind et al., 2018). This is an example of a plausible mechanism not translating into reliable clinical effect.

14.6 Sleep and fear extinction

Sleep supports extinction learning. In experimental studies, sleep after extinction training is associated with better retention of extinction memory, and REM sleep has been implicated.

This suggests that sleep interventions could enhance exposure therapy. Preliminary studies have tested this, but the evidence is not yet sufficient for routine clinical protocols. The practical implication is

simpler: protect sleep during trauma treatment, and avoid scheduling intensive sessions when the patient is severely sleep-deprived.

14.7 Circadian disruption

Circadian rhythms are synchronised by light, activity, meals and social cues. Disruption occurs with shift work, jet lag, hospitalisation, displacement and irregular routines.

Refugees and displaced people often experience multiple forms of circadian disruption: travel across time zones, irregular shelter conditions, night-time danger and loss of routine. These disruptions affect sleep, mood, metabolism and immune function.

Assessment should include sleep timing, light exposure, work schedules and living conditions. Interventions should be practical: morning light, regular meals, safe sleeping arrangements and reduced night-time light where possible.

14.8 Sleep in special populations

Sleep problems are common in children, older adults, pregnant people and people with comorbid medical conditions. Each group requires adaptation.

Children's sleep is affected by developmental stage, caregiving and environment. Nightmares and bedtime resistance are common after trauma, and parental involvement is essential. Older adults have more fragmented sleep and more medical comorbidity, and medication risks are higher. Pregnancy involves physiological sleep changes and specific safety considerations.

Institutional settings—shelters, hospitals, detention centres—often have conditions that make sleep difficult: noise, light, fear and lack of control. These are environmental problems that require environmental solutions.

14.9 Assessment of sleep

Assessment should include sleep history, sleep diary, screening for insomnia, nightmares, restless legs, sleep apnoea and circadian rhythm disorders. Comorbid conditions such as depression, anxiety, pain and substance use should be assessed.

Actigraphy can be useful for patterns over days or weeks. Polysomnography is indicated when sleep apnoea, narcolepsy or other primary sleep disorders are suspected.

Assessment should be trauma-informed: questions about sleep can evoke distressing content, and the bedroom may be associated with danger.

14.10 Sleep interventions

CBT-I is the first-line intervention for chronic insomnia. It is effective, durable and can be delivered in person, in groups or digitally. Imagery rehearsal therapy is first-line for nightmares.

Adjunctive strategies include sleep hygiene education, relaxation training and light therapy for circadian disturbance. Medication should be time-limited and reviewed regularly.

Sleep interventions should be integrated into trauma treatment rather than offered as an afterthought. Improving sleep can reduce reactivity, improve engagement and make trauma-focused work more tolerable.

14.11 Measuring sleep in clinical and research settings

Polysomnography records electroencephalography, eye movements, muscle tone, respiration, oxygen saturation and often cardiac activity. It is the reference standard for staging sleep and for diagnosing sleep apnoea, narcolepsy and periodic limb movement disorder. It is also expensive, unfamiliar and usually conducted for one night in a laboratory, which may not represent habitual sleep.

Home sleep apnoea testing is simpler and adequate for many cases of suspected obstructive sleep apnoea, but it underestimates severity when total sleep time is unknown. Actigraphy, usually a wrist device, estimates sleep and wakefulness from movement over days or weeks. It is useful for circadian patterns and for tracking change, but it misclassifies quiet wakefulness as sleep.

Self-report instruments, including sleep diaries and validated questionnaires such as the Insomnia Severity Index, capture the person's experience and its daytime consequences. They correlate imperfectly with objective measures, and that discrepancy is itself informative: sleep

state misperception is common in insomnia and should be addressed in treatment rather than dismissed.

Consumer wearables increasingly claim to measure sleep stages. Validation studies show wide variation between devices and settings, and proprietary algorithms are often undisclosed. They can support behavioural change, but they should not be treated as diagnostic. Preoccupation with device-derived sleep scores has been described as orthosomnia and can itself worsen insomnia (Baron et al., 2017).

14.12 Nightmares, dreams and emotional processing

Nightmares are vivid, disturbing dreams that awaken the sleeper and are remembered on waking. They are common after trauma, but not all post-traumatic nightmares replay the event; many involve themes of threat, loss or helplessness. This matters clinically, because imagery rehearsal therapy works with the nightmare as it occurs rather than requiring fidelity to the original event.

Why we dream remains unsettled. Threat-simulation accounts propose that dreams rehearse responses to danger; emotional-processing accounts propose that REM sleep supports the integration of affective experience; other accounts emphasise memory consolidation, network stabilisation or the random activation of circuits. None is established, and clinicians should avoid presenting any of them as fact.

What is better established is that nightmares can be treated. Imagery rehearsal therapy reduces nightmare frequency and distress, and it can be delivered in groups or digitally. Treating nightmares often improves sleep quality and daytime functioning, and it may improve engagement with trauma-focused therapy.

Dream interpretation as a diagnostic tool is not supported. Dreams can be meaningful to the dreamer, and exploring them can be therapeutic, but they do not provide reliable access to hidden memories or to a definitive account of the past.

Synthesis

Table 14.1 summarises sleep problems and interventions.

Table 14.1. Sleep problems and evidence-based responses

Problem	Features	First-line intervention	Notes
Insomnia	Difficulty initiating/maintaining sleep	CBT-I	Effective in trauma populations
Nightmares	Vivid awakening dreams	Imagery rehearsal therapy	Prazosin evidence mixed
Circadian disruption	Irregular timing	Light, routine, schedule	Consider social context
Sleep apnoea	Breathing pauses	CPAP, specialist referral	Often missed
Restless legs	Urge to move at night	Iron studies, specialist care	Comorbid with depression

Composite case study

A patient reports sleeping four hours a night, waking with nightmares and fearing sleep. Treatment begins with CBT-I and imagery rehearsal therapy, alongside trauma-focused therapy. Sleep improves over eight weeks, and the patient reports better tolerance of therapy sessions. The clinician notes that improved sleep is not the same as recovery, but it makes recovery more feasible.

Review and discussion questions

How do the homeostatic and circadian processes interact to regulate sleep?

Why is insomnia a risk factor for PTSD rather than only a consequence?

What is the evidence for imagery rehearsal therapy?

Why did prazosin trials produce disappointing results?

How should sleep interventions be adapted for refugees and displaced populations?

What are the risks of sedative medication in older trauma survivors?

Research assignments

- Design a trial of CBT-I delivered before trauma-focused therapy.
- Critically appraise the evidence on sleep and extinction consolidation.
- Write a sleep hygiene guide that is accurate, practical and trauma-informed.

Chapter summary

Sleep is an active process essential for memory, emotion regulation, immunity and metabolism. Trauma disrupts sleep, and poor sleep maintains trauma symptoms. Insomnia and nightmares are treatable with CBT-I and imagery rehearsal therapy. Circadian disruption is common in displaced and shift-working populations and requires practical intervention. Sleep should be assessed and treated as part of trauma care, not as an optional extra.

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Developmental Trauma and Adverse Childhood Experiences

Chapter 15

In this chapter

Learning objectives 169
Introduction 169
15.1 Adverse childhood experiences 169
15.2 Developmental timing 170
15.3 Threat versus deprivation 170
15.4 Unpredictability and chronicity 171
15.5 Developmental trauma 171
15.6 Neurodevelopment under adversity 171
15.7 Attachment and caregiving 172
15.8 Resilience 172
15.9 Assessment in children 173
15.10 Intervention implications 173
15.11 Stability, foster care and reunification 173
15.12 Prevention and early intervention 174
Synthesis 175
Composite case study 175
Review and discussion questions 176
Research assignments 176
Chapter summary 176
References 176

Central question. Why does the timing of adversity matter, and how does early experience shape the developing brain and body?

Learning objectives

- describe the concept of adverse childhood experiences;
- explain developmental timing and sensitive periods;
- distinguish threat, deprivation and unpredictability;
- evaluate the evidence on developmental trauma as a diagnostic construct;
- explain resilience as a developmental process.

Introduction

The developing brain is not a smaller version of the adult brain. It is in the process of building circuits, pruning connections, and calibrating systems to the environment it expects to encounter. Adversity during development can therefore have effects that differ from adversity in adulthood: not only on how the system responds in the moment, but on how it is built.

This chapter examines the developmental dimension of trauma. It begins with the adverse childhood experiences literature, then considers developmental timing, the distinction between threat and deprivation, the concept of developmental trauma, and the evidence on resilience. It closes with implications for assessment and intervention.

> **A note on causality.** *Childhood adversity is associated with a wide range of later outcomes, but association is not causation. Adversity often co-occurs with poverty, discrimination, family instability and inadequate services. Teasing apart the effects of adversity from the effects of these correlated conditions requires careful designs, and many studies do not achieve this.*

15.1 Adverse childhood experiences

The adverse childhood experiences (ACE) study asked adults about childhood abuse, neglect and household dysfunction, and related them to later health. The initial study of more than 13,000 respondents found graded relationships between the number of categories and risks for alcoholism, drug abuse, depression, suicide attempt and other outcomes (Felitti et al., 1998).

The ACE score is a count of categories, not a measure of severity, frequency or meaning. It has been enormously influential in public health because it is simple and demonstrates that childhood adversity is common and consequential. It has also been criticised for reducing complex experiences to a number and for neglecting protective factors.

The public health implication is important: if childhood adversity is common, then prevention and early intervention have large potential benefits. This is the rationale for trauma-informed approaches in schools, health care and social services.

The broader public-health argument for early intervention is set out by Shonkoff and Garner (2012).

15.2 Developmental timing

The timing of adversity matters. Different brain systems develop at different rates, and the same exposure may have different effects depending on when it occurs.

Sensory systems mature early, language develops rapidly in early childhood, and prefrontal circuits continue to develop into early adulthood. Stress-sensitive systems, including the HPA axis and the amygdala, are shaped by experience throughout development but may be particularly sensitive during certain windows.

The concept of sensitive periods describes windows of heightened plasticity during which experience has especially strong effects. Critical periods are narrower and are defined by the absence of plasticity afterwards. Most human development involves sensitive rather than critical periods, meaning that later experience can still have effects, though sometimes less efficiently.

15.3 Threat versus deprivation

Research on childhood adversity has increasingly distinguished threat (abuse, violence, fear) from deprivation (neglect, lack of stimulation, poverty). These dimensions are associated with different outcomes: threat with fear learning and emotion regulation difficulties, deprivation with language and cognitive delays.

The distinction is useful but not absolute. Many children experience both, and the categories overlap. Measurement is also imperfect: retrospective reports are affected by memory and current state, and prospective records may miss experiences.

The practical implication is that interventions should address the specific dimension of adversity. A child exposed to violence needs safety and trauma-focused care; a child exposed to neglect needs stimulation, stable caregiving and enrichment.

15.4 Unpredictability and chronicity

Unpredictability may be as important as severity. An environment that is sometimes safe and sometimes dangerous is harder to adapt to than one that is consistently harsh, because the child cannot learn stable expectations.

Chronicity matters too. A single traumatic event and years of ongoing threat produce different adaptations. Chronic threat may produce hypervigilance and rapid threat detection; single events may produce more circumscribed fear learning.

These distinctions are relevant to assessment: asking "what happened" is not enough; clinicians should ask "how often", "for how long", "who was involved" and "what happened afterwards".

15.5 Developmental trauma

Developmental trauma disorder was proposed as a diagnosis for children and adolescents exposed to chronic interpersonal trauma, with symptoms including affect dysregulation, attentional and behavioural problems, self-concept disturbance and relationship difficulties. It was not included in DSM-5, though complex PTSD was included in ICD-11.

The debate about diagnosis is partly about whether a new category adds value beyond existing diagnoses, and partly about access to services. A diagnosis can open doors to funding and treatment; it can also pathologise children and families.

The construct has clinical utility even without formal diagnostic status: it reminds clinicians that chronic developmental adversity produces a broad pattern of difficulties that do not map neatly onto PTSD criteria.

15.6 Neurodevelopment under adversity

Studies of children exposed to adversity report differences in brain structure and function, including altered amygdala reactivity, reduced hippocampal volume, altered prefrontal connectivity and differences in

white-matter organisation. These findings are group-level and heterogeneous.

The interpretation is complicated by confounding and by the fact that brain development is plastic. Differences observed in childhood may reflect adaptation rather than damage, and may change with intervention.

It is important not to overstate the findings. Claims that adversity causes irreversible brain damage are not supported and can be stigmatising. The evidence is more consistent with altered developmental trajectories that are responsive to environment and experience.

For a review of the neurobiological correlates of maltreatment, see Teicher and Samson (2016).

15.7 Attachment and caregiving

Attachment theory describes the development of emotional bonds between children and caregivers. Secure attachment is associated with better emotion regulation and social functioning; insecure patterns are associated with increased risk.

Trauma can affect caregiving directly, through injury, death or separation, and indirectly, through parental distress. Parents who are struggling may be less available, more irritable or inconsistent, which affects the child's environment.

Interventions that support caregiving—parenting programmes, treatment for parental mental health, economic support—can improve child outcomes. This is a public health approach as much as a clinical one.

15.8 Resilience

Resilience is the capacity to maintain or regain functioning in the face of adversity. It is not a fixed trait, and it is not the same as never being affected. It involves individual factors, family factors and community factors.

Protective factors include secure relationships, adequate income, safe neighbourhoods, good schools, access to health care and cultural continuity. These are not merely personal qualities; they are resources that can be strengthened by policy.

The concept of resilience has sometimes been used to imply that people should cope without help. This is a misuse. Resilience is supported by environments, and asking individuals to be resilient in the absence of resources is unjust.

15.9 Assessment in children

Assessment should be developmentally appropriate, trauma-informed and multi-informant. Young children may express distress through behaviour, play and somatic complaints; adolescents may express it through risk-taking, withdrawal or irritability.

Standardised instruments exist for trauma exposure and symptoms, but they should be used alongside clinical interview and collateral information. Consent and confidentiality require careful handling, particularly when caregivers are involved in the trauma.

Assessment should also identify strengths and resources, not only problems. This informs treatment planning and supports engagement.

15.10 Intervention implications

Interventions for developmental trauma should address safety, caregiving, regulation and, where appropriate, trauma processing. Trauma-focused cognitive behavioural therapy has good evidence in children. Parent–child interventions can improve relationships and reduce symptoms.

School-based approaches can provide universal support and identify children who need more intensive help. Community-based approaches can address social determinants and reduce stigma.

Interventions should be sequenced: safety and stabilisation before processing, and processing only when the child has sufficient support. This is not a rigid rule but a sensible default.

Service descriptions of complex trauma in children are provided by the National Child Traumatic Stress Network (n.d.).

15.11 Stability, foster care and reunification

Continuity of caregiving is one of the strongest protective factors in child development, and disruption of care is one of the most reliable sources of additional harm. Children who experience multiple placements,

repeated school changes and uncertain reunification carry a cumulative burden that is partly independent of the original maltreatment.

Practice implications follow. Placement decisions should prioritise stability and kinship where safe, minimise unnecessary moves, and prepare children for transitions. Siblings should be placed together where possible. Contact arrangements should be predictable rather than erratic, because unpredictability is itself a stressor.

Reunification should be planned and paced. Sudden return to a caregiver after long separation can be experienced as another loss of control, and both caregiver and child may need support. Parenting interventions that address trauma-related behaviour—rather than treating it as disobedience—are more likely to succeed.

Foster carers and kinship carers need training, respite and access to consultation. Without support, carers may interpret trauma-driven behaviour as personal rejection, and the placement may break down. The evidence for training programmes is moderate, but the rationale for supporting carers is strong.

Children in care are also entitled to honest information about their history at a pace they can manage. Concealment, when it later emerges, can damage trust; disclosure handled well can support identity and coherence.

15.12 Prevention and early intervention

Prevention operates at several levels. Universal measures—income support, housing, childcare, education and health visiting—address the conditions in which adversity occurs. Targeted measures identify families at elevated risk and offer additional support. Indicated measures treat children and families already affected.

The evidence is strongest for some targeted programmes. Home visiting by nurses or trained visitors improves some parenting and child outcomes, particularly when programmes are well implemented and reach families who need them. Parenting programmes based on social learning principles reduce harsh discipline and improve behaviour in many trials. School-based programmes can improve emotional literacy and reduce bullying, though effects on trauma symptoms are smaller.

None of these is a panacea. Effect sizes are modest, implementation quality varies, and benefits are often greatest for families with the fewest difficulties—a pattern that can widen inequalities if services are not designed to reach the most disadvantaged.

Screening raises ethical questions. Identifying adversity without providing help can stigmatise families and erode trust. Screening should be linked to services, accompanied by consent and followed by offers of support rather than surveillance.

The strongest prevention is social. Reducing child poverty, improving housing and supporting caregivers may do more for child mental health than any clinical intervention delivered after harm has occurred.

Synthesis

Table 15.1 summarises developmental concepts.

Table 15.1. Developmental concepts and implications

Concept	Meaning	Implication
ACE score	Count of adversity categories	Useful for public health, not individual diagnosis
Sensitive period	Window of heightened plasticity	Timing matters but later change is possible
Threat	Abuse, violence	Fear learning, hypervigilance
Deprivation	Neglect, lack of stimulation	Cognitive and language delays
Developmental trauma	Chronic interpersonal adversity	Broad difficulties beyond PTSD criteria
Resilience	Capacity to maintain functioning	Supported by relationships and resources

Composite case study

A 10-year-old is referred for aggression and difficulty concentrating. Assessment reveals years of domestic violence, separation from a caregiver and housing instability. The plan includes safety planning, caregiver support, school liaison and trauma-focused therapy. The clinician avoids describing the child as damaged and emphasises the potential for change with the right environment.

Review and discussion questions

What are the strengths and limits of the ACE score?

Why is the distinction between threat and deprivation useful?

Why was developmental trauma disorder not included in DSM-5?

How should clinicians avoid overstating neurodevelopmental findings?

What makes resilience a relational rather than an individual property?

How should assessment be adapted for young children?

Research assignments

- Design a prospective study of threat and deprivation that separates their effects.
- Critically appraise the evidence for trauma-focused CBT in children.
- Write a policy brief on adverse childhood experiences for a local authority.

Chapter summary

Early adversity shapes development through timing, chronicity, type and context. The ACE literature demonstrates that childhood adversity is common and consequential but is not a diagnostic tool. Threat and deprivation have partly distinct effects. Developmental trauma captures the broad difficulties associated with chronic interpersonal adversity. Resilience is supported by relationships and resources, and interventions should address safety, caregiving and the environment as well as individual symptoms.

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Systemic and Structural Trauma

Chapter 16

In this chapter

Learning objectives 179
Introduction 179
16.1 Collective trauma 179
16.2 Historical trauma 180
16.3 Discrimination and stress physiology 180
16.4 Poverty and deprivation 180
16.5 War and displacement 181
16.6 Structural violence 181
16.7 Trauma-informed organisations 182
16.8 Community resilience 182
16.9 Measurement and attribution 182
16.10 Responsibility of the field 183
16.11 Displacement, asylum and clinical practice 183
16.12 Community partnership and research ethics 184
Synthesis 184
Composite case study 185
Review and discussion questions 185
Research assignments 185
Chapter summary 186
References 186

Central question. How do collective, historical and structural harms affect individuals, and how should neurobiology engage with them?

Learning objectives

- distinguish individual, collective and structural trauma;
- describe historical trauma and its contested evidence base;
- explain how discrimination and poverty affect stress physiology;
- evaluate the concept of trauma-informed organisations;
- identify the limits of neurobiological explanation for social harms.

Introduction

Most trauma research studies individuals. But much trauma is collective: war, genocide, displacement, apartheid, colonialism, mass incarceration, natural disaster. And much harm is structural: it operates through laws, institutions, economies and norms rather than through a single perpetrator.

This chapter examines these levels. It asks what neurobiology can contribute to understanding collective and structural harm, and what it cannot. It argues that biological language can illuminate mechanisms—how discrimination gets under the skin—but that it can also individualise and depoliticise problems that require social change.

> **A note on terminology.** *Historical trauma refers to cumulative emotional and psychological wounding across generations resulting from massive group trauma. Structural trauma refers to harm embedded in institutions and social arrangements. Collective trauma refers to shared psychological effects of a traumatic event on a group. The terms overlap and are used inconsistently in the literature.*

16.1 Collective trauma

Collective trauma occurs when a group experiences an event that shatters shared assumptions and identities. It affects individuals, but it also affects the group's narratives, rituals, institutions and sense of safety.

Research on collective trauma draws on sociology, anthropology and history as well as psychology. It examines how communities remember, commemorate and transmit experiences, and how they rebuild.

Neurobiological methods are poorly suited to studying collective trauma directly. They can study individuals within affected groups, but they cannot capture the group-level processes that shape meaning and recovery.

16.2 Historical trauma

The concept of historical trauma was developed in relation to Indigenous communities in North America, particularly the legacy of boarding schools and forced assimilation. It proposes that massive group trauma has effects that persist across generations.

Empirical evidence is mixed. Studies report elevated rates of mental health problems, substance use and suicide in some Indigenous communities, but attributing these to historical trauma specifically is difficult because contemporary disadvantage, discrimination and ongoing colonialism are also powerful determinants.

The concept has political and clinical value: it acknowledges that harms are not only individual and not only past. It also risks overextension, and it should be used carefully rather than as a catch-all explanation.

16.3 Discrimination and stress physiology

Experiences of discrimination are associated with elevated stress hormones, blood pressure, inflammation and poor mental health. These associations are found across many groups and are not explained away by socioeconomic status.

Discrimination can be acute (a specific incident) or chronic (ongoing exposure to bias and exclusion). Chronic discrimination is a stressor that is unpredictable, uncontrollable and identity-relevant, which makes it particularly potent.

Biological measures can document the physiological cost of discrimination. They cannot, by themselves, prove causation, and they should not be used to individualise a structural problem. Their value is in showing that social experience has biological consequences—an argument against the idea that discrimination is "just" a perception.

16.4 Poverty and deprivation

Poverty exposes people to multiple stressors: food insecurity, housing instability, unsafe environments, limited access to health care and

chronic uncertainty. These stressors affect stress physiology, cognitive bandwidth and mental health.

The relationship between poverty and trauma is bidirectional. Poverty increases exposure to traumatic events and reduces access to resources for recovery; trauma can also lead to loss of income, housing and social support.

Neurobiological research on poverty has documented associations with cortical development, language exposure and stress physiology. These findings should be interpreted carefully: they describe population patterns, not individual potential, and they can be used to justify deficit narratives if misapplied.

The argument that early socioeconomic adversity becomes biologically embedded is developed by Shonkoff and Garner (2012).

16.5 War and displacement

War and displacement produce trauma through direct violence, loss, separation, deprivation and uncertainty. Refugees often experience multiple traumas before, during and after migration, including detention, exploitation and discrimination in host countries.

Post-migration stressors—uncertain legal status, poverty, isolation, discrimination, difficulty accessing services—predict mental health outcomes alongside pre-migration trauma. This is an important corrective to the assumption that trauma is located only in the past.

Interventions should address both trauma and post-migration conditions. Clinical services that ignore housing, legal status and social support are unlikely to be sufficient.

16.6 Structural violence

Structural violence refers to harm that results from social arrangements rather than from identifiable individuals. It includes inadequate housing, unsafe work, pollution, food insecurity and unequal access to care.

Structural violence is often invisible in clinical settings because it does not present as a discrete event. A patient may present with chronic stress, depression or physical illness without reporting a "trauma" in the conventional sense.

Clinical practice can respond by asking about social conditions, connecting patients to resources and advocating for change. This is not a distraction from neurobiology; it is an application of the understanding that stress physiology is shaped by environment.

16.7 Trauma-informed organisations

Trauma-informed care is an organisational approach that recognises the prevalence of trauma, understands its effects, avoids re-traumatisation and supports recovery. It involves changes in policy, environment, language and staff training.

Evidence for trauma-informed organisational interventions is limited but growing. Studies report improvements in staff knowledge, patient experience and some clinical outcomes. The concept has been criticised for becoming a slogan without substantive change.

Genuine trauma-informed practice requires attention to power, safety, choice and transparency. It is not simply a training course; it is a change in how organisations operate.

16.8 Community resilience

Community resilience refers to the capacity of a community to withstand and recover from adversity. It involves social networks, shared identity, local leadership, infrastructure and access to resources.

Community-based interventions can be effective because they work with existing structures and reach people who do not access clinical services. They can also be more acceptable and sustainable than externally imposed programmes.

Research should be community-led where possible, with attention to consent, benefit-sharing and cultural appropriateness.

16.9 Measurement and attribution

Measuring the effects of collective and structural trauma is difficult. Exposure is often ongoing, comparison groups are hard to define, and outcomes are shaped by many factors.

Attribution requires designs that can separate the effects of a specific historical event from ongoing disadvantage. This is rarely possible with

observational data, and researchers should be explicit about the limits of their claims.

Qualitative and participatory methods can complement quantitative approaches by capturing meaning, process and lived experience.

16.10 Responsibility of the field

The neurobiology of trauma has a responsibility to engage with social context. Biological explanations can be used to depoliticise suffering—to say that the problem is in the brain rather than in the conditions that produced it.

This does not mean that biology is irrelevant. It means that biological findings should be situated within social and political analysis, and that researchers should consider how their work might be used.

A responsible field acknowledges uncertainty, avoids biological determinism and supports interventions at multiple levels: individual, family, community and policy.

16.11 Displacement, asylum and clinical practice

Displaced people often carry several layers of adversity: violence or persecution before flight, dangerous journeys, loss of family and status, and prolonged uncertainty about the right to remain. Post-migration conditions—detention, crowded accommodation, restricted work, discrimination, separation from relatives—are among the strongest predictors of distress, and they are modifiable in principle (Fazel et al., 2012).

Clinical practice should therefore address both past trauma and present circumstances. Assessment should ask about legal status, housing, income, language, family contact and access to health care, not because these are "social issues" separate from biology, but because they shape sleep, nutrition, safety and the capacity to engage in treatment.

Interpreters should be trained, briefed and given time. Family members, particularly children, should not interpret in sensitive assessments. Written materials should be available in the person's preferred language, and consent should be obtained in a way that does not depend on literacy or on fear of authority.

Clinicians should be clear about their role. They may be asked to provide reports for asylum proceedings, where consistency is often treated as a

marker of credibility. Trauma-related memory is not uniformly consistent, and the absence of a detailed narrative does not indicate fabrication. Reports should state the limits of the assessment and avoid claims that the clinician cannot support.

Working with displaced people also carries an emotional load. Vicarious traumatisation, moral distress and burnout are common, and supervision and organisational support are protective rather than optional.

16.12 Community partnership and research ethics

Research on collective and structural trauma has often been extractive: communities provide data and receive little in return. Partnership approaches attempt to change that relationship.

Community-based participatory research involves community members in defining questions, designing instruments, interpreting findings and deciding how results are used. It takes time, requires payment and training for community partners, and does not remove the need for ethical review or scientific rigour.

Several principles follow. Consent should be ongoing rather than a single signature. Data should be governed with attention to who owns it, who can access it and what happens to it after the study ends. Findings should be shared in accessible forms before academic publication. Interventions tested in a community should not depend on resources that disappear when the grant ends.

Researchers should also be cautious about framing. Describing a community primarily through its trauma can reinforce stigma and obscure agency, culture and resistance. A formulation that includes structural causes should also include what communities have built, preserved and changed.

These principles apply with particular force where the researcher is more advantaged than the participants, and where the topic—violence, dispossession, state action—carries political risk. Ethical review is necessary but not sufficient; judgement, humility and accountability matter as much as procedure.

Synthesis

Table 16.1 summarises levels of trauma and their implications.

Table 16.1. Levels of trauma

Level	Examples	Neurobiological engagement	Limits
Individual	Assault, accident	Well-developed	Ignores context
Collective	War, disaster	Individual measures within groups	Cannot capture group process
Historical	Genocide, colonisation	Intergenerational studies	Attribution difficult
Structural	Poverty, discrimination	Stress physiology	Risks individualising

Composite case study

A refugee patient presents with insomnia and intrusive memories. Assessment identifies pre-migration violence but also post-migration stressors: uncertain status, crowded housing and discrimination. The plan combines trauma-focused therapy with practical support and advocacy. The clinician documents how social conditions affect symptoms without reducing the patient's experience to a social problem.

Review and discussion questions

What is the difference between collective and structural trauma?

What are the strengths and limits of the historical trauma concept?

How can biological measures document the effects of discrimination without individualising them?

Why do post-migration stressors matter for refugee mental health?

What would genuine trauma-informed organisational change require?

How should researchers handle attribution when studying structural harms?

Research assignments

- Design a study of discrimination and stress physiology that includes structural measures.
- Critically appraise the evidence for trauma-informed organisational interventions.

- Write a community consultation plan for research in a conflict-affected setting.

Chapter summary

Trauma occurs at individual, collective, historical and structural levels. Neurobiology can document how social harms affect bodies, but it cannot capture group processes or substitute for social analysis. Discrimination, poverty, war and displacement affect stress physiology and mental health, and post-migration conditions matter as much as past events. The field should engage with social context, avoid biological determinism and support interventions at multiple levels.

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Assessment and Differential Diagnosis

Chapter 17

In this chapter

Learning objectives 188
Introduction 188
17.1 Engagement and safety 188
17.2 Trauma history 189
17.3 Symptom assessment 189
17.4 Standardised instruments 189
17.5 Differential diagnosis 190
17.6 Dissociation and complex presentations 190
17.7 Cultural and linguistic considerations 191
17.8 Medical screening 191
17.9 Risk assessment 191
17.10 Formulation and feedback 192
17.11 Assessment of children and adolescents 192
17.12 Assessment in legal and occupational contexts 192
Synthesis 193
Composite case study 194
Review and discussion questions 194
Research assignments 194
Chapter summary 195
References 195

Central question. How should trauma-related conditions be assessed, and how can clinicians avoid the common errors of over- and under-diagnosis?

Learning objectives

- describe the components of a trauma-informed assessment;
- distinguish PTSD from common differential diagnoses;
- explain the role of standardised instruments;
- recognise the effects of culture, language and context on assessment;
- identify when medical investigation is indicated.

Introduction

Assessment is the foundation of good practice. It determines whether treatment is offered, which treatment, and whether the person is safe. It is also where many errors occur: trauma may be missed because it is not asked about, over-diagnosed because symptoms are attributed to trauma without considering alternatives, or misattributed to a medical condition that is not investigated.

This chapter sets out a structured approach. It covers history, symptom assessment, differential diagnosis, instruments, cultural considerations and medical screening. It emphasises that assessment is not a single event but a process that continues through treatment.

> **A note on asking.** *Many people do not volunteer trauma histories. They may not recognise what happened as trauma, may fear consequences, or may have been discouraged from speaking. Asking directly, privately and without pressure increases disclosure. The question should be followed by a response that is respectful and practical, not by immediate interrogation.*

17.1 Engagement and safety

Assessment begins with engagement. The person needs to know who you are, what you will do with the information, and what choices they have. Confidentiality and its limits should be explained.

Physical and emotional safety should be considered. Is the setting private? Is the person at risk at home? Are there immediate medical needs? These questions come before symptom inventories.

Assessment should be paced. A person who is highly dissociated or intoxicated may not be able to provide a reliable history, and the assessment should be resumed later rather than forced.

17.2 Trauma history

The trauma history should establish what happened, when, for how long, who was involved and what the consequences were. It should include childhood adversity, adult trauma, recent events and ongoing threats.

Questions should be specific enough to elicit information without being leading. Asking "have you ever been physically hurt by someone close to you" is more useful than asking "do you have trauma".

The history should also cover protective factors, supports and the person's own understanding of what happened. This informs formulation and engagement.

17.3 Symptom assessment

Core PTSD symptoms include intrusive memories, avoidance, negative alterations in cognition and mood, and alterations in arousal and reactivity. The assessment should establish frequency, intensity, duration and functional impact.

It should also assess dissociation, complex PTSD features, depression, anxiety, substance use, psychosis, suicidal ideation and self-harm. Comorbidity is the rule rather than the exception.

Symptoms should be linked to functioning: work, relationships, sleep, self-care and safety. A symptom count without functional context is of limited use.

Most adults report at least one traumatic event, but only a minority develop PTSD (Kessler et al., 1995).

17.4 Standardised instruments

Standardised instruments improve reliability and support monitoring. Commonly used measures include the PTSD Checklist for DSM-5, the Clinician-Administered PTSD Scale, the Impact of Event Scale-Revised and the Dissociative Experiences Scale.

Instruments are screening or severity measures, not diagnoses. They depend on the population, the language and the method of administration. Cut-off scores should be interpreted with knowledge of local validation.

Self-report instruments can be completed privately, which may increase disclosure. They can also be affected by literacy, language and cultural interpretation of items.

17.5 Differential diagnosis

Several conditions can mimic or co-occur with PTSD. Major depression shares low mood, sleep disturbance and concentration difficulties. Generalised anxiety shares hyperarousal and worry. Panic disorder shares autonomic arousal. Psychosis can involve intrusive experiences that resemble flashbacks. Traumatic brain injury can produce cognitive and emotional changes.

Medical conditions should be considered: thyroid disease, anaemia, sleep apnoea, chronic pain, medication effects and substance withdrawal. These can produce symptoms that overlap with trauma.

The goal is not to exclude trauma but to avoid attributing everything to it. A person can have PTSD and hypothyroidism, and treating one does not treat the other.

Diagnosis rests on clinical interview against established criteria rather than on screening scores alone (Yehuda et al., 2015).

17.6 Dissociation and complex presentations

Dissociation should be assessed specifically, including depersonalisation, derealisation, amnesia and identity confusion. Severe dissociation may require a modified treatment approach.

Complex PTSD, as defined in ICD-11, includes the core PTSD symptoms plus disturbances in self-organisation: affect dysregulation, negative self-concept and difficulties in relationships. Assessment should establish whether these features are present and how they affect functioning.

Personality disorder diagnoses should be made cautiously in the context of trauma, because many features overlap and because labelling can be stigmatising. Where a diagnosis is made, it should inform treatment rather than replace formulation.

The dissociative subtype and its assessment are reviewed by Lanius et al. (2010).

17.7 Cultural and linguistic considerations

Culture shapes how distress is expressed, what is considered traumatic, who is consulted and what help is acceptable. Somatic idioms, spiritual explanations and family-based coping are common and should be respected.

Language is central. Assessment in a second language may obscure nuance, and interpreters should be trained and briefed. Family members should not interpret for sensitive assessments.

Instruments developed in one culture may not be valid in another. Local validation and qualitative input are important.

17.8 Medical screening

Medical screening should be guided by the history and presentation. Indicated investigations might include thyroid function, full blood count, glucose, vitamin levels and, where relevant, toxicology.

Red flags—focal neurological signs, sudden cognitive decline, severe headache, seizures, unexplained weight loss—require urgent medical assessment. These should not be attributed to trauma without investigation.

The interface between trauma and medicine is often poorly managed. Coordinated care between mental health and primary care improves outcomes.

17.9 Risk assessment

Risk assessment should cover suicide, self-harm, harm to others, safeguarding and immediate danger. It should be documented and followed by a plan.

Asking about suicide does not increase risk. It provides an opportunity to intervene. Assessment should include intent, plan, means, protective factors and access to support.

Risk is not a static property of a person; it changes with circumstances. Assessment should be repeated at transitions and during crises.

17.10 Formulation and feedback

Formulation integrates the history, symptoms, context and strengths into an explanatory account that guides treatment. It should be shared with the person, checked for accuracy and revised as new information emerges.

Feedback improves engagement and outcomes. It also respects the person's expertise about their own life.

Formulation is not a diagnosis. It is a working model that can accommodate complexity, uncertainty and change.

17.11 Assessment of children and adolescents

Children rarely describe trauma in the way adults do. Younger children may show regression, clinginess, sleep disruption, somatic complaints, aggression or repetitive play; adolescents may show risk-taking, withdrawal, irritability or changes in school performance. A single informant is rarely sufficient, and caregivers, teachers and the young person should each contribute where possible.

Assessment should be developmentally calibrated. Questions should use the child's vocabulary, concrete examples and, for younger children, drawing or play-based methods. Forced-choice questions and repeated interrogation should be avoided.

Consent and confidentiality require care. A child may not understand the purpose of the assessment, and a caregiver may be the source of harm. Where safeguarding concerns arise, the clinician must follow local procedures and tell the child, in advance where possible, what will be shared and with whom.

Standardised instruments exist for trauma exposure and symptoms across age ranges, but they should be supplemented by clinical interview and, where appropriate, observation. Reports from school can reveal difficulties that are not apparent at home.

Assessment should identify strengths, relationships and resources, not only symptoms. A formulation that lists deficits without context is both inaccurate and demoralising for families.

17.12 Assessment in legal and occupational contexts

Clinicians are sometimes asked to assess trauma for courts, immigration tribunals, employers or insurers. These contexts differ from clinical care, and the differences should be made explicit.

The first issue is role clarity. A treating clinician is an advocate for the patient's wellbeing; an expert witness owes a duty to the court. The same person should not usually occupy both roles, and where they do, the dual role should be disclosed and managed.

The second issue is the standard of proof and the question asked. Legal questions are not clinical questions: "is this account consistent with the medical evidence" is different from "does this person meet criteria for PTSD". Reports should answer the question asked, state the limits of the assessment and avoid speculation.

The third issue is symptom validity. Effort and symptom exaggeration occur in some medico-legal assessments, but they are not the default, and no clinician can detect deception by impression. Validated symptom validity tests can be used where indicated, with attention to false positives and to the distress that testing can cause.

The fourth issue is documentation. Contemporaneous notes, verbatim quotes where appropriate, and clear reasoning are essential. Reports should distinguish what was reported, what was observed and what was inferred.

Finally, the clinician should consider the consequences of the assessment for the person. A report that overstates certainty can harm the person it is meant to help; one that understates genuine impairment can deny them justice. Accuracy, not advocacy in either direction, is the standard.

Synthesis

Table 17.1 summarises assessment components.

Table 17.1. Components of trauma-informed assessment

Component	Purpose	Common errors
Engagement	Safety, consent	Rushing to symptoms
Trauma history	Identify exposure	Not asking directly
Symptom assessment	Severity, function	Counting symptoms only
Instruments	Reliability, monitoring	Treating scores as diagnosis
Differential diagnosis	Avoid misattribution	Attributing all to trauma
Risk assessment	Safety planning	Avoiding the question
Formulation	Integrated explanation	Not sharing with the person

Composite case study

A patient presents with insomnia, irritability and intrusive images. Assessment identifies a traumatic event, but also untreated sleep apnoea and heavy alcohol use. The formulation integrates these factors. Treatment addresses sleep, alcohol and trauma in a sequenced plan, with medical follow-up. The clinician does not assume that trauma explains everything.

Review and discussion questions

How would you ask about trauma in a way that increases disclosure?

Why are screening instruments not diagnostic?

Which medical conditions should be considered in the differential diagnosis of PTSD?

How should interpreters be used in trauma assessment?

What are the risks of diagnosing personality disorder in trauma survivors?

Why should formulation be shared with the person?

Research assignments

- Compare two PTSD instruments, noting validation evidence and cultural limitations.

- Design an assessment protocol for a refugee clinic.
- Write a risk assessment template that is trauma-informed and legally defensible.

Chapter summary

Trauma-informed assessment integrates engagement, trauma history, symptoms, differential diagnosis, risk and formulation. Standardised instruments support but do not replace clinical judgement. Culture, language and medical conditions shape presentation and require attention. A good assessment avoids both under-recognition and over-attribution, and it results in a shared formulation that guides treatment and can be revised.

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Therapeutic Translation: From Mechanism to Intervention

Chapter 18

In this chapter

Learning objectives 197
Introduction 197
18.1 Stages of translational research 197
18.2 Efficacy and effectiveness 198
18.3 Why translation fails 198
18.4 Exposure therapy 198
18.5 Medication 199
18.6 Neuromodulation 199
18.7 Digital and self-guided interventions 199
18.8 Implementation science 200
18.9 Evidence standards 200
18.10 Ethical translation 200
18.11 Workforce, training and supervision 201
18.12 Routine outcome monitoring and service evaluation 201
Synthesis 202
Composite case study 202
Review and discussion questions 203
Research assignments 203
Chapter summary 203
References 203

Central question. How do findings about trauma neurobiology become treatments, and why do so many promising mechanisms fail to translate?

Learning objectives

- describe the stages of translational research;
- distinguish efficacy, effectiveness and implementation;
- explain common reasons for translation failure;
- evaluate mechanism-based treatments for trauma;
- apply evidence standards to new interventions.

Introduction

Translation is the process by which basic science becomes clinical practice. It is slower and less linear than the word suggests. A mechanism discovered in a laboratory may take decades to yield a treatment, and many mechanisms never do.

This chapter examines translation in trauma research. It describes the stages of translational research, the difference between efficacy and effectiveness, common reasons for failure, and specific examples of mechanism-based treatments. It closes with practical guidance for evaluating new interventions.

> **A note on mechanism.** *A treatment can work without knowing its mechanism, and a mechanism can be real without yielding an effective treatment. Mechanism and efficacy are separate questions, and conflating them leads to overconfidence.*

18.1 Stages of translational research

Translational research is often described in stages: T1, from basic discovery to candidate intervention; T2, from candidate to efficacy trials; T3, from efficacy to effectiveness and implementation; T4, from implementation to population health impact.

The stages are not strictly sequential. Implementation problems can reveal efficacy problems, and basic discoveries can emerge from clinical observation. The model is a map, not a recipe.

For trauma, T1 research includes animal models of fear learning and stress physiology; T2 includes randomised trials of exposure therapy

and medication; T3 includes dissemination studies in community settings; T4 includes policy and population-level evaluation.

18.2 Efficacy and effectiveness

Efficacy trials test whether an intervention works under ideal conditions: carefully selected participants, standardised delivery, rigorous monitoring. Effectiveness trials test whether it works under routine conditions: diverse participants, variable delivery, competing demands.

Many interventions that are efficacious in trials are less effective in practice. This is not necessarily because the intervention is flawed; it may be because the context, population or delivery differs.

For trauma, effectiveness research is essential because most people are treated in generalist settings with limited resources, not in specialist research clinics.

18.3 Why translation fails

Translation can fail at several points. The mechanism may not be causally important in humans. The intervention may not engage the mechanism as intended. The effect size may be too small to be clinically meaningful. The intervention may be unacceptable, unaffordable or unsafe. Implementation may be inadequate.

Failures are informative. Negative trials can reveal that a mechanism is less important than assumed, or that the intervention was poorly designed or delivered. They should be reported and discussed, not buried.

18.4 Exposure therapy

Exposure therapy is the best-established mechanism-based treatment for trauma. It is grounded in extinction learning: repeated exposure to feared cues without adverse outcome produces new inhibitory learning.

Efficacy is well established across trauma populations. Effectiveness in routine settings is good, though access remains limited. Variants include prolonged exposure, cognitive processing therapy, narrative exposure therapy and virtual reality exposure.

Exposure is not the same as reliving. It is structured, paced and collaborative, with attention to safety and to the person's goals.

The inhibitory-learning account of exposure, and its implications for optimising practice, are set out by Craske et al. (2014).

18.5 Medication

Medication can target specific mechanisms: selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors modulate serotonergic function; alpha-1 antagonists target noradrenergic arousal; glucocorticoids have been studied for consolidation and prevention.

Evidence varies. SSRIs have moderate evidence for PTSD. Prazosin has mixed evidence for nightmares. Hydrocortisone has been studied for prevention after trauma with some promising findings but is not standard care.

Medication is often used alongside psychotherapy. Sequencing, interactions and patient preference should guide decisions.

For a review of the pharmacological evidence in PTSD, see Yehuda et al. (2015).

18.6 Neuromodulation

Neuromodulation includes transcranial magnetic stimulation, transcranial direct current stimulation and, more invasively, deep brain stimulation. These methods alter brain activity in targeted regions.

Repetitive transcranial magnetic stimulation has been studied for PTSD, with some positive trials and considerable heterogeneity. It is not yet a first-line treatment. Invasive methods are experimental for trauma.

Neuromodulation raises ethical questions about consent, access and the risk of premature commercialisation.

18.7 Digital and self-guided interventions

Digital interventions can increase access and reduce cost. They include internet-delivered CBT, mobile apps, virtual reality and guided self-help.

Evidence is strongest for guided interventions with human support. Unguided self-help has smaller effects and higher dropout. Digital tools should be evaluated with the same rigour as other interventions.

Digital interventions also raise concerns about data privacy, safety and the quality of content. Regulation is uneven.

18.8 Implementation science

Implementation science studies how evidence-based practices are adopted, delivered and sustained. It uses frameworks to identify barriers and facilitators at the level of individuals, teams, organisations and systems.

Common barriers include lack of training, time, funding and leadership support. Common facilitators include clear protocols, supervision, feedback and alignment with organisational priorities.

For trauma, implementation research is essential because effective treatments are often unavailable outside specialist centres.

18.9 Evidence standards

Evaluating a new intervention requires attention to study design, sample size, blinding, outcome measurement, follow-up, adverse events and conflicts of interest.

Systematic reviews and meta-analyses synthesise evidence but depend on the quality of included studies. Guidelines translate evidence into recommendations, with attention to values and resources.

Clinicians should be cautious about interventions supported only by case series, testimonials or mechanistic reasoning. Enthusiasm is not evidence.

18.10 Ethical translation

Translation raises ethical questions: who benefits, who bears risk, who can access the intervention and who decides. Research in low-resource settings must be fair and reciprocal.

Commercial interests can distort translation. Marketing may outpace evidence, and patients may be offered interventions that are not yet established.

A responsible field communicates uncertainty, reports negative findings and prioritises interventions that are effective, acceptable and accessible.

18.11 Workforce, training and supervision

Even well-evidenced treatments fail if there are too few trained clinicians, too little supervision and too few hours in the week. Implementation is a workforce problem as much as a scientific one.

Training should include more than attendance at a workshop. Competence develops through observation, practice with feedback, supervised cases and routine outcome monitoring. Short workshops alone rarely change practice; they may improve knowledge and confidence, which are not the same as skill.

Task-shifting—training non-specialists to deliver structured interventions—has been studied chiefly in low- and middle-income settings, where specialist capacity is scarce (Patel et al., 2018). Trials of lay-counsellor-delivered treatments for depression and trauma-related conditions have reported benefits, but the evidence base is uneven and supervision remains essential. Task-shifting should extend capacity, not substitute an unaccountable service for adequate staffing.

Supervision protects patients and clinicians. It provides a setting to review complex cases, notice drift from protocol, manage risk and address the emotional impact of trauma work. Where supervision is unavailable, clinicians should create peer consultation and be explicit about the limits of their practice.

Staff wellbeing is an organisational responsibility. Heavy caseloads, inadequate time and unsupportive management predict burnout more strongly than the content of the work itself.

18.12 Routine outcome monitoring and service evaluation

Routine outcome monitoring uses standardised measures at the start, during and end of treatment. It can identify deterioration early, support supervision and provide accountability to commissioners and patients.

Measures should be brief, validated in the population served, and used to inform care rather than to rank clinicians. The PTSD Checklist for DSM-5 and measures of depression and functioning are common choices. Session-by-session measures are useful for feedback but add administrative burden.

Three pitfalls are common. The first is missing data: people who drop out often have the worst outcomes, and analysing only completers flatters a

service. The second is gaming: targets can incentivise discharging complex cases early or selecting easier referrals. The third is inequity: aggregated data can conceal poorer access or outcomes for particular groups, which requires disaggregation.

Feedback-informed treatment has intuitive appeal, but trials show modest and inconsistent effects on outcomes. Monitoring is most valuable when it changes a clinical decision—adjusting the plan, arranging supervision, or offering an alternative—rather than when it generates reports that nobody uses.

Service evaluation should include access, waiting times, dropout, outcomes, adverse events and patient experience. A service that treats a selected minority very well is not equivalent to one that reaches the population it exists to serve.

Synthesis

Table 18.1 summarises translational stages and trauma examples.

Table 18.1. Translational stages

Stage	Question	Trauma example	Common failure
T1	Does the mechanism work?	Fear conditioning	Animal model mismatch
T2	Does it work in ideal conditions?	Exposure therapy trial	Small effect
T3	Does it work in practice?	Community implementation	Poor fidelity
T4	Does it improve population health?	National policy	Unequal access

Composite case study

A service considers adopting a new digital trauma therapy. The team reviews the evidence: efficacy in a small trial, no effectiveness data, high dropout in unguided use. They decide to pilot the intervention with human support, collect routine outcome data and review after six months. The decision is based on evidence and context, not marketing.

Review and discussion questions

Why is efficacy not sufficient for clinical adoption?

What are the most common reasons for translation failure?

How strong is the evidence for neuromodulation in PTSD?

What distinguishes guided from unguided digital interventions?

Which implementation factors most affect sustainability?

How should conflicts of interest be managed in translational research?

Research assignments

- Design an effectiveness trial of exposure therapy in a low-resource setting.
- Critically appraise the evidence for rTMS in PTSD.
- Write an implementation plan for a trauma-focused therapy in a general hospital.

Chapter summary

Translation from mechanism to intervention is slow, uncertain and context-dependent. Efficacy trials are necessary but not sufficient; effectiveness and implementation determine real-world benefit. Exposure therapy has the strongest evidence base, medication and neuromodulation have narrower roles, and digital interventions require rigorous evaluation. Ethical translation requires attention to access, commercial influence and honest reporting of negative findings.

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Research Methods and Evidence Appraisal

Chapter 19

In this chapter

Learning objectives 206
Introduction 206
19.1 Research questions and designs 206
19.2 Randomised trials 207
19.3 Observational studies 207
19.4 Qualitative methods 207
19.5 Bias and confounding 208
19.6 Effect sizes and uncertainty 208
19.7 Systematic reviews 208
19.8 Guidelines 209
19.9 Questionable research practices 209
19.10 Appraising a paper 209
19.11 Analysis, visualisation and reporting 210
19.12 Writing, peer review and responding to criticism 210
Synthesis 212
Composite case study 212
Review and discussion questions 212
Research assignments 212
Chapter summary 213
References 213

Central question. How should students and practitioners evaluate trauma research, and what are the strengths and limitations of the main study designs?

Learning objectives

- describe the main study designs used in trauma research;
- explain bias, confounding and causal inference;
- interpret effect sizes and confidence intervals;
- appraise systematic reviews and guidelines;
- recognise questionable research practices.

Introduction

Trauma research spans molecular biology, clinical trials, epidemiology, qualitative inquiry and policy analysis. No single method answers all questions. The task is to match the method to the question and to interpret findings with appropriate humility.

This chapter provides a practical guide to evidence appraisal. It covers study designs, bias, effect sizes, systematic reviews and questionable practices. It is written for readers who need to make judgements about evidence, not to conduct research themselves—though it is also useful for those who do.

> **A note on "evidence-based".** *The phrase is often used to mean "supported by randomised trials". That is one kind of evidence, appropriate for questions of efficacy. Other questions—how people experience care, why implementation fails, what meanings trauma has—require other methods. Evidence-based practice involves using the best available evidence for the question at hand, not privileging one design for all questions.*

19.1 Research questions and designs

The design should follow from the question. Questions about prevalence require epidemiological surveys. Questions about mechanism require laboratory or imaging studies. Questions about efficacy require randomised trials. Questions about experience require qualitative methods.

Mixing methods can be valuable: a trial can include qualitative interviews to understand acceptability, and a survey can include biological measures to examine mechanisms.

The most common error is using a design that cannot answer the question—for example, a cross-sectional study to establish causation.

19.2 Randomised trials

Randomisation balances known and unknown confounders between groups, which is why it supports causal inference. Blinding reduces bias in delivery and assessment. Intention-to-treat analysis preserves the benefits of randomisation.

Trials in trauma face challenges: heterogeneity of trauma, comorbidity, difficulty blinding psychological treatments, dropout and contamination between arms.

Reporting standards, such as CONSORT, improve transparency. Registration and prespecified analysis plans reduce selective reporting.

19.3 Observational studies

Cohort studies follow groups over time and can establish temporality. Case–control studies compare people with and without an outcome and are efficient for rare outcomes. Cross-sectional studies measure exposure and outcome at one time and cannot establish direction.

Confounding is the central challenge. Childhood adversity, for example, is correlated with poverty, family instability and genetic factors. Statistical adjustment can reduce but not eliminate confounding.

Causal inference methods—such as instrumental variables, difference-in-differences and Mendelian randomisation—can strengthen observational claims when assumptions are met.

Confounding by socioeconomic and family factors is a persistent challenge in research on childhood adversity (Teicher & Samson, 2016).

19.4 Qualitative methods

Qualitative research explores meaning, process and experience. Methods include interviews, focus groups, ethnography and participatory research. Analysis may be thematic, narrative or grounded theory.

Quality criteria differ from quantitative research: credibility, transferability, dependability and confirmability. Sample size is determined by information power rather than statistical power.

Qualitative findings cannot be generalised statistically, but they can be transferable to similar contexts and can generate hypotheses.

19.5 Bias and confounding

Bias is a systematic error that distorts results. Selection bias occurs when the sample is not representative. Measurement bias occurs when measures are inaccurate or inconsistent. Attrition bias occurs when dropout is related to outcome. Reporting bias occurs when studies or outcomes are selectively reported.

Confounding occurs when a third variable is associated with both exposure and outcome. It can be addressed by design (randomisation, restriction, matching) or analysis (stratification, regression, propensity scores).

No study is free of bias. The question is whether the bias is likely to change the conclusion.

19.6 Effect sizes and uncertainty

Statistical significance indicates whether an effect is unlikely under the null hypothesis; it does not indicate whether the effect is important. Effect sizes—such as standardised mean differences, odds ratios and numbers needed to treat—provide information about magnitude.

Confidence intervals convey uncertainty. A wide interval indicates imprecision; an interval that includes no effect indicates that the data are compatible with no effect.

Clinical significance depends on context: a small effect on a severe condition may matter more than a large effect on a trivial one.

19.7 Systematic reviews

Systematic reviews use explicit methods to identify, select and synthesise studies. Meta-analysis statistically combines results. Both can reduce bias and increase precision, but they inherit the limitations of included studies.

Heterogeneity—variation in effects across studies—should be examined, not ignored. Subgroup analyses should be prespecified, not exploratory.

Publication bias can distort reviews. Funnel plots and trim-and-fill methods can detect it, though imperfectly. Prospective registration of reviews reduces selective reporting.

Reporting standards such as PRISMA improve transparency in systematic reviews (Page et al., 2021).

19.8 Guidelines

Clinical guidelines synthesise evidence and provide recommendations. They vary in quality and in how they handle uncertainty and values.

GRADE is a widely used framework for rating evidence quality and strength of recommendations. It separates the quality of evidence from the strength of the recommendation, which depends also on values, resources and acceptability.

Guidelines should be adapted to local contexts, not applied mechanically.

19.9 Questionable research practices

Questionable practices include p-hacking, HARKing (hypothesising after results are known), selective reporting, salami slicing and inadequate outlier handling. They inflate false positive rates and undermine trust.

Preregistration, open data, open materials and registered reports reduce these practices. Journals and funders increasingly require them.

Replication is essential. A single study, however elegant, should not change practice without independent confirmation.

19.10 Appraising a paper

A practical appraisal asks: What question did the study address? What design was used, and was it appropriate? Who was studied, and how were they selected? What was measured, and how? What was the effect size and precision? Were confounders addressed? Were limitations acknowledged? Do the conclusions follow from the data?

These questions are more useful than a checklist score. They direct attention to the reasoning, not only the reporting.

19.11 Analysis, visualisation and reporting

Analysis should follow the question, not the other way round. The primary outcome, the comparison and the statistical model should be specified before the data are inspected.

Exploratory analysis is legitimate, but it should be labelled as such. A finding that emerges after examining many subgroups is a hypothesis, not a result, unless it is tested in independent data.

Statistical significance is a poor summary. Report effect sizes with confidence intervals, the number of participants contributing to each analysis, and the amount of missing data. For clinical trials, report the number needed to treat where it is meaningful.

Figures should be honest. Truncated axes exaggerate differences; cherry-picked individual traces mislead; error bars should indicate what they represent (standard deviation, standard error or confidence interval—each tells a different story). Bar charts of continuous data hide distributions; scatter plots or box plots with individual points are often better.

Selective reporting remains common. Studies that find null results are less likely to be published, and published studies often report outcomes that were not prespecified. Registration, reporting guidelines and access to protocols reduce but do not eliminate the problem.

Data sharing is increasingly expected. It allows reanalysis and replication, but it requires attention to consent, de-identification and the risk that participants in small, distinctive populations could be identified.

19.12 Writing, peer review and responding to criticism

Scientific writing should be clear, specific and proportionate. Claims should match the evidence: "associated with" is not "causes", and "in this sample" is not "in general".

Reporting guidelines exist for most designs—CONSORT for trials, STROBE for observational studies, PRISMA for systematic reviews, COREQ for qualitative research. They improve completeness and make appraisal easier.

Peer review is imperfect. Reviewers are busy, may lack methodological expertise, and may be biased toward familiar approaches. Review

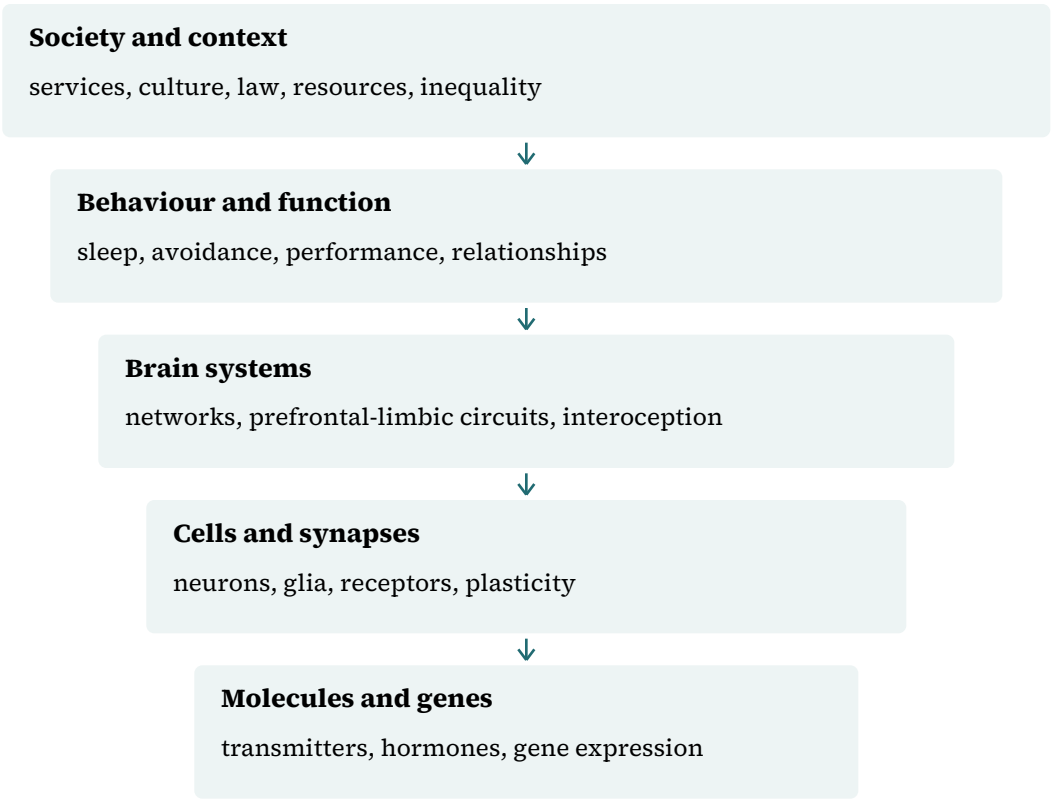
improves many papers but does not guarantee validity. Post-publication critique, replication and data sharing are essential complements.

Responding to criticism well is a skill. Address the substance, acknowledge limitations, provide additional analyses where appropriate, and avoid defensiveness. Reviewers can be wrong, but engagement is more productive than dismissal.

Retraction and correction are part of the system, not a sign that science has failed. What matters is that errors are identified, disclosed and corrected.

Finally, writing for different audiences is not a compromise of rigour. A plain-language summary that is accurate is more useful to participants and policymakers than a technically precise abstract that nobody reads.

Figure 19.1. Levels of analysis in trauma neurobiology



The levels interact reciprocally. Arrows indicate influence, not anatomical containment; a finding at one level cannot be substituted for a finding at another.

Synthesis

Table 19.1 summarises designs and their uses.

Table 19.1. Study designs and appropriate questions

Design	Question	Strength	Limitation
Randomised trial	Efficacy	Causal inference	Cost, generalisability
Cohort	Risk over time	Temporality	Confounding
Case–control	Rare outcomes	Efficiency	Recall bias
Cross-sectional	Prevalence	Cheap	No temporality
Qualitative	Meaning, process	Depth	Limited generalisability
Systematic review	Synthesis	Precision	Inherits bias

Composite case study

A clinician reads a study claiming that a supplement reduces PTSD symptoms. She checks the design: open-label, no control group, 30 participants, outcomes measured by the treating clinician. She concludes that the study does not support the claim and waits for better evidence. This is evidence appraisal in practice.

Review and discussion questions

Why does randomisation support causal inference?

What is the difference between statistical and clinical significance?

How can publication bias distort a meta-analysis?

Why are qualitative methods appropriate for some questions?

What are the main questionable research practices, and how can they be reduced?

What questions should you ask when appraising a paper?

Research assignments

- Appraise a trauma trial using CONSORT and GRADE.
- Design a mixed-methods study of treatment acceptability.

- Write a plain-language summary of a meta-analysis for a clinical team.

Chapter summary

Trauma research uses multiple designs, each suited to different questions. Randomised trials support causal inference about efficacy; observational studies describe risk and course; qualitative methods explore meaning and process. Bias, confounding and selective reporting threaten all designs. Effect sizes and confidence intervals matter more than p-values alone. Systematic reviews and guidelines synthesise evidence but inherit its limitations. Critical appraisal is a practical skill, not a checklist.

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Integration, Professional Practice, and Future Directions

Chapter 20

In this chapter

Learning objectives 215
Introduction 215
20.1 Levels of explanation 215
20.2 The biopsychosocial formulation 216
20.3 Ethical practice 217
20.4 Ethical research 217
20.5 Emerging areas 217
20.6 Persistent uncertainties 218
20.7 Professional development 218
20.8 Communication and public understanding 218
20.9 Working with lived experience 218
20.10 Conclusion 219
20.11 Teaching trauma neurobiology 219
20.12 What would change practice 220
Synthesis 220
Composite case study 221
Review and discussion questions 221
Research assignments 222
Chapter summary 222
References 222

Central question. How can the neuroscience of trauma be integrated into ethical, effective professional practice, and where is the field heading?

Learning objectives

- integrate biological, psychological and social levels of explanation;
- apply ethical principles to trauma research and practice;
- identify emerging areas of trauma neuroscience;
- recognise the limits of current knowledge;
- plan continuing professional development in this field.

Introduction

This book has moved from molecules to society. It has described how stress hormones, neurotransmitter systems, memory processes, immune signalling and brain networks respond to threat, and how these responses are shaped by development, social context and clinical care.

The final chapter draws the threads together. It argues for integration: biological, psychological and social explanations are not competing accounts but different levels of description. It sets out ethical principles for practice and research, identifies emerging areas and persistent uncertainties, and proposes a stance of disciplined humility.

> **A note on integration.** *Integration does not mean that every clinical problem requires a biological explanation. Sometimes the most useful formulation is social, psychological or practical. Integration means having multiple frameworks available and choosing the one that serves the person.*

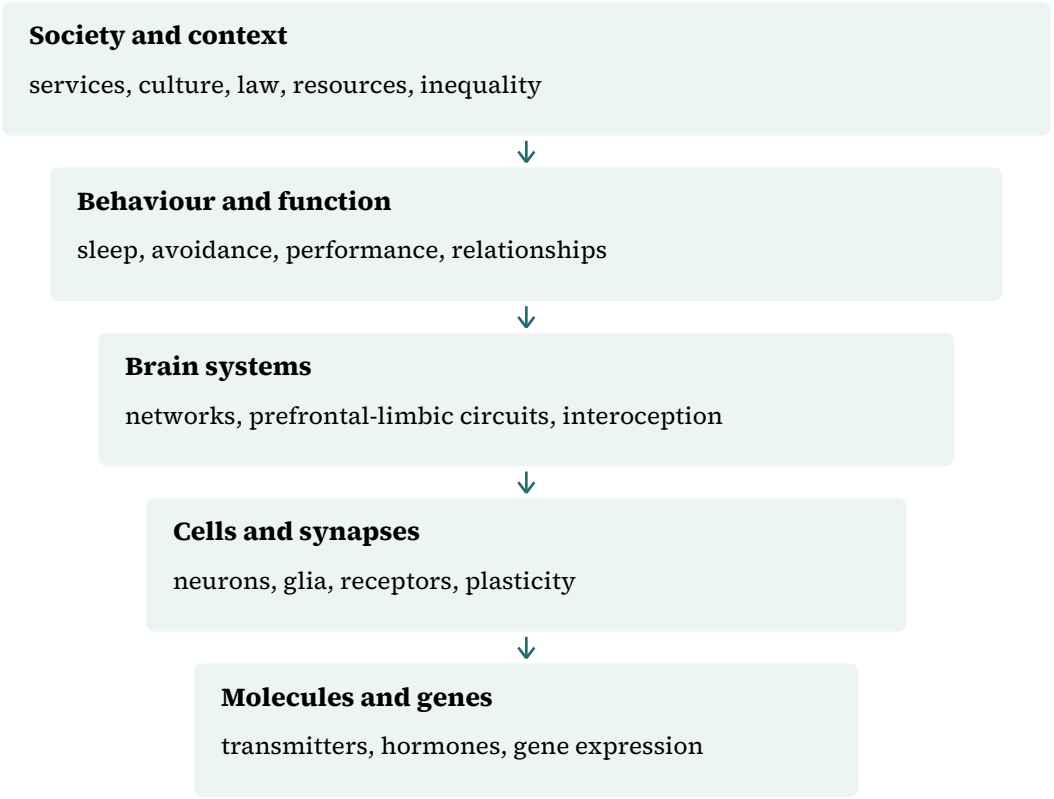
20.1 Levels of explanation

Trauma can be described at molecular, cellular, circuit, cognitive, behavioural, social and political levels. Each level has its own vocabulary, methods and evidence standards.

Reductionism—explaining higher levels entirely in terms of lower ones—is tempting but incomplete. A full molecular account of fear would not tell us what the fear means, whether it is justified, or what should be done about it.

Explanatory pluralism holds that multiple levels can be valid simultaneously. This is not a licence for vagueness; it is a demand for clarity about which level is being used for which purpose.

Figure 20.1. Levels of analysis in trauma neurobiology



The levels interact reciprocally. Arrows indicate influence, not anatomical containment; a finding at one level cannot be substituted for a finding at another.

20.2 The biopsychosocial formulation

The biopsychosocial model integrates biological, psychological and social factors. It is often invoked but rarely applied rigorously.

A good formulation specifies which biological factors are relevant (for example, sleep disruption, thyroid disease, medication effects), which psychological factors (appraisal, avoidance, memory), and which social factors (housing, safety, discrimination, support).

The formulation should guide intervention: some problems require medication, some require therapy, some require housing, and some require all three.

20.3 Ethical practice

Ethical practice in trauma care rests on respect for persons, beneficence, non-maleficence and justice. These principles have practical implications.

Respect requires informed consent, confidentiality and attention to power. Beneficence requires effective treatment, not merely good intentions. Non-maleficence requires avoiding re-traumatisation and iatrogenic harm. Justice requires attention to access and to the distribution of resources.

Trauma survivors may be especially vulnerable to coercion, particularly in legal, immigration and child protection contexts. Clinicians should be clear about their role and its limits.

Public-facing guidance on PTSD and its treatment is available from the National Institute of Mental Health (n.d.).

20.4 Ethical research

Research with trauma survivors must be safe, respectful and useful. Risks include distress during assessment, breach of confidentiality and stigmatisation of groups.

Trauma-informed research practices include flexible protocols, trained interviewers, accessible information, referral pathways and the option to pause or withdraw.

Community participation improves relevance and acceptability. Benefit-sharing is important, particularly in low-resource settings.

20.5 Emerging areas

Several areas are developing rapidly. Biomarkers and predictive modelling may eventually support stratification, though current tools are weak. Digital therapeutics may increase access, with questions about safety and equity. Psychedelic-assisted therapy has generated substantial interest, with early trials showing promise for PTSD; larger, blinded trials are needed, and hype should be resisted.

Optogenetics and chemogenetics have transformed animal research and may inform circuit-level treatments, though translation to humans is distant. Closed-loop neuromodulation is being explored for several conditions.

Each emerging area requires the same standards of evidence as established treatments.

20.6 Persistent uncertainties

Several questions remain unresolved. Why do some people develop PTSD after trauma while others do not? Which mechanisms are causal and which are consequences? How do biological, psychological and social factors interact over time? Which treatments work for whom?

These questions are not failures of the field; they are its agenda. Honest acknowledgement of uncertainty is a mark of maturity.

20.7 Professional development

Continuing professional development should include both content and skills: new evidence, critical appraisal, communication, cultural competence and self-care.

Supervision and peer consultation are essential, particularly for clinicians working with complex trauma. Reflective practice helps clinicians notice their own reactions and biases.

Organisations have a responsibility to provide time, resources and support for development.

20.8 Communication and public understanding

Public understanding of trauma is shaped by media, social media and popular psychology. Misinformation spreads quickly, and simplistic claims about brain chemicals or single treatments can mislead.

Researchers and clinicians have a responsibility to communicate accurately, to correct misinformation and to avoid overclaiming. This does not mean avoiding engagement; it means engaging honestly.

20.9 Working with lived experience

People with lived experience of trauma bring expertise that complements clinical and scientific knowledge. Their involvement improves research questions, service design and public communication.

Involvement should be genuine, resourced and reciprocal, not tokenistic. It requires attention to power, consent and support.

20.10 Conclusion

Trauma is a whole-person and whole-society phenomenon. Neurobiology helps us understand how experience becomes biology, how memory and stress systems adapt, and why some people remain symptomatic while others recover.

That knowledge should be used with humility. It does not replace the person's account, the social context or the ethical requirement to provide safe, effective and accessible care. The field's future depends on rigorous science, honest communication and commitment to justice.

20.11 Teaching trauma neurobiology

Teaching this material well requires more than transmitting facts. Students need to understand levels of explanation, the difference between a mechanism and a treatment, and the limits of each method they encounter.

A workable curriculum moves from normal function to disruption to intervention. Students who understand the HPA axis in ordinary circumstances can grasp what changes under chronic stress; students who have never seen a conditioned response will struggle with extinction. Cases and laboratory demonstrations help, provided they are clearly identified as teaching material and do not require students to disclose their own histories.

Assessment should test reasoning rather than recall alone. Questions that ask students to interpret a finding, identify an alternative explanation or design a control are more informative than questions that ask them to name a structure. Where statistics and methodology are taught, they should be applied to real papers from the field.

Clinical and laboratory teaching require boundaries. Students should not be asked to practise assessment on each other's trauma, to disclose personal experiences, or to interpret images or samples beyond their competence. Simulation and standardised cases are safer.

Teachers should model uncertainty. Saying "we do not know" and explaining how the field might find out is more valuable than presenting a tidy account that collapses under scrutiny. Students who learn to tolerate uncertainty are better prepared for practice than those who expect certainty.

20.12 What would change practice

Several developments would materially change clinical practice if they were realised. None is guaranteed, and each should be judged by evidence rather than enthusiasm.

Reliable prediction of who will develop persistent symptoms after trauma would allow targeted early intervention. Current models perform poorly at the individual level, and the ethical risks of false positives—stigma, unnecessary treatment, insurance consequences—are considerable.

Brief, scalable treatments with durable effects would extend reach. Exposure-based and trauma-focused therapies are effective but require trained staff and time. Digital and guided self-help formats may help, but the evidence for unguided tools is weak and dropout is high.

Biologically informed stratification—matching people to treatments based on mechanism—remains speculative. The heterogeneity of PTSD suggests that subtyping may eventually help, but current biomarkers are not ready for clinical use.

Better treatment of sleep, pain, substance use and social adversity would improve outcomes without requiring new neuroscience. These are unglamorous priorities, and they are among the most likely to help.

Finally, equitable access would change more lives than any single discovery. Effective treatments that reach only a minority of those who need them are, in public-health terms, a partial solution.

Synthesis

Table 20.1 summarises the book's levels of analysis.

Table 20.1. Levels of analysis and clinical implications

Level	Focus	Example	Implication
Molecular	Signalling, gene expression	Glucocorticoid feedback	Medication targets
Cellular	Neurons, glia	Synaptic plasticity	Learning mechanisms
Circuit	Networks	Amygdala–prefrontal	Exposure, neuromodulation
Psychological	Appraisal, memory	Avoidance	Therapy
Social	Relationships, resources	Housing, discrimination	Advocacy, policy
Ethical	Rights, justice	Consent, access	Professional standards

Composite case study

A service redesigns its trauma pathway. It combines trauma-focused therapy, sleep intervention, peer support and practical advice on housing and benefits. Staff receive training in trauma-informed practice and supervision. Outcomes are monitored, including access for marginalised groups. The pathway reflects the book's argument that biological, psychological and social levels must be addressed together.

Review and discussion questions

What is explanatory pluralism, and why does it matter clinically?

How can the biopsychosocial model be applied rigorously rather than rhetorically?

What are the ethical risks of trauma research, and how can they be reduced?

How should clinicians respond to patients who request experimental treatments?

Why is lived experience important in research and service design?

What would you prioritise for your own continuing development in this field?

Research assignments

- Write a service specification for a trauma-informed pathway in a general hospital.
- Critically appraise the evidence for psychedelic-assisted therapy for PTSD.
- Develop a public communication strategy to counter misinformation about trauma neurobiology.

Chapter summary

This book has integrated molecular, cellular, circuit, psychological, social and ethical perspectives on trauma. Each level contributes to understanding, and none is sufficient alone. Ethical practice requires consent, competence, safety and justice. Emerging areas offer promise but require rigorous evaluation. Honest communication, lived-experience involvement and continued learning are professional obligations.

References

National Institute of Mental Health. (n.d.). *Post-traumatic stress disorder*. https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/post-traumatic-stress-disorder-ptsd

Glossary

All 187 headwords retain their original scope, with corrected capitalisation and term-specific definitions. Definitions follow usage in the chapters of this volume and standard neuroscience reference works. They are teaching definitions: they are not diagnostic criteria, regulatory definitions or clinical protocols, and they do not replace the sources cited in the chapters and listed in the references.

A

Acetylcholine. A neurotransmitter acting at nicotinic and muscarinic receptors; it mediates neuromuscular transmission and has autonomic and central nervous system functions.

Acquisition. The initial development of a learned response or association during training. In conditioning, acquisition is distinguished from later extinction and retrieval.

ACTH. Adrenocorticotrophic hormone: an anterior pituitary hormone that stimulates glucocorticoid secretion by the adrenal cortex as part of the hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal axis.

Action potential. A brief, regenerative change in membrane potential that propagates an electrical signal along an excitable cell membrane.

Adaptation. An adjustment in physiological function, behaviour or cognition in relation to environmental demands. An adjustment useful during danger may become costly in a safer context.

Adverse effect. An unwanted harmful effect associated with an intervention. Temporal association alone does not establish that the intervention caused it.

Affect dysregulation. Difficulty modulating the intensity, duration or expression of emotional states in ways suited to the situation.

Allele. An alternative version of a DNA sequence at a particular genomic location.

Allostasis. Maintenance of physiological stability through changes in regulatory activity in response to anticipated or actual demands.

Allostatic load. The cumulative physiological burden associated with repeated or poorly regulated adaptive responses; its measurement requires an explicitly specified set of indicators.

Artificial intelligence. Computational systems designed to perform tasks involving capacities such as inference, learning or decision-making. The term does not imply consciousness or clinical competence.

Astrocyte. A central nervous system glial cell that supports neuronal function and contributes to the maintenance of the blood–brain barrier.

Attachment. An enduring emotional bond through which a person seeks proximity, comfort or security from an attachment figure, particularly a caregiver in early life.

Attachment disruption. Interruption or destabilisation of a relationship that ordinarily provides security and emotional support. It is not, by itself, a diagnosis of an attachment disorder.

Avoidance. Attempts to evade distressing internal experiences or external reminders. In PTSD, these may include trauma-related thoughts, feelings, places or activities.

Axon. A neuronal process that carries signals towards other neurons, muscle cells or glands.

B

Bilateral stimulation. Alternating stimulation of the two sides of the body or sensory field, such as back-and-forth eye movements, sounds or taps used within EMDR.

Biomarker. A measured characteristic indicating a biological process, a disease process or a response to an exposure or intervention. Its interpretation depends on the intended context of use.

Blood–brain barrier. A selective physiological interface between the circulation and central nervous system that restricts the passage of substances into brain tissue.

Blood–brain communication. Exchange of signals between the circulation and brain through transport, vascular and other signalling mechanisms. Communication does not require unrestricted passage across the blood–brain barrier.

BOLD signal. Blood-oxygen-level-dependent MRI contrast, influenced by changes in deoxyhaemoglobin and the haemodynamic response. It

is an indirect measure of neural activity, not a recording of individual neurons firing.

Brain–computer interface. A system that uses recorded brain activity to control, communicate with or otherwise interact with an external device.

C

C-reactive protein. A circulating acute-phase protein used as a nonspecific indicator of inflammation. An elevated concentration does not identify a particular psychological cause.

Calibration. In measurement, comparison or adjustment against a reference standard. In probabilistic prediction, agreement between predicted probabilities and observed outcome frequencies.

Causation. A relationship in which changing one factor would change an outcome under specified conditions. An observed association alone is insufficient to establish causation.

Chemokine. A member of a family of signalling proteins that direct cell movement, including the migration of immune cells.

Childhood adversity. Potentially harmful experiences or circumstances during childhood, such as abuse, neglect or serious family disruption. Adversity is broader than any one diagnostic definition of traumatic exposure.

Circadian rhythm. An approximately 24-hour cycle in biological activity, coordinated by internal timing mechanisms and influenced by environmental cues such as light.

Circuit. An interconnected set of neurons or brain regions participating in information processing. A circuit need not correspond to a single psychological function.

Classifier. A computational rule or model that assigns observations to categories, sometimes with estimated probabilities.

Clinical utility. The usefulness of a test or intervention for improving decisions or outcomes in an intended clinical setting, taking account of potential harms and practical consequences.

Co-regulation. Support through another person's responsive interaction that helps an individual modulate emotional or physiological states.

Cognitive change. An alteration in attention, memory, interpretation, reasoning or beliefs. In treatment research, the particular cognitive process and its measurement must be specified.

Comorbidity. The presence of two or more disorders or health conditions in the same person. It does not establish that one condition caused another.

Complex trauma. Repeated or multiple traumatic experiences, often interpersonal, together with their potentially wide-ranging effects. This exposure-related concept is not synonymous with a diagnosis of complex PTSD.

Conditioned stimulus. A stimulus that acquires the capacity to elicit a learned response through its predictive relationship with another event.

Conditioning. Learning through relationships between events, or between actions and their consequences. Classical and operant conditioning describe different arrangements.

Confounding. Distortion of an estimated exposure–outcome relationship by another variable associated with both the exposure and outcome, rather than lying on the causal pathway.

Connectivity. Connections or statistical relationships between neural elements. Structural, functional and effective connectivity refer to anatomical pathways, covariation and modelled directional influence, respectively.

Connectome. A representation of neural connections at a specified spatial scale, from individual cells to larger brain regions.

Consolidation. Processes through which newly acquired information becomes more stable over time. Cellular and systems consolidation concern different levels of explanation.

Construct. A theoretical attribute or process, such as perceived threat, defined for explanation or measurement rather than directly observed as a single physical object.

Correlation. Statistical covariation between variables. Its magnitude and interpretation depend on the measure used; correlation does not, by itself, establish causation.

Corticotropin-releasing hormone. A peptide involved in stress regulation; hypothalamic release stimulates pituitary ACTH secretion. Corticotropin-releasing factor is a commonly used alternative name.

Cortisol. A glucocorticoid hormone produced by the adrenal cortex, involved in metabolic, immune and stress regulation; concentrations vary with circadian timing and other influences.

Cumulative risk. The combined burden of multiple risk exposures or conditions. A count of exposures does not necessarily capture their severity, timing or interaction.

Cytokine. A signalling protein that influences cell activity, particularly immune and inflammatory responses. Different cytokines have different, context-dependent functions.

D

Dendrite. A neuronal process that commonly receives synaptic input from other cells.

Depersonalisation. An experience of detachment from one's body, mental processes or sense of self.

Depression. A term used for depressed mood and for depressive disorders. A disorder requires a defined pattern of symptoms and clinical assessment, not sadness alone.

Derealisation. An experience in which the surrounding world feels unreal, distant, dreamlike or distorted.

Developmental cascade. A sequence in which change in one area of development influences other areas over time; the direction and mechanisms require empirical investigation.

Developmental timing. The age or developmental stage at which an experience or biological process occurs, considered in relation to its possible effects.

Diagnostic marker. A biomarker used to detect or confirm a condition, or identify a subtype. An association with a disorder does not by itself establish diagnostic performance.

Differential diagnosis. The clinical process of distinguishing between conditions that could explain a person's presentation, including medical, substance-related and psychological alternatives.

Diffusion imaging. MRI methods sensitive to the movement of water molecules in tissue. Diffusion measures can inform models of tissue organisation but do not directly count axons.

Digital phenotype. A measurable pattern of behaviour or functioning derived from digital devices, such as movement or interaction data. Its meaning requires validation and attention to privacy.

Discrimination. In learning, responding differently to distinguishable stimuli. In prediction, a model's ability to distinguish outcome groups. In social contexts, unequal or unfair treatment.

Dissociation. Disruption in the usual integration of awareness, memory, identity or perception. Depersonalisation and derealisation are particular dissociative experiences.

DNA methylation. Addition of methyl groups to DNA, an epigenetic modification that can influence gene regulation without changing the underlying DNA sequence.

Dopamine. A monoamine neurotransmitter involved in functions including movement, learning, motivation and reward processing. It is not a simple measure of pleasure.

E

EEG. Electroencephalography: recording of electrical potential differences, usually at the scalp, reflecting the combined activity of neuronal populations.

Effect size. A quantitative measure of the magnitude of a difference, association or other effect. It should be interpreted with its uncertainty and the study's design.

Emotion regulation. Processes that influence which emotions arise, their intensity or duration, and how they are experienced or expressed.

Encoding. Processes through which information is initially represented in a form that can contribute to subsequent memory.

Endocannabinoid. A lipid-derived signalling molecule produced within the body that acts at cannabinoid receptors; examples include anandamide and 2-arachidonoylglycerol.

Endophenotype. A measurable, partly heritable characteristic investigated as an intermediate link between genetic variation and a

disorder. A proposed endophenotype requires evidence, not merely an association.

Epigenetics. Study of modifications to DNA and associated proteins that influence gene activity without altering the underlying DNA sequence. Not every modification is transmitted between generations.

Executive control. Processes that support goal-directed behaviour, including maintaining goals, inhibiting competing responses and adjusting actions.

Explainability. The extent to which the basis or operation of a computational prediction can be described intelligibly. An explanation does not establish that a prediction is accurate or causal.

Extinction. A reduction in a learned response when the previously predictive relationship or reinforcement no longer occurs. It need not erase the original learning.

Extinction learning. Learning associated with extinction, such as learning that a previously threatening cue no longer predicts harm in a particular context.

F

Feature. An input variable or representation supplied to a computational model, such as a symptom score or an imaging-derived measurement.

Flexibility. The capacity to adjust behaviour, attention or regulatory strategies when goals or circumstances change. The relevant domain must be specified.

fMRI. Functional magnetic resonance imaging: MRI methods used to study brain function, commonly through BOLD contrast rather than direct measurement of neuronal firing.

Functional impairment. Interference with activities or roles such as work, education, relationships or self-care. It is distinct from the mere presence of a symptom.

G

GABA. Gamma-aminobutyric acid: a major inhibitory neurotransmitter in the mature central nervous system. Its effects depend on receptor and cellular conditions.

Gene. A DNA sequence that contributes to a functional product, such as an RNA molecule or a protein. Gene activity is regulated rather than fixed at a constant level.

Gene–environment interplay. The joint contribution of genetic variation and environmental conditions to development or outcomes. The term can include interaction and gene–environment correlation.

Generalisation. Extension of a learned response to new stimuli or contexts. In machine learning, performance on observations not used to fit the model.

Genotype. The genetic variants present at a specified genomic location or set of locations; the term may also refer more broadly to genetic constitution.

Glutamate. An amino acid that serves as the principal excitatory neurotransmitter in the central nervous system and participates in synaptic plasticity.

Grey matter. Nervous tissue containing neuronal cell bodies, dendrites, synapses and glia, with fewer myelinated axons than white matter.

H

Heritability. A population-specific estimate of the proportion of variation in a trait attributable to genetic differences under specified conditions. It is not an individual's percentage of genetic determination.

Heterogeneity. Variation within a population or body of evidence. Clinical, biological and methodological heterogeneity are different forms and should not be conflated.

Histone. A DNA-associated protein involved in chromatin organisation; histone modifications can influence the accessibility and regulation of genetic information.

Homeostasis. Regulation of internal physiological conditions within ranges compatible with functioning, through interacting feedback and control processes.

Hyperarousal. Heightened arousal or reactivity, such as exaggerated startle, vigilance or sleep disturbance. It is not specific to PTSD.

I

Immune regulation. Processes that initiate, coordinate, limit or resolve immune responses. Regulation is not equivalent to increasing immune activity.

Immunity. The body's capacity to recognise and respond to harmful agents through innate and adaptive defence mechanisms.

Implementation. The deliberate introduction and sustained use of an intervention or practice in a real-world setting, including attention to feasibility and context.

Inflammation. A coordinated tissue and immune response to injury or harmful stimuli. Acute and persistent inflammation differ in duration and potential consequences.

Insula. A region of cerebral cortex within the lateral sulcus, involved in functions including interoceptive, sensory and affective processing.

Interleukin. A cytokine designated within the interleukin family. Interleukins influence immune and other cellular activities and do not all have the same inflammatory effects.

Interoception. Sensing and processing signals from within the body, including signals related to visceral and physiological states.

Intrusion. An involuntary entry of distressing memories, images or related experiences into awareness; trauma-related intrusions can include nightmares and flashbacks.

Ion channel. A membrane protein forming a pathway through which selected ions can move. Channel opening and selectivity shape cellular electrical signalling.

M

Machine learning. Computational methods that fit patterns or decision rules from data, rather than requiring every rule to be explicitly specified in advance.

Maturation. Developmental change through which biological or psychological systems acquire more developed organisation or capacities; it occurs in interaction with experience.

Mechanism. A process or organised set of processes proposed to explain how an effect occurs. A correlation or group difference is not, by itself, a mechanism.

Mediator. A variable proposed to transmit part of the effect of an exposure or intervention on an outcome. Statistical mediation alone does not establish a causal mechanism.

MEG. Magnetoencephalography: recording of very small magnetic fields generated by electrical activity in neuronal populations.

Membrane potential. The electrical potential difference across a cell membrane, arising from ionic distributions and membrane properties.

Memory system. A set of processes and neural substrates supporting a form of memory, such as episodic or procedural memory. The classification depends on the theoretical framework.

Meta-analysis. A statistical synthesis of results from multiple studies addressing a defined question. Its conclusions depend on study quality, comparability and the synthesis model.

Metacognition. Monitoring and regulation of one's own cognitive processes, including judgements about memory or confidence in a decision.

Microglia. Resident immune cells of the central nervous system, involved in surveillance and responses to tissue disturbance.

Migration. Movement of cells from one location to another. In neurodevelopment, neuronal migration contributes to the arrangement of cells in developing tissue.

Mitochondrion. A cellular organelle involved in energy metabolism and other functions, including calcium handling and regulation of cell survival.

Moderator. A variable associated with differences in the magnitude or direction of a relationship across its levels. Moderation describes a conditional relationship, not necessarily its mechanism.

MRI. Magnetic resonance imaging: production of images from magnetic resonance signals, using magnetic fields and radiofrequency pulses. Different sequences provide different tissue contrasts.

Myelin. A lipid-rich sheath around many axons that supports rapid electrical conduction; it is produced by oligodendrocytes in the CNS and Schwann cells in the peripheral nervous system.

Myelination. Formation and development of myelin sheaths around axons.

N

Negative cognition. A negatively valenced thought, interpretation or belief, such as an expectation of danger or self-blame. The term requires a specified context and measure.

Negative self-concept. A pattern of unfavourable beliefs or feelings about oneself, such as worthlessness, shame or perceived failure.

Neuroanatomy. Study of the structure and organisation of the nervous system.

Neurodevelopment. Development of the nervous system through interacting cellular, circuit-level and experiential processes across the lifespan.

Neurogenesis. Production of new neurons from precursor cells. Its extent and functional significance depend on species, brain region and developmental stage.

Neuroimaging artefact. An image feature or signal distortion arising from acquisition, movement, physiology or processing rather than the phenomenon being interpreted.

Neuromodulation. Alteration of neuronal or circuit activity by chemical signalling or an intervention such as electrical or magnetic stimulation; the intended meaning depends on context.

Neuron. A nervous system cell specialised for receiving, integrating and transmitting signals to other cells.

Neuropeptide. A peptide used in neural signalling that can influence the activity of neurons and other target cells.

Neuroscience. The scientific study of the nervous system and its relationships with behaviour, cognition, emotion, bodily regulation, development and disease.

Neurotransmission. Communication in which a neuron influences a target cell through chemical transmitter release or direct electrical coupling.

Noradrenaline. A catecholamine, also called norepinephrine, acting as a neurotransmitter and hormone in arousal, autonomic and stress-related regulation.

Nucleus. In neuroanatomy, a localised group of neuronal cell bodies in the central nervous system. In cell biology, the membrane-bound compartment containing most cellular DNA.

O

Oligodendrocyte. A central nervous system glial cell that forms myelin around axons.

Operational definition. The explicit procedures used to identify, manipulate or measure a construct in a particular study.

Opioid. A substance acting at opioid receptors, including endogenous peptides and medicines. Effects depend on the substance, receptor and dose.

Overfitting. Fitting patterns specific to training data so closely that performance is poor on new data from the intended application.

Oxidative stress. A disturbance in the balance between oxidant production and antioxidant regulation that can disrupt signalling or damage cellular components.

P

Parasympathetic system. A division of the autonomic nervous system involved in functions such as cardiac slowing and digestive regulation. Its activity is not a direct measure of psychological safety.

PET. Positron emission tomography: imaging of the distribution of a positron-emitting tracer to investigate processes such as metabolism or receptor binding.

Pharmacotherapy. Treatment using medicines, selected and monitored according to the condition, evidence, potential harms and individual circumstances.

Phenotype. An observable or measurable characteristic arising through genetic and environmental influences, including biological or behavioural traits.

Plasticity. The capacity of neural structure or function to change through development, experience, learning, injury or intervention. Change is not necessarily beneficial.

Polygenic score. A numerical summary combining information across multiple genetic variants, usually weighted by estimated associations with a trait. It is not a deterministic prediction.

Potentiation. An increase in the strength or effectiveness of a response. Synaptic potentiation refers specifically to increased synaptic efficacy.

Precision neuroscience. An approach seeking to characterise individual differences in nervous system function or organisation with sufficiently detailed and reliable measurements. It does not imply established individualised clinical prediction.

Prediction error. A discrepancy between an expected and an observed event or outcome, which can contribute to updating learned expectations.

Predictive marker. A biomarker used to identify the likelihood of a response to an exposure or intervention. It is distinct from a marker of the likely course of a condition without that intervention.

Prognostic marker. A biomarker used to estimate the likelihood of a future clinical event or disease course in people with a condition.

Protective factor. A characteristic or condition associated with a reduced likelihood or impact of an adverse outcome in a specified context. It does not guarantee protection.

Protective relationship. A relationship that provides safety, reliable support or other resources that may reduce the impact of adversity.

Protein kinase. An enzyme that transfers a phosphate group to a protein, thereby potentially altering its activity, interactions or location.

Pruning. Selective reduction or removal of neural connections or processes during development or plasticity. It is not interchangeable with indiscriminate neuronal loss.

Psychoneuroimmunology. Study of interactions among psychological processes, the nervous system and immune function.

Psychotherapy. A structured psychological treatment delivered through a therapeutic relationship to address distress, symptoms or functioning.

PTSD. Post-traumatic stress disorder: a disorder that can follow traumatic exposure, with symptoms involving intrusion, avoidance, changes in cognition or mood, and arousal or reactivity. Diagnosis requires the applicable clinical criteria, not a biomarker alone.

R

Reappraisal. Changing the interpretation of a situation in order to influence its emotional significance or effects.

Receptor. A molecular structure that recognises a signal, such as a neurotransmitter or hormone, and initiates or modifies a cellular response.

Reconsolidation. Processes through which a retrieved memory may become labile and subsequently restabilise. Retrieval does not invariably trigger reconsolidation or permit reliable memory erasure.

Recovery. Improvement or restoration of symptoms, functioning or well-being after adversity or illness. The relevant outcomes and time frame must be specified.

Recovery trajectory. A pattern of change in recovery-related outcomes over time, which can include improvement, fluctuation or persistent difficulties.

Relational disturbance. Difficulty forming, maintaining or feeling secure in relationships. This is a descriptive term, not an independent diagnosis.

Reliability. The consistency or precision of measurements under specified conditions. A reliable measure can still fail to measure the intended construct accurately.

Renewal. Return of an extinguished conditioned response when the cue is encountered in a context different from the extinction context.

Resilience. Dynamic maintenance or recovery of meaningful function despite adversity, supported by interacting personal, relational, biological and social conditions.

Retrieval. Access to or use of previously encoded information. Successful retrieval depends on cues, context and the state of the memory system.

S

Salience. The prominence or relevance of information for attention or behaviour, arising from its features, learned meaning or current goals.

Sampling. The selection of observations, people or other units from a target population or data source. The sampling procedure affects the scope of inference.

Second messenger. An intracellular signalling molecule generated or released in response to receptor activation that conveys or amplifies a signal within the cell.

Self-regulation. Processes through which a person modulates attention, emotion, behaviour or physiological arousal in relation to goals and circumstances.

Sensitive period. A developmental interval during which particular experiences have comparatively strong effects on a system. It does not imply that subsequent change is impossible.

Sensitivity. For a diagnostic test at a specified threshold, the proportion of people with the target condition who test positive. The relevant meaning differs in sensitivity analyses.

Serotonin. A monoamine neurotransmitter, also called 5-hydroxytryptamine, involved in multiple functions including mood, sleep and bodily regulation. Its role is not reducible to a simple happiness chemical.

Social buffering. Reduction of stress responses or their effects in the presence of supportive social relationships or interactions. Its occurrence depends on the context and relationship.

Source localisation. Estimation of the locations of neural generators from recorded signals, commonly EEG or MEG, using assumptions and an explicit source model.

Specificity. For a diagnostic test at a specified threshold, the proportion of people without the target condition who test negative.

State dependence. Variation in a process or response according to the individual's current state. In memory, retrieval may differ with the match between encoding and retrieval states.

Stressor. An event, condition or demand that challenges or threatens an organism's regulatory resources. Responses depend on characteristics of the event and the individual.

Suppression. An attempt to inhibit an expression, thought or response. Expressive suppression and attempts to suppress thoughts or memories are distinct processes.

Sympathetic system. A division of the autonomic nervous system involved in functions including cardiovascular and metabolic responses to demands. It is active in ordinary regulation as well as emergencies.

Synapse. A specialised junction through which a neuron communicates with another cell by chemical or electrical signalling.

Synaptogenesis. Formation of synaptic connections between neurons or between neurons and other target cells.

T

Test set. Data reserved for evaluating a fitted model after model selection, rather than for fitting or tuning it. Repeated use for decisions can compromise the independence of the evaluation.

Tract. A bundle of axons within the central nervous system, connecting neural regions.

Training set. Data used to fit a computational model's parameters or decision rules, distinct from data reserved for independent evaluation.

Transcription. In molecular biology, synthesis of an RNA molecule using DNA as a template. In qualitative research, production of a written record from speech or other recorded material.

Translation. In molecular biology, synthesis of a polypeptide according to an RNA sequence. In translational research, movement between research findings and practical applications; these are different meanings.

Traumatic stress. Psychological and biological responses following traumatic exposure. Such responses do not necessarily constitute

PTSD; diagnostic definitions of exposure and disorder must be distinguished.

Treatment mechanism. A process through which a treatment produces change. Establishing a mechanism requires more than observing improvement or a pre–post biological difference.

U

Unconditioned stimulus. A stimulus that elicits a response without the specific prior conditioning under investigation.

V

Vagus nerve. The tenth cranial nerve, carrying sensory and motor fibres involved in communication between the brainstem and several thoracic and abdominal organs.

Validation. Evaluation of evidence for a measure's intended interpretation or a model's performance in a specified context. Internal model tuning and independent external validation are not interchangeable.

Validity. The extent to which evidence supports the intended interpretation and use of a measurement or inference. It is specific to the purpose and context, not an unrestricted property of a test.

W

White matter. Nervous tissue consisting predominantly of axonal pathways, many of them myelinated, together with glia and other supporting structures.

Note on sources and method

Each definition was written for this edition and checked against the usage of the corresponding concept in the chapters. Where a term has more than one established meaning, the sense used in this volume is the one given. The editorial register accompanying this glossary records the original source page, the original definition, the replacement and the verification status of every entry.

Back matter

Acronyms and abbreviations

Abbreviation	Expansion
ACC	anterior cingulate cortex
ACTH	adrenocorticotropic hormone
AI	artificial intelligence
AMPA	α-amino-3-hydroxy-5-methyl-4-isoxazolepropionic acid
ANS	autonomic nervous system
ATP	adenosine triphosphate
BBB	blood–brain barrier
BOLD	blood-oxygen-level-dependent
CBT	cognitive behavioural therapy
CBT-I	cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia
CB1	cannabinoid receptor type 1
CRH	corticotropin-releasing hormone
CSF	cerebrospinal fluid
CT	computed tomography
DSM-5	Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, Fifth Edition
EEG	electroencephalography
FDA	U.S. Food and Drug Administration
fMRI	functional magnetic resonance imaging
GABA	gamma-aminobutyric acid
GR	glucocorticoid receptor
GWAS	genome-wide association study
HPA	hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal
HRV	heart rate variability
ICD-11	International Classification of Diseases, 11th Revision
IL-6	interleukin-6
LTD	long-term depression
LTP	long-term potentiation

Abbreviation	Expansion
MRI	magnetic resonance imaging
NCTSN	National Child Traumatic Stress Network
NIMH	National Institute of Mental Health
NMDA	N-methyl-D-aspartate
NPY	neuropeptide Y
PET	positron emission tomography
PFC	prefrontal cortex
PTSD	post-traumatic stress disorder
PVN	paraventricular nucleus
REM	rapid eye movement
rTMS	repetitive transcranial magnetic stimulation
SCN	suprachiasmatic nucleus
SNP	single nucleotide polymorphism
SSRI	selective serotonin reuptake inhibitor
TNF	tumour necrosis factor
VTA	ventral tegmental area
WHO	World Health Organization

Appendix A. Critical appraisal template

Use this template for a single study. Record the source, then answer each prompt in a short paragraph. A completed template is a record of reasoning, not a score.

Section	Prompts to answer
Citation and access	Full reference; did you read the full text, an abstract, or a summary?
Question	What question does the study ask? Is it a question about prevalence, mechanism, efficacy, experience or implementation?
Design	What design was used? Is it capable of answering the question?
Sample	Who was studied, how were they selected, and who was excluded?
Measures	What constructs were measured, with which instruments, and what are their reliability and validity?
Comparison	What is the comparison group or condition, and is it appropriate?
Analysis	Are the analyses prespecified and appropriate? Is multiple testing handled?
Effect and precision	What is the effect size, with what confidence interval? Is it clinically meaningful?
Bias	What selection, measurement, attrition and reporting biases are plausible?
Confounding	Which alternative explanations remain?
Applicability	To whom, in what setting, does this result plausibly apply?
Conclusion	What does the study support, what does it not support, and what would reduce uncertainty?

Appendix B. Trauma-informed assessment checklist

This checklist supports teaching and supervision. It is not a validated instrument and does not replace local protocols.

Domain	Checks
Safety and setting	Private space; interpreter if needed; no immediate danger; exit route; planned ending time
Consent and confidentiality	Purpose of questions; limits of confidentiality; storage of records; right to decline
History	What happened; when; for how long; who was involved; childhood and adult adversity; current stressors
Symptoms	Intrusion; avoidance; negative cognition and mood; arousal; dissociation; sleep; substance use
Risk	Suicide; self-harm; harm to others; safeguarding; access to means; protective factors
Health	Relevant medical conditions; medication; pain; sleep disorder; pregnancy; neurological red flags
Culture and language	Idioms of distress; explanatory models; language of assessment; role of family
Strengths	Supports; coping; values; previous helpful treatment
Formulation	Integrated explanation shared with the person and open to revision
Plan	Immediate safety; treatment; referral; review date; what to do in a crisis

Appendix C. Research protocol outline

A protocol for an educational project should be reviewed by the relevant ethics committee before data collection. This outline indicates the sections such a document normally contains; it is not itself an approved protocol.

Section	Content
Title and version	Short title; version number; date; responsible investigator
Background	What is known; what is uncertain; why this question matters
Question and objectives	Primary question; secondary questions; hypotheses, if any
Design	Design and its justification; comparators; duration
Participants	Inclusion and exclusion criteria; recruitment; consent procedure; withdrawal
Measures	Constructs; instruments; reliability and validity; translation
Procedure	What participants do; time burden; setting; adaptations
Analysis	Primary analysis; missing data; sensitivity analyses; power or information power
Ethics	Risks; benefits; safeguards; confidentiality; data protection; incidental findings
Data management	Storage; access; retention; sharing; destruction
Dissemination	Community feedback; publication; authorship; data availability
Timeline and resources	Milestones; staff; costs; contingencies

Appendix D. Statistical and methodological terms

Bias. A systematic error that distorts an estimate. Bias differs from random error, which is reduced by larger samples.

Confidence interval. A range of values consistent with the observed data at a stated level of confidence. It conveys precision and is more informative than a significance test alone.

Confounding. A third variable associated with both exposure and outcome that distorts their apparent relationship.

Effect size. The magnitude of a difference or association, expressed in standardised or natural units.

Heterogeneity. Variation in effect estimates across studies or subgroups beyond what sampling error would predict.

Intention-to-treat. Analysis of participants according to the group to which they were allocated, regardless of the treatment received.

Power. The probability of detecting an effect of a given size if it exists. Underpowered studies produce unstable estimates.

Preregistration. Public registration of hypotheses, outcomes and analyses before data collection or analysis.

Sensitivity analysis. Reanalysis under different assumptions to test whether conclusions are robust.

Research resources

The following organisations publish material that is useful for teaching and for orientation to services. Resources change; verify the current page, date and jurisdiction before relying on any item. Listing does not imply endorsement.

Resource	Purpose
National Institute of Mental Health (nimh.nih.gov)	Public and professional information on PTSD and related conditions
National Child Traumatic Stress Network (nctsn.org)	Resources on child trauma, complex trauma and service models
World Health Organization (who.int)	International classifications, guidance and global mental health material
PubMed (pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov)	Bibliographic database for biomedical and psychological literature
Cochrane Library (cochranelibrary.com)	Systematic reviews of health interventions
National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (nice.org.uk)	Clinical guidance and evidence reviews for England and Wales
American Psychological Association (apa.org)	Ethics guidance, publication standards and professional resources

Laboratory and classroom teaching protocols

These protocols describe teaching activities only. They do not authorise clinical investigation, and they do not produce diagnostic information. Each requires institutional approval, supervision by a qualified teacher, informed consent from participants, and a risk assessment. Where a protocol involves biological samples, local biosafety, storage and disposal rules apply, and the assay manufacturer's instructions govern the procedure.

Protocol 1. Salivary cortisol sampling (educational)

Aim. To demonstrate diurnal variation and the practical constraints of endocrine measurement.

Materials. Salivary collection devices approved for human use; labels; timed reminders; cold storage; assay arranged through an approved laboratory.

Procedure. Students review the sampling schedule specified by the assay and the study question; record sleep, food, caffeine, nicotine, medication and exercise; collect samples at the approved times; store and transport them according to the laboratory's instructions.

Analysis. Plot individual values against time. Discuss why a single sample cannot characterise a person's stress physiology.

Limits. Values depend on time of day, posture, recent activity, oral health and assay method. Results are not interpreted clinically.

Protocol 2. Heart rate variability demonstration

Aim. To show how autonomic regulation can be indexed indirectly.

Materials. A validated recording device; electrodes or photoplethysmography sensor; analysis software with documented artefact handling.

Procedure. Record resting and paced-breathing conditions; inspect the trace for artefacts; compute time-domain and frequency-domain measures with the software's stated settings.

Analysis. Compare conditions within participants and discuss the influence of posture, breathing rate, fitness and medication.

Limits. Consumer devices vary in validity; short recordings are unstable; group averages do not describe individuals.

Protocol 3. Conditioning and extinction demonstration

Aim. To illustrate acquisition, extinction and renewal using mild stimuli only.

Materials. Computer task with neutral images and brief, non-painful sounds; structured instructions; debriefing.

Procedure. Participants learn that one image predicts a sound; the sound is then omitted; the image is presented in a new context. Subjective expectancy ratings and simple reaction times are recorded.

Analysis. Plot expectancy across phases and discuss renewal.

Limits. Mild laboratory conditioning differs from traumatic learning. No aversive stimulation is used, and participation is voluntary and withdrawable.

Protocol 4. Neuroanatomy practical

Aim. To identify the structures discussed in Chapters 2–4.

Materials. Anatomical models, plastinated sections or approved digital atlases.

Procedure. Students locate the hippocampus, amygdala, insula, anterior cingulate, hypothalamus, brainstem nuclei and ventricular system; they trace the course of the HPA axis and the main noradrenergic projection.

Analysis. Short structured identification exercise with a marking guide.

Limits. Models simplify anatomy; imaging appearances differ from specimens.

Professional standards and scope of practice

This textbook supports doctoral study of trauma neurobiology. It does not confer clinical competence, prescribing authority, imaging privileges, laboratory certification or legal authority to assess trauma in forensic settings.

Students and practitioners should work within their competence and their jurisdiction's law; seek supervision when a case exceeds that competence; obtain informed consent and explain the limits of confidentiality; protect identifiable data; recognise and declare conflicts of interest; and refer for medical assessment when symptoms, history or examination suggest a condition requiring it.

Research with trauma-affected people requires ethical review, valid consent, attention to power and dependency, referral pathways for distress, and arrangements for sharing findings with participants and communities. Authorship should reflect substantive contribution. Findings should be reported honestly, including those that are negative or inconvenient.

Where this book and local law, professional regulation or institutional policy differ, the latter takes precedence.

Further reading

The following works are cited in the chapters and are useful starting points. Annotations indicate scope, not endorsement.

- **Shonkoff and Garner (2012)** — the American Academy of Pediatrics technical report on childhood adversity and toxic stress; a concise framing of developmental and policy implications.
- **Teicher and Samson (2016)** — a review of the neurobiological correlates of childhood maltreatment, with attention to sensitive periods and methodological limits.
- **McEwen (1998)** — the classic account of allostasis and allostatic load, still the clearest short statement of the framework.
- **Ulrich-Lai and Herman (2009)** — neural regulation of endocrine and autonomic stress responses.
- **Herman et al. (2016)** — detailed physiology of the HPA axis, including feedback and circadian control.
- **LeDoux (2000)** and **Maren (2001)** — complementary accounts of fear circuitry and Pavlovian conditioning.
- **Milad and Quirk (2012)** — extinction as a translational model, with a clear account of relapse phenomena.
- **Nader et al. (2000)** — the reconsolidation experiment that reframed memory stability.
- **Vervliet et al. (2013)** — a critical review of extinction and relapse; useful for judging clinical claims.
- **Craske et al. (2014)** — inhibitory learning and the practical optimisation of exposure.
- **Ehlers and Clark (2000)** — the cognitive model that organises much trauma-focused therapy.
- **Lanius et al. (2010)** — the dissociative subtype and its neurobiological basis.
- **Etkin and Wager (2007)** — meta-analytic imaging findings across anxiety disorders.
- **Germain (2013)** — sleep disturbance as a central feature of PTSD.
- **Hori and Kim (2019)** — inflammation in PTSD, with appropriate caution about causality.
- **Yehuda et al. (2015)** — an authoritative overview of PTSD, from epidemiology to treatment.
- **Felitti et al. (1998)** — the original adverse childhood experiences study.

- **Kessler et al. (1995)** — the National Comorbidity Survey estimates of trauma exposure and PTSD.
- **Page et al. (2021)** — the PRISMA 2020 reporting standard for systematic reviews.

Worksheet W1. Sample educational structural MRI report

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Clinical question

State the clinical question.

Technique

Scanner, sequences, image quality, and limitations.

Findings

Describe anatomy using standard radiological language.

Incidental findings

Record only findings supplied in the approved exercise.

Impression

Provide a concise clinical interpretation.

A structural MRI does not establish that trauma caused an anatomical feature or diagnose PTSD by itself. This teaching template requires adaptation by a qualified radiologist and local service.

Worksheet W2. Sample educational fMRI research report

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Research question

State the research question.

Participants and task

Describe the supplied sample and task.

Acquisition and preprocessing

Specify the approved procedures.

Primary contrast and regions

Identify the prespecified contrast and regions.

Multiple-comparison control

State the supplied or proposed method.

Results

Report only supplied effect estimates and uncertainty.

Sensitivity analyses

Describe the supplied or proposed analyses.

Interpretation

State group-level meaning, alternatives, and limits.

Functional activation depends on task and analysis. It cannot provide a personal diagnosis or confirm a trauma history. Do not invent research findings to complete this worksheet.

Worksheet W3. Research question builder

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Purpose

Population and setting

Constructs and definitions

Procedures

Quality controls

Ethics and data protection

Analysis or synthesis

Interpretation limits

Responsible person and review date

Complete for an authorised educational task. These fields retain the source template structure; they are not a complete or approved study protocol.

Worksheet W4. Variable and measurement matrix

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Purpose

Population and setting

Constructs and definitions

Procedures

Quality controls

Ethics and data protection

Analysis or synthesis

Interpretation limits

Responsible person and review date

Complete for an authorised educational task. These fields retain the source template structure; they are not a complete or approved study protocol.

Worksheet W5. Data-management plan

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Purpose

Population and setting

Constructs and definitions

Procedures

Quality controls

Ethics and data protection

Analysis or synthesis

Interpretation limits

Responsible person and review date

Complete for an authorised educational task. These fields retain the source template structure; they are not a complete or approved study protocol.

Worksheet W6. Statistical analysis plan

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Purpose

Population and setting

Constructs and definitions

Procedures

Quality controls

Ethics and data protection

Analysis or synthesis

Interpretation limits

Responsible person and review date

Complete for an authorised educational task. These fields retain the source template structure; they are not a complete or approved study protocol.

Worksheet W7. Qualitative interview guide

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Purpose

Population and setting

Constructs and definitions

Procedures

Quality controls

Ethics and data protection

Analysis or synthesis

Interpretation limits

Responsible person and review date

Complete for an authorised educational task. These fields retain the source template structure; they are not a complete or approved study protocol.

Worksheet W8. Mixed-methods integration matrix

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Purpose

Population and setting

Constructs and definitions

Procedures

Quality controls

Ethics and data protection

Analysis or synthesis

Interpretation limits

Responsible person and review date

Complete for an authorised educational task. These fields retain the source template structure; they are not a complete or approved study protocol.

Worksheet W9. Dissemination and community feedback plan

Learner-completion worksheet. Blank response spaces are intentional. Use only approved or explicitly hypothetical exercise information; do not enter identifiable patient data.

Purpose

Population and setting

Constructs and definitions

Procedures

Quality controls

Ethics and data protection

Analysis or synthesis

Interpretation limits

Responsible person and review date

Complete for an authorised educational task. These fields retain the source template structure; they are not a complete or approved study protocol.

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TRT 903 · DOCTORAL TEXTBOOK

Advanced Neurobiology of Trauma

How threat, adversity and recovery are written into the nervous system

Why do some experiences leave lasting marks on the brain and body while others do not? This doctoral-level textbook follows trauma through every level of the nervous system — from molecules, synapses and genes to circuits, stress physiology, memory, sleep and social context — and asks at each step what the evidence actually shows, what it merely suggests, and what it cannot support.

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- HPA-axis stress physiology, allostasis, genetics and epigenetics
- Threat learning, traumatic memory, emotion regulation and dissociation
- Neuroimmunology, neuroimaging methods and their limits
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For doctoral students, clinicians, researchers and educators working at the interface of neuroscience and traumatic stress.

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